



EXPRESSinvestigation

His govt mapped Ujjain’s infra push, Madhya Pradesh CM Mohan Yadav, family bought land in prime areas

SINCE HE BECAME MINISTER IN 2021, FAMILY PURCHASES ADD UP TO **253 ACRES**

Jay Mazoomdaar
Ujjain, New Delhi, June 22

THE CITY of Ujjain is at the centre of a massive urban renewal, driven by a sweeping infrastructure upgrade — from new roads and highways to changes in land use that will allow an unprecedented expansion of residential and commercial spaces.

All this has made Ujjain one of India’s hottest property markets. Among the early investors are Chief Minister Mohan Yadav, his immediate family, siblings and first cousins.

Since he took oath as the Chief Minister of the BJP-led government in Madhya Pradesh on December 13, 2023, Mohan Yadav’s family and their real estate companies have bought at least 137 plots, adding up to 168 acres, for Rs 45 crore, in zones most benefited by this infrastructure push, an investigation of land records by *The Indian Express* has found. Records also show that at least six of these plots were sold subsequently. This does not include the family’s land transactions in 2026, if any, as official land records are not updated immediately.

According to *khatauni* (ownership) records, these plots were purchased by Mohan Ya-

dav’s wife Seema, son Vaibhav’s wife Shalini Yadav, brothers Nandlal and Narayan Yadav, Narayan’s wife Rekha, their son Abhay Yadav, and first cousins Govind and Nilesh Yadav — either directly or through one of four real estate companies run by the family.

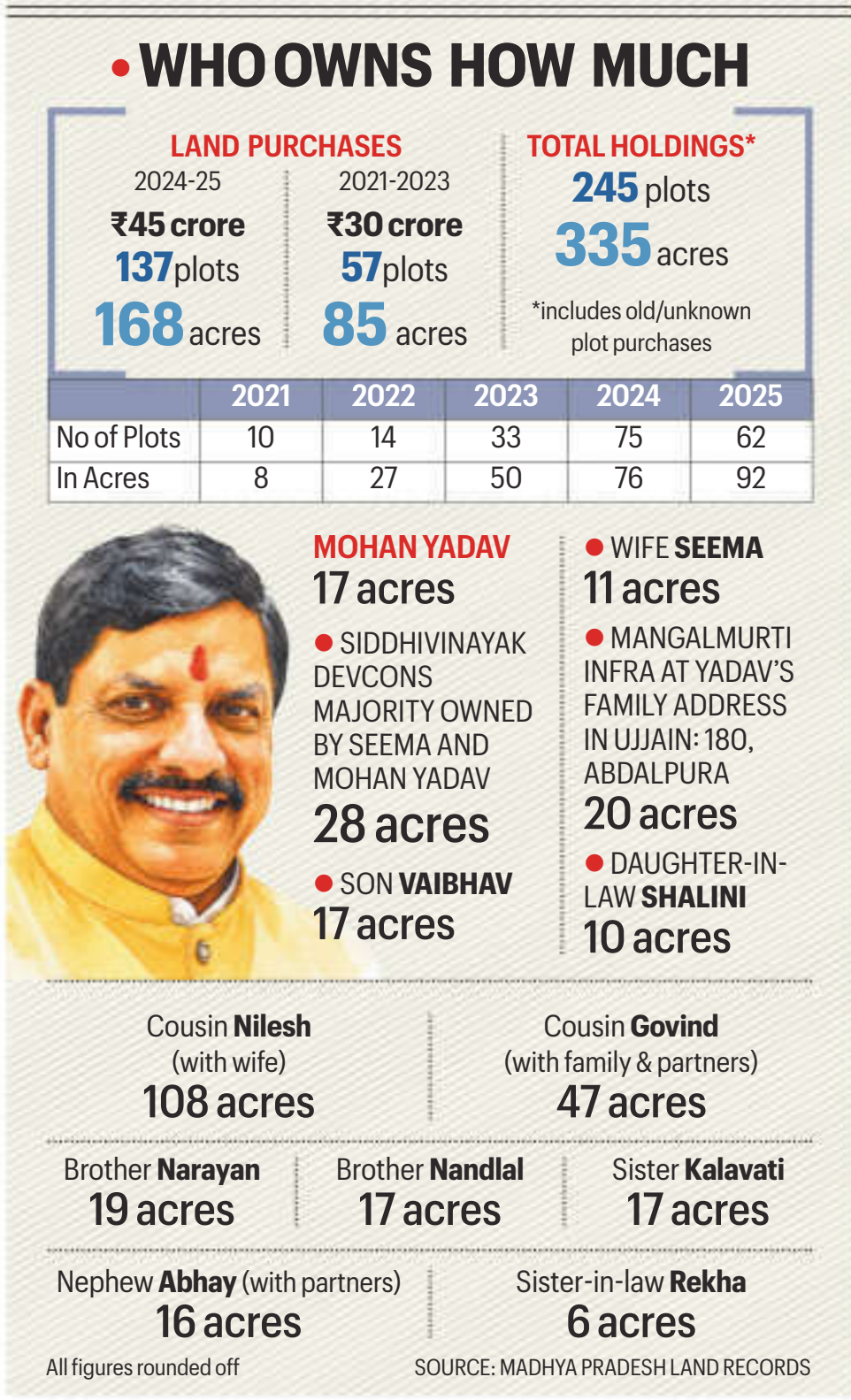
These purchases highlight two key issues that raise questions of propriety and conflict of interest.

One, most of these plots are either close to new road projects announced in and around Ujjain, or in areas demarcated for change of land use from agriculture to residential or commercial in the Ujjain Master Plan 2035.

While the Ujjain Master Plan 2035 was released in May 2023, months before Yadav became the chief minister, he has been involved in the holy city’s tourism and infrastructure development for decades — as the chairperson of the Ujjain Development Authority during 2004-2010, as head of MP Tourism Development Corporation (MPTDC) during 2011-13, and as MLA from Ujjain (south) since 2013.

Since January 2024, soon after Mohan Yadav took charge as chief minister, the state

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 6



Don’t link CM to extended family; they have long been in realty: State officials

Express News Service
Bhopal, New Delhi, June 22

NEITHER CHIEF Minister Mohan Yadav nor his office commented on a detailed questionnaire sent by *The Indian Express* on its findings. However, state government officials, on the condition that they not be named, said it was “not correct” to link purchases by the CM’s family and his presence in the government.

“The CM’s extended family has been in the real estate business for a while,” said an official. “To link their businesses with the CM’s rise in politics will not be proper.”

He added that it was also “not correct” to go beyond the Chief Minister’s immediate family in talking about his assets: “When you talk about his family, it should include only his wife, son and daughter-in-law... and there you may not find anything major.”

According to another senior official, the land transactions were not always purchases of plots, and there were cases of some of them being sold subsequently. “All plots purchased are not held forever. These are also sold as part of the business,” the official said.

Responding on behalf of Mohan Yadav’s cousins Govind and Nilesh, Govind Yadav’s son Anant Yadav said: “Our family is in realty business since 2010 when my father developed a 100-bigha property. My uncle has many housing projects. As private individuals, we have

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 6

NARROW STAIRCASE SOLE EXIT, FIREFIGHTERS BREAK WALL

15 killed in Lucknow building fire; owners among three held

SIT formed, four officials suspended; building housed game development studio, pet shop

Manish Sahu, Bhupendra Pandey & Maulshree Seth
Lucknow, June 22

AT LEAST 15 people were killed after a massive fire tore through a three-storey commercial building in Lucknow’s upscale Aliganj area on Monday afternoon. While a pet shop was on the ground floor, the second floor, which bore the brunt of the blaze, housed Head Hopper Studios, a company involved in 3D art production and game development. Most of the victims worked there.

The fire department first received information about the blaze at the building on Usha Mehta Marg, under the Aliganj police station limits, around 3 pm, officials said. A fire department official said 14 fire tenders, including a hydraulic platform vehicle, were pressed into service.

According to officials, firefighters had no way to enter the building since the only way in was engulfed in flames and smoke, and they had to break a side wall after reaching the terrace of the adjoining house to begin the rescue operation. It took another hour for constables to use sledgehammers to make two holes in the wall to enter the building. The families

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2



At the site of the incident in Aliganj, Lucknow, Monday. VISHAL SRIVASTAV

‘Papa, please save me’: Desperate phone calls from those trapped inside

Maulshree Seth & Bhupendra Pandey
Lucknow, June 22

AT THE mortuary of King George’s Medical University (KGMU) in Lucknow, the grief was palpable as parents and relatives replayed the final

phone calls from their children and siblings — trapped inside a burning building in Aliganj, crying out for help that never came.

Fifteen people, most of whom were employees of Head

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

MORE REPORTS, PAGE 7

Happening today

• **BANGLADESH WILL BE** on high alert in view of the founding anniversary of the now-disbanded Awami League party.

LEBANON FIGHTING ABATES

Amid peace talks, US waives sanctions on Iran oil for 60 days

Humeyra Pamuk, Dave Graham & Laila Bassam
Buergerstock, Beirut, June 22

THE UNITED States waived sanctions on Iran for 60 days from Monday after the first talks under a nascent peace deal, and officials reported calm in Lebanon after fighting that had prompted Iran to declare the Strait of Hormuz closed.

After a weekend that had seemed to put the week-old peace agreement in jeopardy, including threats from US President Donald Trump to restart the war if Iran closed the strait, tanker traffic started to pick up through the waterway and oil prices resumed their slide. US Vice President J D Vance said his talks with Iranian officials in Switzerland had laid a good foundation for a final peace deal, although Iran denied that



“There was a little bit of threatening, there was a little bit of whining, but at the end of the day the talks continued and we made great progress.”

J D VANCE, U.S. VICE-PRESIDENT

it had begun discussions of its nuclear programme.

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

Cousins turn land bank into housing projects

Govind’s deal with Indore developer, Nilesh building under Sawariya brand

Jay Mazoomdaar
Ujjain, June 22

WHILE ON a land-purchasing spree in and around Ujjain, Chief Minister Mohan Yadav’s family struck deals with builders to develop some of these parcels. A few clusters are being developed by the

family itself.

For instance, between April 2024 and July 2025, Mohan Yadav’s cousin Govind Yadav and his associates purchased 41 acres through 16 land deals in Gangedi, near the junction of the upgraded Ujjain-Badnagar and Ujjain-Indore highways.

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A housing project coming up in Ujjain’s Gangedi. EXPRESS

12 Indians killed in Qatar gas plant blast

Divya A
New Delhi, June 22

TWELVE INDIANS were among 13 people killed in an explosion at a gas processing facility in Ras Laffan Industrial City in Qatar on Sunday night.

In a statement, Qatar’s Ministry of Interior said the incident was caused by a “technical malfunction” during operations.

“Qatari authorities have confirmed that 12 Indian nationals have unfortunately passed away in the Ras Laffan incident yesterday night. We extend our

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Goyal-Greer talks start today, trade surplus with US down over 40%

Ravi Dutta Mishra
New Delhi, June 22

WHILE COMMERCE Minister Piyush Goyal is scheduled to begin the two-day talks with United States Trade Representative Jamieson Greer on Tuesday to conclude a trade deal by next month, data shows that India’s trade surplus with the US has slipped by over 40% since the negotiations began last year, following Prime Minister Narendra Modi’s meeting with US President Donald Trump on February 13, 2025.

E. EXPLAINED

Across sectors

From petroleum products to electronic components, motor vehicles to fresh fruits, data shows Indian exports are declining while imports from the US are on the rise.

The high-level talks come as the US is set to complete its

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2



In conversation with Nara Lokesh

Andhra Pradesh IT Minister Nara Lokesh with Vandita Mishra, National Opinion Editor, *The Indian Express*, at the Express Adda in New Delhi, Monday. RENUKA PURI



ECONOMY PAGE 13

CRED FOUNDER KUNAL SHAH TO HEAD WHATSAPP

Business as Usual

By EPUNNY



Sandip G
New Jersey, June 22

THE BELGIUM forwards must have been spooked by Iranian goalkeeper Alireza Beiranvand. No matter how hard they tried, they couldn’t get anything past his elastic, ever so reliable giant fists.

At one time during their World Cup group game in Los Angeles on Sunday, which ended in a 0-0 draw, the Belgium star, Kevin De Bruyne, stood stunned when Iran’s hero for the day saved a close-range shot hammered at him by Maxim De Cuyper. When De Cuyper took the shot from a deflection that fell at his feet, Alireza slipped and was wrong-footed. Yet, the Iranian somehow stretched out his left hand and palmed the ball away from danger.

If not a footballer, Alireza may have made it big as a gym-



Iran’s goalkeeper Alireza Beiranvand made seven saves to record a clean sheet against Belgium on Sunday. AP

nast. But such has been his life of hardships that he had to take several odd jobs to pursue his dream of becoming a footballer.

The eldest son of a sheep-herding, nomadic family in Iran’s Lorestan province, Alireza doesn’t remember a permanent dwelling until he was in his teenage years. “We moved from one village to another, rearing our sheep, ensuring they didn’t stray from the herd, guarding them from being stolen,” he told *Varzesh3.com*, an Iranian sports news portal.

In his spare time, he played

football and ‘*Dal Paran*’, a traditional Iranian game which involves pelting stones into a distance. “It helped me with my distribution later in football,” he would say. The dream ignited only after his family settled down at Sarabias.

Dodging his stern father’s attention, he joined a local club when he was around 12 years old. He was a striker, but got a chance at goalkeeping when both the regular goalies got injured. One day, his father found out he was playing football, leaving the herding to the younger siblings.

“I was the eldest, so I had to take on my father’s lineage, but I wanted to be a footballer,” Alireza would say later.

In a fit of rage, his father tore his gloves. And he didn’t have the money to buy another pair. There was only one solution: to board the bus to Tehran at night, when his father was asleep. So, Alireza borrowed money from a cousin and left home. The 600-kilometre journey was arduous, and he had little money.

In the bus, he met the coach of a local team, named Hussein

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Devotees light diyas at the Kheer Bhawani Temple during the annual mela in Ganderbal, J&K, on Monday. SHUAIB MASOODI

Kashmiri Pandits visit Kheer Bhawani temple for mela, welcomed by residents, leaders

Bashaarat Masood
Srinagar, June 22

THOUSANDS OF people belonging to the Kashmiri Pandit community from different parts of the country assembled at Tulmulla, around 30 km from Srinagar, on Sunday to celebrate Zyeshtha Ashtami and take part in the Kheer Bhawani Mela. It is one of the most religiously significant days for Kashmiri Pandits and has been a symbol of communal unity in the Kashmir Valley. On Monday, as Pandits from the Valley and other parts of the country paid obeisance at the Kheer Bhawani temple in Ganderbal district's Tulumulla, they were welcomed by local residents and authorities. J&K Lt Governor Manoj Sinha and former chief minister Mehbooba Mufti visited the temple, and the Valley's chief cleric Mirwaiz Umar Farooq greeted the Kashmiri Pandits on the occasion of Zyeshtha Ashtami. Tight security arrangements were in place as people poured into Tulmulla from early Monday morning and offered milk and kheer (rice pudding) to the goddess. A large number of tourists also arrived at the temple. The annual festival gives a rare opportunity to Kashmiri Pandits living outside the Valley to return for a few days and to pay obeisance at the sacred temple. The Kheer Bhawani Temple, dedicated to the Goddess Ragnya Devi, is one of the

most sacred Hindu pilgrimage sites in Kashmir.

Lt Governor Sinha offered prayers at the temple also interacted with the Kashmiri Pandit community. "Today, I prayed for the well-being, peace and prosperity of all. May the blessings of Mata Kheer Bhawani be upon everyone. This year, the number of devotees visiting the holy shrine is higher compared to previous years," Sinha told reporters. Extending greetings on the occasion, J&K Chief Minister Omar Abdullah, who visited the temple a couple of days earlier, expressed hope that the festival would "further strengthen the bonds of harmony, brotherhood and rich composite cultural heritage of Jammu and Kashmir".

Former chief minister and People's Democratic Party (PDP) president Mehbooba Mufti visited the temple on Monday and said, "I am happy that they (Kashmiri Pandits) are coming and that the people here are giving them a warm welcome."

"I would appeal to them that whatever happened in the past, they should forget that and focus on the future," she added. She asked the Pandits to sideline people "who weaponise their sufferings".

The Valley's chief cleric, Mirwaiz Umar Farooq, extended his greeting to Kashmiri Pandits on the occasion. "May this day renew the spirit of mutual respect, brotherhood and the shared heritage of Kashmir that we inherited," he said.

[FROM PAGE 1 | FULL REPORTS ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM]

15 killed in Lucknow building fire

of several victims told *The Indian Express* that precious minutes were lost in the process.

The only entrance to the building was a narrow staircase, which also served as the sole exit. There was no emergency exit on any floor, and no ventilation was found in any of the halls or rooms, officials said.

The biggest trap for the victims was that entry to the studios was through biometric access, which got locked after the fire broke out, officials and the relatives of some of the victims said. There was also a lock on the terrace door.

Several people were seen jumping from the building, and one of them sustained fractures. Some broke open a window and rappelled down an electric cable. A few victims who were trapped had shut themselves in-

side the washroom to escape the flames and smoke. They were all found dead, officials said.

The dead include 11 men and four women.

Police have arrested three people so far: Ramkrishna Upadhyay, 43; Virendra Prasad Shukla, 62; and T K Jaiswal, 31. According to Assistant Commissioner of Police, Aliganj, Shashi Prakash Mishra, Upadhyay operated the pet clinic housed in the building, while Shukla and Jaiswal are among the owners of the premises. Police said Shukla's son, Akhilesh, ran the studio.

Sections invoked against them include attempt to commit culpable homicide and culpable homicide not amounting to murder.

Uttar Pradesh Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath ordered the

suspension of four officials: Gaurav Kumar, Executive Engineer (Collection) of Electricity Department of Lucknow's Jankipuram area; Kamendra Kumar Singh, Fire Service Officer of Indira Nagar Fire station; Anil Kumar and Pramod Pandey, Assistant Engineer and Junior Engineer of the Lucknow Development Authority.

The CM also visited the site of the fire and later met the injured men and women at King George's Medical University (KGMU), assuring strict action against those found responsible.

KGMU Vice-Chancellor Sonia Nityanand told *The Indian Express* that all 15 victims suffocated to death.

Deputy Chief Minister Brajesh Pathak said a high-level inquiry has been ordered. "When the fire was reported, (people

ran towards the back (to save themselves). I myself saw about 13-14 bodies... There was no space to enter, so rescue teams had to break a wall to get in," he said.

A Special Investigation Team (SIT) was constituted on the CM's order after he held a meeting with the Chief Secretary, ACS Home, DGP and other top officers. It has been given seven days to submit the report.

Prime Minister Narendra Modi announced an ex gratia payment of Rs 2 lakh from the PM's relief fund for the families of those who died, and Rs 50,000 for the injured.

This blaze in Lucknow comes within weeks of a massive fire in Delhi. Twenty-three people, including foreign nationals, were killed in the fire that destroyed a ground-plus-five-storey building operating as a bed and breakfast (B&B) establishment in Malviya Nagar in South Delhi.

'Papa, please save me'

Hopper Studios, a company involved in 3D art production and game development on the second floor, were killed in the blaze that tore through a three-storey building on Monday afternoon.

Among those killed was Sukhmani Singh (23), a game designer at the company. His father, Prabhjot Singh, said his son called him around 2 pm, pleading for help. "*Papa mujhe bacha lo* (Papa, please save me)," he cried. He told us there was no space to get out," the father said.

Another victim, Joyneel Chakravorty (27), also worked at the centre. His relative, Vishwa-

nath Sarkar, said, "Joyneel called his aunt around 2 pm in a state of panic. 'Chachi, hum phans gaye hain, kisi tarah bachao (Aunt, we're trapped, please save us somehow),' he told her."

The relatives said they reached the spot around 3 pm and believe that several lives could have been saved had the decision to break the wall to the burning building from the adjacent terrace been taken earlier. "They broke the wall in front of us. We were still on the call with Joyneel at the time," Vishwanath said.

Kalpna Srivastava, mother of 25-year-old victim Aditya Sri-

vastava, said she saw young men and women trying to escape the building using a pipe on the outside.

"My son's friends jumped, but he just could not come out," she said. "Our last conversation with him was around 1 pm."

She said Aditya started working at the animation centre about a month and a half ago for a salary of Rs 9,000. Questioning how the establishment was allowed to operate, she said, "I just want to ask how a place like this was given a licence to function without proper ventilation and exits."

Aditya's father is a lawyer; his family hails from neighbouring Sitapur district.

Another victim, Suraj Singh, worked at the same centre and

lived with Joyneel. Vishwanath said Suraj's parents could not be contacted as their phones were switched off.

KGMU Vice-Chancellor Sonia Nityanand told *The Indian Express* that 24 people were brought to the hospital, of whom 15 were declared dead on arrival. "There were no injury marks on the bodies... all of them suffocated to death. The autopsies are being conducted."

Of the seven injured, five were discharged after treatment, while two — a man and a woman — remain hospitalised with serious injuries, officials said.

The man suffered multiple fractures after jumping from the building in an attempt to escape the flames, according to hospital sources.

Trade surplus with US down

• Imports from US rising, exports falling

	U.S. IMPORTS TO INDIA (in \$ million)			INDIA'S EXPORTS TO U.S. (in \$ million)		
	March 2025	March 2026	Growth %	March 2025	March 2026	Growth %
Petroleum products	139	321	130	309	235	-24
Electronic component	182	431	136	203	135	-33
Organic chemicals	86	172	98	115	101	-12
Copper products	29	75	159	38	31	-18
Motor vehicles/Cars	1	14	1,284	2	1	-37
Fresh fruits	113	131	15	2	1	-10

SOURCE: COMMERCE AND INDUSTRY MINISTRY

Section 301 investigation by next month and come out with a new tariff architecture, which could act as an alternative to reciprocal tariffs. After over a year of trade tension between India and the US, government officials said Goyal and Greer are expected to give "the final touch" to the first tranche of the trade agreement.

Meanwhile, data released by the Commerce and Industry Ministry showed that India's export surplus slipped over 40% to \$2.94 billion in May this year, from \$5.02 billion in May 2025. Data suggests that India's surplus has been declining in multiple categories beyond energy.

Ahead of Greer's visit, several farm groups have reiterated that the US has one of the largest farm subsidy programmes, and the government should stick to its stance in the World Trade Organisation (WTO) and refrain from commitment on farm imports, which could hurt the interests of apple, almond, walnut, soybean, cotton and rubber growers.

Declining export surplus

The fears of higher imports from the US come as India's export surplus is already declin-

ing due to various concessions that India agreed to during the negotiations. Right before Modi's visit to the US last year, India reduced duty on American bourbon whiskey and slashed tariff on Harley-Davidson motorcycles.

Last November, Indian public sector refiners also signed a one-year deal for American liquefied petroleum gas (LPG) imports, marking the first structured contract of US LPG for the domestic market. The deal stated that India would import around 2.2 million tonnes per annum (MTPA) of LPG from the US, which is close to 10% of India's annual imports. Amid disruption in LNG imports from West Asia, US turned into India's top source for LNG in May, as per data shared by commodity market analytics firm Kpler.

A push for higher imports from the US came as India, for the better part of 2025, was bargaining to get lower tariff rates. However, the US imposed 50% duty for months until the US Supreme Court declared it illegal in February this year.

Competition from US

Data showed that several Indian exports have been declining in the same categories where US imports are on the

rise, signalling potential competition. Government officials have claimed that US goods are not price-competitive as compared to Indian manufacturers.

In March this year, India's petroleum product exports to the US slipped by 24.02% to \$235.47 million, as compared to \$309.91 million in March 2025. India's imports in March under the same category increased by 130.95% to \$321.73 million, as compared to \$139.31 million in March 2025.

Another high-volume product category where US imports have been gaining ground is electronic components. While India's exports of electronic components in March this year slipped by 33.41% to \$135.54 million, from \$203.54 million in March 2025, India's imports under this category jumped by 136.30% to \$431.89 million in March 2026 as compared to \$182.77 million in March 2025.

A similar trend was visible in organic chemicals, copper products, motor vehicles and fresh fruits, where exports slipped between 10 to 40% and imports jumped between 15 to 1285%. India's imports of scientific instruments have also been increasing.

Farmers' appeal

The most sensitive element

IELTS, TOEFL exam racket busted in Gujarat, one from UP arrested: Police

Aditi Raja
Vadodra, June 22

A HIDDEN passage through a wall, mirrored computer screens and dummy test-takers working from a separate room formed the backbone of an alleged exam fraud racket for international language proficiency tests such as TOEFL and CELPIP that was on Monday busted by the Anand Cyber Crime Police, which arrested one accused and launched a search for more suspects, including the alleged masterminds.

Police identified the alleged mastermind of the racket as Harshad Raval and said he, along with his aide Arth Bun-

dela, set up the examination centre under the guise of a legitimate facility. The centre allegedly conducted not only TOEFL and CELPIP examinations but also IELTS and other foreign-language proficiency tests required for overseas education and employment.

Police identified the arrested accused as Tarunkant Sharma, a resident of South Bopal, Ahmedabad, and originally from Sahibabad in Uttar Pradesh. Sharma was allegedly working as an employee of the centre under the direction of Raval, police said. Teams have been formed to arrest Raval and Bundela, both residents of Ahmedabad, police said.

Police said that following intelligence inputs, a team on Monday carried out a raid at an 'examination centre' operating from a building behind a college near Anand Grid Chokdi.

Investigators found that a company, Link Horizon, was allegedly facilitating malpractice in online examinations including TOEFL, CELPIP and others, which are often required for study, work and immigration purposes.

Police said the suspects had devised a sophisticated arrangement to allow impersonation during the examinations. During the raid, officers discovered two rooms functioning as a "test lab and a support

room". The rooms were connected through a concealed opening in a common wall. Police claimed that the accused used HDMI splitter adapters to mirror examination screens from the test lab to computers located in the support room.

Deputy Superintendent of Police J N Panchal said, "The setup enabled a dummy candidate sitting in the support room to take the examination on behalf of the registered test-taker. The system was designed to help candidates clear examinations through fraudulent means, thereby cheating examination authorities and compromising the integrity of the testing process."

Iran oil sanctions

The two sides, trying to build on the interim deal they signed last week, agreed to a roadmap towards a permanent agreement within 60 days at the talks in the Qatari-owned Swiss mountain resort of Buergerstock, mediators Pakistan and Qatar said.

They also agreed on a mechanism to end fighting in Lebanon between US ally Israel and Iran-aligned Hezbollah, and opened a communications line to help ensure safe passage for commercial ships through the strait. In the first major step of several foreseen under the agreement to provide Iran with economic benefits, the US Treasury announced a waiver until August 21 on sanctions, allowing Iran to sell oil and related products and receive payment for them.

Vance, who has maintained a largely upbeat tone since the memorandum of understanding was signed, said Tehran had agreed to allow in nuclear inspectors, and to establish mechanisms to handle its assets frozen abroad and manage ceasefires. "We laid a very good foundation for a successful final deal," he told reporters after taking part in the talks.

However, Iran's Foreign Ministry spokesperson Esmail Baghaei told the official IRNA news agency that Iran had not yet discussed nuclear issues or made new commitments.

Iran has limited inspections by the International Atomic Energy Agency since the US and Israel launched a first round of air strikes last year, and suspended them entirely when war broke out in February. It says its nuclear programme is peaceful.

Vance played down the tensions that had emerged over the weekend, which were driven by escalating fighting in Lebanon, Iran's new declaration that it had again closed the strait, and an angry response from Trump. "There was a little bit of threatening, there was a little bit of whining, but at the end of the day the talks continued and we made great progress," Vance said.

Iranian Foreign Minister Abbas Aragchi said on social media that Tehran had secured waivers for oil and petrochemical exports, the release of some of its frozen assets abroad and the launch of a reconstruction and development plan for Iran.

Vance said White House envoy Jared Kushner, Trump's son-in-law, had come up with a process whereby the US and Qatar would have control over Iranian funds when they are unfrozen, and the money could be spent on US corn, soy and wheat.

Oil prices drop

Technical talks were due to continue for the rest of this week.

The interim peace agreement calls for ending all hostilities, including in Lebanon which Israel invaded in March after Hezbollah fired across the border. Israel was not party to the peace agreement and says it will not withdraw its troops from Lebanon, but on Friday it agreed to a new ceasefire.

Though intense fighting continued for another day, Lebanese officials said it had abated since Saturday night. Hassan Wazni, director of a hospital in Nabatieh, a city in the south that has been heavily bombarded during the conflict, said it was the first two full days of calm since the war began. "I'm monitoring the situation day by day, and most of the time I'm sleeping in the hospital. This is the longest a ceasefire has held," he told Reuters by phone.

More than a million Lebanese have been displaced by the war, and though some have begun returning to their homes, many are still too wary.

In Qennarit, a southern town, mourners carried the bodies of four women killed in Saturday's wave of Israeli strikes. The coffins were draped in yellow Hezbollah flags with the group's green logo of an arm holding an assault rifle.

Meanwhile, reflecting the reduced tensions, the Israeli military lifted safety restrictions in eight communities in northern Israel near the Lebanese border.

Lebanese President Joseph Aoun discussed efforts to maintain the ceasefire and halt Israeli military escalation during a phone call with Vance, Qatar's Prime Minister, and Kushner, the Lebanese presidency said.

Israeli President Isaac Herzog said Israel was not opposed to a diplomatic end to the Iran war, but any agreement must ensure Tehran cannot use funds it receives as part of the deal for military purposes or to support regional proxies. REUTERS

Qatar gas plant blast

deepest condolences to the bereaved families and prayers for the departed souls," the Indian Embassy in Doha said in a post on X on Monday.

The identities of the deceased are not known yet. While many of the injured are also Indians, the Embassy said they were "stable".

"Qatari authorities have also confirmed that all those who got injured in the incident are in stable condition and are receiving appropriate medical treatment. Our Embassy is working in close contact with the Qatari authorities to extend all possible help to the Indian nationals and their families affected by this incident, including ensuring that mortal remains of the deceased are sent to India at the earliest," it said.

Confirming the deaths at a press conference in Doha,

Qatar's Energy Minister Saad bin Sherida Al Kaabi said: "I find myself today having to do something I have always hoped will never happen, and that is to announce the tragic loss of 13 lives of our people who hold Indian and Pakistani nationalities. Sixty-six people have been reported injured and are receiving medical treatment, none of whom are in life-threatening condition".

"I would like to emphasise that this was an accident and not sabotage or hostile in nature," he said, according to AP.

The Indian community is the largest expatriate group in Qatar, with over 830,000 Indians residing and working across various industries. Ras Laffan is Qatar's central natural gas hub, employing thousands of engineers, technicians and labourers, many of whom are Indians.

Iran's World Cup hero

Faiz. He explained his dream, but the coach demanded token money. "It's not his fault, it was a club on a meagre budget, and it can't provide free training for everyone," Alireza reasoned.

He paid the first month's fee from whatever his cousin had given him.

In Tehran, he had no relatives or shelter. He trained in the evening and slept in mosques, or on the streets sometimes. One day, he slept near the club, and when he woke up, he could feel the coins on his body. "They had thought I was a beggar. Well, I had a delicious breakfast for the first time in a long while," he told *The Guardian*. Moved by his struggles and determination, the coach told the club owners to allow him to train for free and lodge with a senior player. But he still had to make ends meet. His roommate introduced him to a car-washing firm. "The owner was delighted because I was tall and I could wash the SUVs without straining," he said.

From a car-washer, he became a waiter at a pizza shop. His

coach found out and gave him a stipend to stop him from going, but the money would run dry by the end of the month. Alireza later became a street cleaner by night, so that nobody would see him.

But the nightly shifts took a toll on his body and his game time diminished. A local club, Nafta, noticed him and asked him to train with the U-23 side. "My career took off, I started to get money for appearances and got into Iran's U-23 side," he told *Varzesh3.com*.

Alireza made his Iran debut in 2015, just four years after he left his hometown in the dead of the night. Three years later, he famously saved a Cristiano Ronaldo penalty in the 2018 World Cup.

In between, he returned home and reconciled with his father. "He told me I had made him proud, and that he was sorry he didn't support me. It was an emotional moment, but in life, you have to make some tough decisions," Alireza recalled later.

On Sunday, he made all the right decisions.



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AAP GOVT, DISCOMS WERE IN CAHOOTS, SAYS MINISTER; ATISHI SAYS HER GOVT ORDERED AUDIT

HC clears way for BSES audit amid nexus claim

Devansh Mittal
New Delhi, June 22

THE DELHI High Court on Monday dismissed a plea by BSES Rajdhani Power Limited and BSES Yamuna Power Limited challenging a government notice proposing to entrust an audit of the two major discoms in the Capital to the Comptroller and Auditor General of India (CAG).

A June 6 notice, the High Court held, was only a show-cause notice under the CAG Act, which gave the two discoms an opportunity to submit their response before any decision on an audit was taken.

The proposed audit could not be ruled out at this stage, provided the procedure under

the law was followed, underlined the court.

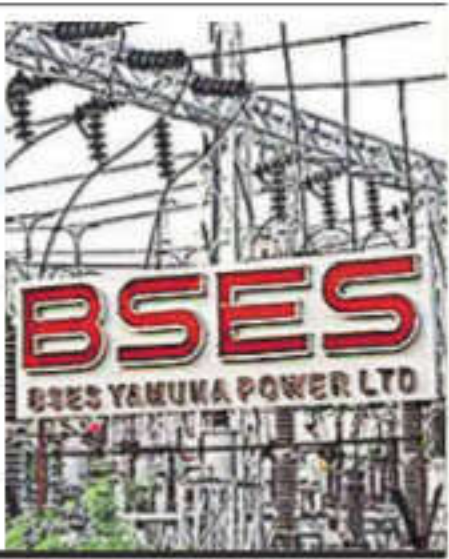
The case is linked to the accumulation of regulatory assets — the gap between the revenue discoms are allowed to recover through tariffs and their approved costs. Regulatory assets are ultimately recovered from consumers through tariffs or surcharges.

The court also stated that the proposed audit is prima facie in public interest as the decision on regulatory assets would directly affect the consumers of the petitioners.

BSES refused to comment on whether it will appeal against the decision.

The Supreme Court, while dealing with the issue last year, had directed a strict and inten-

• IN NUMBERS	
Discoms	Regulatory assets (Rs cr)
BSES Rajdhani Power Limited	19,174
BSES Yamuna Power Limited	12,333
Tata Power Delhi Distribution Limited	7,046
TOTAL	38,500



sive audit into the circumstances that led to such dues remaining unrecovered for years.

Meanwhile, Delhi Power Minister Ashish Sood welcomed the High Court order on Monday and hit out at the previous Aam Aadmi Party (AAP)

government, accusing it of “a deep-rooted nexus and collusion with private electricity distribution companies (discoms) to deliberately evade financial accountability and fleece the residents of Delhi”.

He claimed that the pre-

vious government had left Delhi consumers with a burden of around Rs 38,000 crore in regulatory assets.

“Our moving forward to seek permission for the CAG audit, and the discoms going to the High Court in opposition to it, proves in itself that the electricity companies, Arvind Kejriwal, and the AAP government were in cahoots,” Sood claimed.

The High Court, however, also said the notice did not make any adverse finding against the discoms and merely called upon them to appear for a hearing.

It clarified that the competent authority must take a decision after hearing the companies and without being influenced by the court’s obser-

vations.

Former Delhi chief minister and Aam Aadmi Party leader Atishi refuted the charge as “baseless and illogical” and said that the previous AAP government in Delhi ordered the audit of discoms on the pension surcharge issue in October 2024. “If there was any nexus between AAP and the power companies, why would our government order an audit of those very companies?” she asked.

In Delhi, regulatory assets have crossed Rs 38,500 crore, according to submissions made by the Delhi Electricity Regulatory Commission (DERC) before the Appellate Tribunal for Electricity (APTEL).

These include Rs 19,174

crore for BSES Rajdhani Power Limited (BRPL), Rs 12,333 crore for BSES Yamuna Power Limited (BYPL), and Rs 7,046 crore for Tata Power Delhi Distribution Limited (TPDDL).

Tariffs in Delhi have not seen a revision since 2014-15, even as power purchase costs for discoms have increased over a decade. This has led to a steady accumulation of dues. Moreover, Delhi has a hefty power subsidy bill of around Rs 4,000 crore.

As part of the government’s power subsidy, domestic consumers do not have to pay for electricity consumption of up to 200 units per month, while those consuming between 201 and 400 units get a 50% subsidy.

AIIMS restricts coaching centre ads, posters across campus

New Delhi: AIIMS Delhi in a circular has ordered to remove any advertisement, poster or pamphlet tied to coaching classes, entrance examination preparation, private educational activities on the notice boards across its campus.

A circular issued by AIIMS on June 17 said: “It has been observed that notices/advertisements relating to coaching classes, entrance examination preparation, private educational activities, and other unauthorized promotional materials are being displayed on notice boards and at various locations within the premises of AIIMS, New Delhi without prior approval of the Competent Authority.” ENS

Child-trafficking case: 2 more held, another infant rescued

Sakshi Chand
New Delhi, June 22

TWO INDIVIDUALS were arrested and an infant was rescued on Sunday as police widened their investigation into the alleged interstate child-trafficking ring that was busted earlier this month.

Investigators said they were examining the role of more employees of Hira’s Multi Speciality Hospital, a private establishment in Begumpur in northwest Delhi that has emerged as the epicentre of the alleged racket. Tracing the biological parents of the rescued children has emerged as one of the biggest challenges in the investigation, police officers said. Names and addresses obtained so far have not matched with the official records, which has made it difficult to locate the families, they said.

The infant who was rescued on Sunday had been allegedly passed off as the biological child of a woman who is one of the two individuals who have been arrested. This woman, whom police have identified as Garima Jain, was allegedly admitted to the hospital in Begumpur on June 4, and records had been prepared to show that she had delivered the baby boy the following day.

The woman’s father-in-law, identified as Satish Jain, has

The rescued infant had been allegedly passed off as the biological child of a woman who is one of the two who have been arrested

been arrested. Her husband remains absconding, police said. Both the woman and the man were arrested in Rohini in northwest Delhi.

Investigators suspect the documents were fabricated by Dr Viveki, the owner of Hira’s hospital, who is among the 15 people who have been arrested since police opened their investigation into the alleged criminal ring that was believed to have been running for more than a year. Officers said Dr Viveki has not been cooperating with investigators and has failed to provide clear responses to investigators during questioning.

The probe has expanded to Gujarat, and the police forces of the two states are coordinating to try to identify the biological parents of the rescued children. The alleged mastermind of the racket, a man named Sayabhai Ghamar alias Kalia, was recently taken to Gujarat as part of the investigation.

Special Commissioner of Police (Law and Order) Devesh Srivastava said the investigation so far suggests the alleged child-trafficking network was a large, well-organised racket that operated across North Delhi.

“A Special Investigation Team (SIT) has been constituted to ensure that every aspect of the case is thoroughly investigated, and the probe extends to all those involved in the network. Efforts are underway to trace more infants who may have been trafficked through the racket and to rescue them,” he said.

The officer added that the biological parents of the children who allegedly sold their children too would be held accountable. Investigators have zeroed in on the name of a woman who they believe is the biological mother of an infant who was rescued earlier, and efforts are on to establish her identity and to track her down. The alleged criminals procured newborns from vulnerable families and sold them to childless couples using forged documentation.

In their coded communication, the members of the ring allegedly referred to the infants as “files”. The syndicate allegedly operated across multiple states, using hospitals, fake birth records, and a network of middlemen.

MILESTONE MARKED WITH CELEBRATORY DINNER WITH MINISTER IN ATTENDANCE

Final deck slab cast, Barapullah III project closer to completion after multiple delays over a decade



Work underway at the site (top); PWD Minister Parvesh Sahib Singh with the workers on Monday. EXPRESS

Singh said that after the BJP formed the government in Delhi last year, Barapullah Phase-III was identified as a priority pro-

ject and monitored continuously at the highest level.

He had earlier announced that the project would be ready by June 30. “For years, Delhiites saw deadlines come and go. After our government came to power, we decided that this project could not be allowed to remain stuck any longer. I have personally visited the site multiple times, reviewed progress regularly and worked with officials to remove bottlenecks. Today’s milestone is the result of that collective effort,” he added.

For more than a decade, the Barapullah Phase-III project

had become synonymous with delays, missed deadlines and unanswered questions. Originally expected to be completed in 2017, it remained unfinished year after year owing to land acquisition disputes, environmental clearances, technical challenges and prolonged administrative hurdles. The project, which began in 2015, saw repeated delays and significant cost escalation, with the revised cost now standing at approximately Rs 1,635 crore.

The final slab involved casting approximately 175 cubic metres of concrete. With this, the project has crossed the landmark figure of nearly 4.5 lakh cubic metres of concrete in total, a remarkable engineering achievement that reflects the scale of the elevated corridor, officials said. The slab physically connects the two sides of the Yamuna through the corridor’s structure, a moment many had feared would be delayed indefinitely.

The project’s journey has been far from easy. Approved in

2014 and initiated in 2015, it was originally targeted for completion in 2017. Instead, it became one of Delhi’s most delayed infrastructure projects, with setbacks ranging from a seven-year land acquisition dispute and environmental approvals to technical challenges associated with constructing a major bridge across the Yamuna floodplain.

The 3.5-km, three-lane flyover will provide eight loops, four each at Sarai Kale Khan and Mayur Vihar.

The corridor, expected to decongest traffic along National Highway 24, the DND Flyway and Ring Road, will allow commuters to travel from East Delhi to AIIMS in 15 minutes, a journey that currently takes 35 to 40 minutes.

The project is also set to become a landmark in urban infrastructure. Besides being a first-of-its-kind elevated corridor with a dedicated cycle track, a key engineering highlight is the special bridge structure over the Yamuna floodplain.

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Adv. No. A-120116/06-2023-IIAC Date: 21.06.2026

In continuation to IIAC's recruitment advertisement dated 08.05.2026 for Assistant Registrar-01, Assistant Registrar (Accounts)-01, Private Secretary-04 and Executive Assistant/Assistant Section Officer (Accounts)-01 post on "Deputation Basis" (on Foreign Service Terms), for which the last date of receipt of applications was 15.06.2026 has been extended to 06.07.2026 due to administrative reasons.

(Navin Kumar Singh)
Chief Executive Officer, IIAC

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The post was previously advertised on 16.12.2025, 03.01.2026 and 03.03.2026. Based on the recommendations of the Selection Committee constituted by the Government, the eligibility criteria have been revised and the post is hereby re-advertised to attract a larger pool of qualified candidates. Candidates who have already applied and appeared for the interview conducted on 15.04.2026 need not apply again. Their applications will be considered along with the applications received pursuant to this notification.

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3. Ph.D. is desirable but not mandatory.

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For detailed Terms of Reference (ToR), application format and eligibility conditions, visit the KSNDMC website: www.ksndmc.org

Last Date for Submission of Applications: 1st July, 2026, 5.00 PM

Sd/- DIRECTOR, KSNDMC

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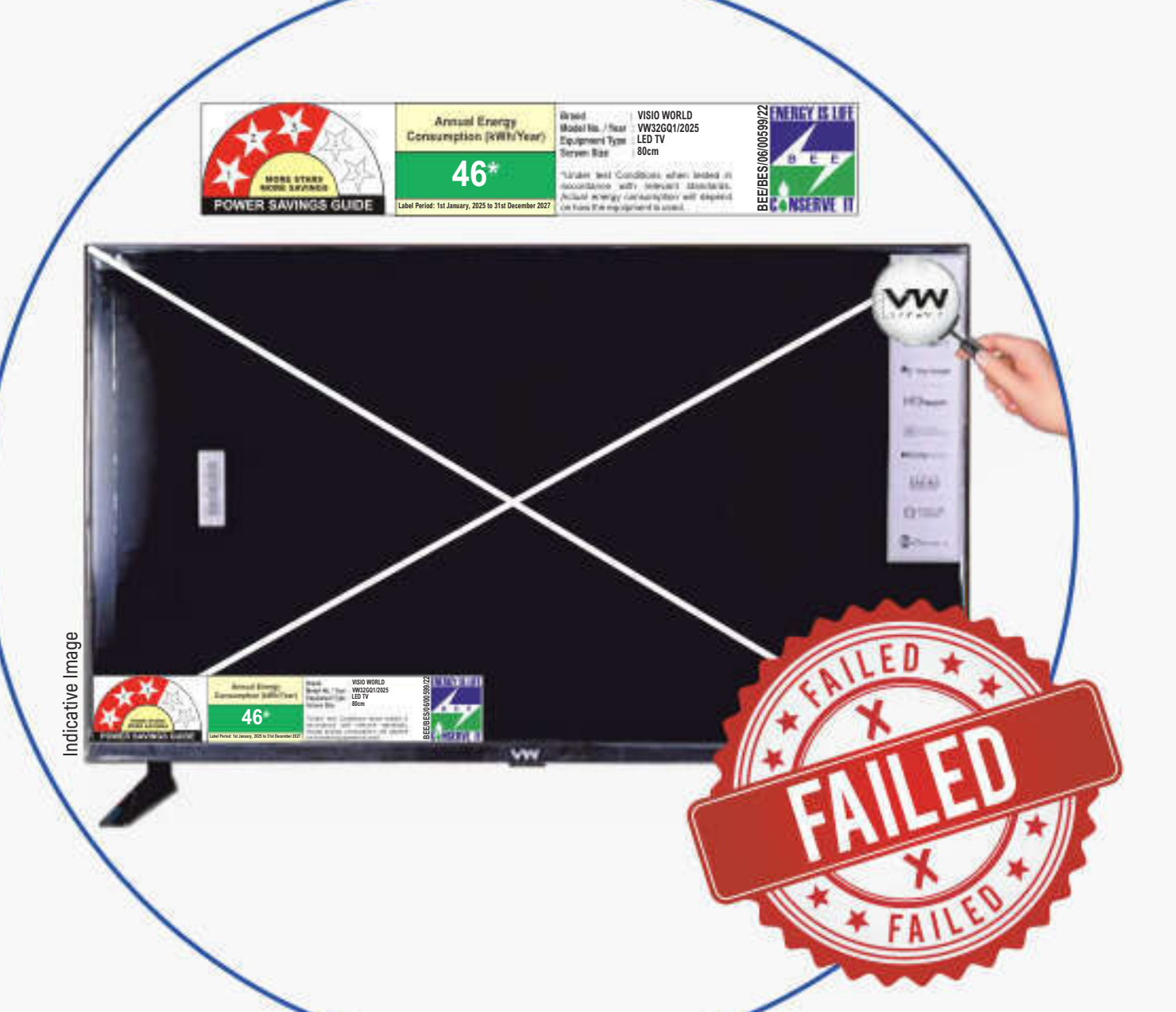
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New Delhi

TOP INSTITUTES HAVE BACKED GOVT PLAN TO INCENTIVISE HYBRIDS

Should strong hybrids be cheaper? Key question as EV policy call nears

Gayathri Mani
New Delhi, June 22

PROVISIONS RELATING to strong hybrid vehicles in Delhi's new Electric Vehicle (EV) Policy continue to be debated as the existing policy, which has already been extended multiple times, nears expiry. The new EV Policy 2026-30 is expected to be placed before the Cabinet at its next meeting.

Over the past couple of months since the draft policy was put in the public domain, the Delhi Transport Department has received more than 700 responses, and the suggestions are under review, officials said.

There is a clear divergence of opinion over exempting strong hybrids from road tax. A strong (or 'full') hybrid vehicle combines a traditional internal combustion engine with a powerful electric motor and a larger battery, which enables it to run entirely on electric power at low speeds, and to switch automatically to the engine for higher speeds. A mild hybrid, by contrast, has a smaller electric motor and battery, and cannot run on electricity alone. The electric motor in mild hybrids acts only to boost acceleration and smoothen stop-start systems.

"The government wants to provide road tax exemptions on buying strong hybrid vehicles at least for the first couple of years so that the public can gradually switch to electric vehicles... Several stakeholders have also backed the policy and the proposed incentives on strong hybrid vehicles. However, there is resistance from some quarters," a senior Transport officer told *The Indian Express*. Critics have argued that in-

E. EXPLAINED

What is strong hybrid?

Strong Hybrid Vehicle uses a combination of an electric motor and an internal combustion engine. This helps optimise fuel efficiency as well as performance.

stead of providing incentives to strong hybrids, the government should invest in charging infrastructure and push the adoption of pure EVs.

The draft EV Policy has proposed a 50 per cent exemption on road tax and registration charges for strong hybrids with an ex showroom price up to Rs 30 lakh.

Several top institutes and consultants working to promote electric mobility, such as the IITs and the International Road Federation (IRF), have backed the government's plan to incentivise strong hybrids, the officer said.

"The incentives on strong hybrids have been proposed after proper research and studying similar policies implemented in other states. For instance, Uttar Pradesh allowed 100 per cent exemption on strong hybrid vehicles for almost a year and a half, and both the government's revenues and vehicle registrations increased during this period, even as Delhi lost out to UP in revenues," the official said.

Auto industry data show that before strong hybrids were exempt from road tax in UP in July 2024, an average of 538 such vehicles were registered in the state every month; this

Haryana nod to tax concessions to replace old trucks, buses in NCR

Gurgaon: In a major push towards reducing vehicular emissions and improving air quality in the National Capital Region (NCR), the Haryana Cabinet on Monday approved a scheme providing substantial motor vehicle tax concessions for the replacement of old trucks and buses complying with BS-IV or earlier emission norms. The Cabinet, which met under the chairmanship of Chief Minister Nayab Singh Saini, approved the grant of exemption in motor vehicle tax for replacement of old trucks and buses registered in Gurgaon, Faridabad and other NCR districts of Haryana. The decision has been taken in accordance with the scheme for support to the National Capital Region Planning Board.

According to official estimates, the scheme has the potential to benefit approxi-



mately 93,458 trucks and 16,329 buses operating in the NCR districts of Haryana. The government expects the initiative to play an important role in fleet modernisation. Under the scheme, eligible beneficiaries replacing their old vehicles will be entitled to a 100% concession in motor vehicle tax on the purchase of new trucks and buses complying with BS-VI or stricter emission norms. The concession will also be available for EV and CNG trucks and buses purchased under the scheme. **ENS**

number increased by 175 per cent on average after the incentives were introduced. Also, the state's monthly revenues under this head increased by 60 per cent from an average Rs 29 crore per month to Rs 47 crore per month. "In just one year, UP collected revenue of Rs 500 crore by incentivising strong hybrid vehicles," the official said.

According to officials, incentivising strong hybrids will also help bridge the adoption gap as the EV charging infrastructure is gradually strengthened in the capital.

"Giving incentives will gradually nudge the public towards switching to electric mobility," the official said.

In its submission to the government, CUTS International, a public policy research and advocacy organisation, has said: "...The [proposed] 50% road tax waiver recognizes the role of strong hybrids as an effective transition technology. Self-charging hybrids operate in electric mode for around 60% of urban driving and deliver about 25-35% reduction in CO2 emissions compared to conven-

tional vehicles, offering immediate benefits without dependence on charging infrastructure."

It has also pointed out that "in the absence of such incentives earlier, consumers were registering hybrid cars in neighbouring states such as Uttar Pradesh and Haryana, leading to an estimated annual revenue loss of Rs 400-500 crore for Delhi. By rationalizing the tax structure, the policy effectively reverses this trend, turning a revenue leakage into a revenue-positive outcome while simultaneously supporting cleaner technologies..."

IRF, a global nonprofit based in Washington DC, has commended the Delhi government for proposing the incentive. "...The decision to extend a 50% road tax waiver for strong hybrid cars is a timely and progressive step... They offer an immediate and practical pathway for reducing emissions without dependence on external charging infrastructure," the IRF has said.

Nat Zero Energy Transition Association (NETRA), a global nonprofit that works on promoting cleaner energy, has argued that "a 50% waiver of road tax on SHEVs (strong hybrid electric vehicles) is not likely to result in revenue loss to the exchequer vis-à-vis a petrol equivalent vehicle but will resolve the anomaly of higher tax being paid by consumers on a cleaner technology (SHEV) as compared to a petrol car."

According to Nomura Research Institute (NRI), "inclusion of hybrids in the road tax exemption policy signals a phased approach by the government, with hybrids acting as a bridge to curb vehicular pollution till the full EV transition goal can be realized."

Summons, warrant: SOP laid for illegal tree cutting

Sophiya Mathew
New Delhi, June 22

WHAT HAPPENS when illegal tree cutting or damage to trees is reported in Delhi? The response is meant to begin at once and follow a documented legal trail under the Forest Department's Standard Operating Procedure (SOP) for dealing with offences under the Delhi Preservation of Trees Act, 1994.

The SOP, notified earlier this year and made available on the department's portal this month, details how a complaint can trigger a first offence report. Real-time alerts are sent to control rooms and field officers, the site is cordoned off, followed by video-recording of suspects, seizure of tools, complainant participation in hearings and, where required, and prosecution before a court. Those who skip summons may face arrest warrants.

According to the SOP, information on a tree offence may be received through the dedicated portal, Green Helpline calls; through letters or handwritten complaints; the Green Delhi App, or any other Delhi government app. Once information is received, the Range Officer or Range In-charge must register a First Offence Report under Section 22 of the Act. The information must then be transmitted in real time to the Forest Control Room, division control room, Beat Officer concerned and the land-owning agency.

Site response

Quick Response Team personnel must maintain status quo at the site, stop the offence and prevent further damage. They have to take geo-referenced photographs, video-record suspected offenders, document tools, vehicles, animals or other conveyances allegedly

• HIGHLIGHTS

24-HOUR control rooms at head-quarter level, and various forest divisions

QUICK RESPONSE Team to be deployed at HQ & forest divisions

ADEQUATE MANPOWER and handy equipment to be ensured with QRT

REAL-TIME ALERTS for com-

plaints from the Control rooms to the HQ and QRT at Divisional level

MAINTAIN A dedicated website to cover the entire life cycle of a complaint under DPTA

ESTABLISHMENT OF Legal Cell at Head quarter Level

ESTABLISHMENT OF Prosecution Cell at Division Level

used, and record names and addresses of suspected offenders.

If a suspect refuses to provide details, gives details believed to be false, or is likely to abscond, the person may be taken to the Range Officer for further action. The QRT must cordon the site until the Beat Officer, Deputy Range Officer or Range Forest Officer arrives, and can leave only after handing over the information collected.

Preventive action

As per the document, Beat Officers also have preventive duties where an offence is apprehended. They must record geo-referenced photographs and geo-coordinates of trees. The SOP specifically mentions digging or excavation near trees, visible deterioration of tree health, barricading of construction areas blocking direct line of sight to trees, and soil erosion.

In such cases, the land-owning agency, private owner or occupier must be informed, and a copy sent to the local police station. A restraining order may be issued under Section 20 where there is reasonable apprehension of contravention of Section 8. If such an order is violated, the Tree Officer has to intimate police under Section 173 of BNS.

Inquiry and summons

For offences underway or

Biker, daughters aged 11 & 12, fall off from Geeta Colony flyover

Express News Service
New Delhi, June 22

A BIKER and his two minor daughters plunged from a sharp curve on the Geeta Colony flyover in Shahdara on Monday afternoon, leaving the youngest daughter critically injured, police said.

As per police, the biker identified as Ashish (35), a resident of Sonia Vihar, was riding his motorcycle with his daughters Ruby (12) and Mansi (11) when the vehicle lost control on a steep loop of the flyover.

"They fell nearly 30 feet to the road below. Ashish and Ruby were partially cushioned by a tree before hitting the ground, while Mansi fell directly onto the roadway," an officer said.

Police said Mansi suffered a severe head injury and a fractured leg. Mansi is currently on ventilator support, an officer said, adding that Ashish and Ruby also sustained injuries.

23 services added to delivery system in Delhi

Express News Service
New Delhi, June 22

APPROVAL FOR new factory plans, sewage connections, and permissions for shooting films within 15 days are among the 23 services that have now been included under the Delhi Right of Citizen to Time Bound Delivery of Services Act, 2011. Currently, the Act covers time-bound delivery of 561 services delivered by various government departments.

The move, Chief Minister Rekha Gupta said Monday, aims to strengthen good governance, transparency and public service delivery. The decision, she said, will directly benefit not only ordinary citizens but will also give a boost to ease of doing business. Important approvals, licences, registrations and No Objection Certificates (NOCs) issued by various departments will now be delivered within stipulated timelines, said officials.

Under the new framework, approval of factory plans by the Labour Department will be granted within 15 days, while

registration under the Shops and Establishments Act will be completed within a single day.

The DJB will provide sewerage connections within 15 days, and the Delhi Tourism and Transportation Development Corporation will issue film shooting permissions in 15 days.

Applications related to electricity meters and connection agreements under the Energy department will be processed within 60 days. Registration of weighing and measuring instruments used in shops, industries and commercial establishments under Legal Metrology will be completed within 45 days.

The Delhi Pollution Control Committee (DPCC) will issue authorisations related to the collection, storage, transportation and recycling of battery waste under the Battery Waste Management Rules within 15 days, said officials.

Among municipal services, the CM said, registration of water sports and adventure sports operators and approvals for operating amusement parks will be issued within 60 days

RWA, residents continue to spar over dues at Gurgaon society despite govt order

Abhimanyu Hazarika
Gurgaon, June 22

EVEN AS an order by the Haryana Registrar-General of Societies last week that Resident Welfare Associations (RWAs) cannot withhold essential services or basic civic amenities to recover pending dues came as a major relief for residents, the woes of the residents of N Block at — whose appeal prompted the ruling — are far from over. While the RWA has said that the order is being examined, residents have claimed that essential services for several defaulters are yet to be restored, calling the approach "dictatorial".

The order, passed on June 16 by Dr Yash Garg, quashed a controversial resolution passed by the N Block RWA. The issue escalated after the General Body Meeting (GBM) of the N Block RWA passed a resolution on September 27 last year, revising the quarterly maintenance charges to Rs. 5,000. I

t also had a slew of punitive and coercive measures against



Mayfield Gardens at Sector 51 in Gurgaon. EXPRESS

residents for non-payment of these dues such as no garbage collection, plumber and electrician services; as well as the non-attendance of complaints. The appellants, led by N Block resident Sanjay Gupta and six other residents, challenged this before the Registrar, arguing the measures were unlawful, resulting in the denial of essential services.

In its order, the Registrar General firmly rebuked the RWA approach. The order noted that essential services and basic civic amenities necessary for sanitation, hygiene, and public

health cannot be arbitrarily withheld or discontinued merely on the basis of a General Body resolution. The authority ruled that any resolution seeking to discontinue such essential services as a coercive measure for recovery is beyond the internal administrative powers of the Society.

Further, the authority pointed out that the Rs. 5,000 quarterly charge was fixed uniformly for all categories of dwelling units.

Consequently, the GBM Resolution dated September 27, 2025, was officially quashed.

Responding to the order, RWA secretary Jitender Singh said it was being examined for potential clarifications. "The authority relied on rules meant for apartments whereas we are a plotted colony. The order makes it difficult to get those paying to continue. All coercive action was being taken as per our approved by-laws. Even the electricity board disconnects your connection on default. Essential services are not being stopped, we were requesting people to pay so we could recover." Lead appellant Gupta, who is a lawyer, claimed the RWA was not complying with the order. "They are being dictatorial and still sending reminders to alleged defaulters asking them to pay the inflated dues. For many of the appellants, essential services have not been fully restored."

The development assumes significance *The Indian Express* recently on March 18 reported a similar crackdown at another premium Gurgaon township — Uppal Southend, in Sector-49 over pending dues.

• ELDERLY CITIZENS DUPED IN DELHI

‘We are from the Crime Branch...’: How ‘Irani gang’ pulled off jewellery thefts

Pragynesh
New Delhi, June 22

ON THE evening of October 23 last year, Ashish Mishra, a lanky 19-year-old from Central Delhi's Pahadi Dhiraj, received a phone call from his employer's son.

Mishra worked as a cash collector for Praveen Gupta, a local businessman with shops in Chandni Chowk and Karol Bagh. Gupta's son, Vasu, asked him to come to Chandni Chowk, from where Mishra and another employee, Mohammad, travelled to Karol Bagh to collect cash.

Near a Vijay Sales store around 5 pm, a man handed Mishra a bag containing Rs 18 lakh. Mishra left on foot. "Near a church on DBG Road, two men on a bike stopped me. They said they

were from the Crime Branch and wanted to check my bag," Mishra later told police.

They were not policemen. The duo, dressed in t-shirts and jeans — like most special unit police officers dressed in civilian clothes — were members of the 'Irani' gang.

Two more men soon arrived on a Bullet motorcycle. "They slapped me, snatched the bag, and fled towards Anand Parbat," Mishra told the police.

For the Delhi Police, the DBG Road incident was one of several cases in which men posing as Crime Branch officers intercepted victims and fled with cash or jewellery.

In August 2025, just 10 minutes away in Prasad Nagar, a 76-year-old woman, Shanti Bajaj, was targeted in a similar manner. While travelling in an auto from her flat to her

daughter's nursing home, three men on a bike stopped her.

"They claimed to be from the Crime Branch, warned me about rising thefts in the area, and snatched my gold jewellery before fleeing," she told police.

Police records show that in 2024 alone, at least four such cases were reported in Delhi, all following a similar script.

As investigators began probing these incidents collectively, they traced them to an alleged interstate 'Irani' gang that had been operating for over a decade. Their probe, police said, eventually led them to Nasir Hafeez Khan, 48, known as 'Irani' in Old Delhi circles.

Kingpin lands in police net

Nasir was arrested on January 3 this year by the DBG Road police station team in connec-



Nasir Hafeez Khan. EXPRESS

tion with Mishra's case. Police said he has more than 38 criminal cases registered against him across Maharashtra, Delhi, Haryana and other states.

He was earlier booked under the Maharashtra Control of Organised Crime Act

(MCOCA) in Mumbai and re-mained in judicial custody till 2024.

In June, Delhi Police invoked the MCOCA against Nasir, alleging he headed a network that repeatedly impersonated Crime Branch officers to carry out organised robberies and snatchings across Delhi and several states.

"He has had a base in Delhi since 2014, after he married a woman from Daryaganj. After he was released on bail, he came back again. On October 23, 2025, along with his associates, he committed a robbery of Rs 18.84 lakh in DBG Road, Delhi," said DCP (Central) Rohit Rajbir Singh.

"Nasir was finally arrested by a team from the DBG Road police station on January 3. This month, the MCOCA was invoked by the Delhi Police

against him," added DCP Singh.

After the DGB Road robbery, police said Nasir had fled to Nagpur where he executed two back-to-back robberies, and then to Ajmer, where he conned an elderly woman into giving him 100 gms of gold jewellery in December.

Nasir and the gang

Nasir is from Maharashtra. He was born in Kalyan, a suburb near Mumbai. His alias, police said, comes from his association with what investigators have dubbed the 'Irani' gang — a gang of robbers whose members often add 'Irani' to their names to signal allegiance.

Police stressed the gang has no link to the Irani community, whose ancestors migrated to India around the 16th century

from the vast swathes of deserts spread across Balochistan and Iran. Gang members have been traced to parts of Ambavali, Mumbai and Beed in Maharashtra, Bengaluru and Bidar in Karnataka, Bhopal in Madhya Pradesh and Andhra Pradesh.

One of their trademarks, police said, is their appearance: stout, well-built men in tailored clothes, often wearing tinted aviators.

Nasir's appearance, police said, also fit the template: fair complexion, sharp features, and medium-length brown hair parted in the middle. "The gang was active around 2015, when they began targeting elderly women in South India and Maharashtra. They wore safari suits and posed as police officials," an officer said.

"They would talk about a murder or rising crime and ad-

vise elderly people to wrap their jewellery instead of wearing it."

They would take the jewellery from the elderly person, pretend to wrap it for safekeeping, and hand it back. The bundle, however, contained stones instead of gold, the officer said.

"In 2016 and 2017, they carried out brazen snatchings in Andhra Pradesh, Maharashtra and Karnataka. They travelled across states on their bikes, carried out snatchings in a particular area, and then immediately rode across the border to another state," said a police officer.

In April 2024, police said two gang members were arrested in Nagpur after allegedly travelling nearly 900 km to Odisha, carrying out six snatchings in quick succession, and riding back to Nagpur.

• Skywatch

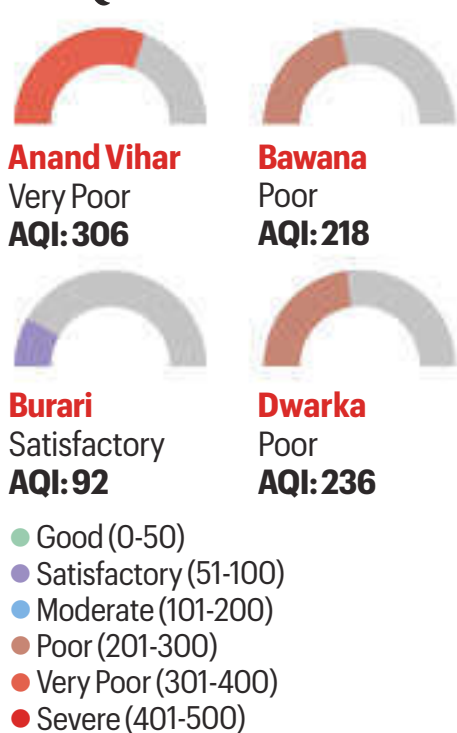

Forecast: June 23, 2026
Partly cloudy sky, possibility of thunder
MAX: 39-41
2.4°C above normal

MIN: 24-26
4°C below normal

• Sunrise: 5:25 AM (June 24)
• Sunset: 7:23 PM (June 23)

• Moonrise: 1:42 AM (June 23)
• Moonset: 1:07 PM (June 24)

• AQI Tracker



ALL IN THE YADAV FAMILY

Plot’s who’s who: Wife, son, daughter-in-law, sister, brothers, sister-in-law, nephew, first cousins

Jay Mazoomdaar
Ujjain, New Delhi, June 22

AT THE core of the Yadav family’s land holding structure are Mohan Yadav’s first cousins Govind and Nilesh Yadav. Other land purchasers in the Yadav family — either directly or through family-owned realty companies — include Mohan Yadav himself, his wife Seema, son Vaibhav, daughter-in-law Shalini, brothers Narayan and Nandlal, sister Kalavati, Narayan’s wife Rekha, and their son Abhay.

MOHAN YADAV: At least 17 acres in his own name in Ujjain. Of this, 4 acres are declared as inheritance and 13 acres as purchase (1998) in Ujjain’s Sawarakhedhi in his 2023 asset declaration.

Mohan Yadav co-owned at least another 39.5 acres through Shri Siddhivinayak Devcons Pvt Ltd, including 2.6 acres purchased in 2024-2025. Of this, 12 acres were sold to first cousin Nilesh Yadav in September 2024.

Mohan Yadav and wife Seema together hold 73% stake in the company while their son Vaibhav serves as a director.

SEEMA YADAV: Mohan Yadav’s wife holds at least 10.6 acres in her name. Of this, 3.4 acres in Sawarakhedhi and 7.2 acres in Kasba Ujjain were declared as purchases made during 2008-2011 in Mohan Yadav’s 2023 asset declaration. Seema co-owns at least another 27.5 acres through Shri Siddhivinayak Devcons Pvt Ltd (after selling 12 acres to Nilesh) where she was a director until 2017.

VAIBHAV YADAV: Mohan Yadav’s son purchased at least 16 acres in Ujjain’s Sawarakhedhi and Dhediya from 2021. He also signed several land deals as a director on behalf of family company Shri Siddhivinayak Devcons Pvt Ltd.

SHALINI YADAV: Married Vaibhav in February 2024. During June-July 2025, she purchased over 10 acres in Gangedi.

NARAYAN YADAV: The patriarch of the Yadav family, Mohan Yadav’s elder brother

is known as “dada dayalu” in Ujjain. Narayan Yadav holds at least 19 acres in his name, as joint holdings with family, and through family company Sreyanvi Developers. Of this, at least 15 acres have been purchased since 2021.

REKHA YADAV: Narayan’s wife purchased at least 4 acres in Ujjain since 2021.

NANDLAL YADAV: Mohan Yadav’s other brother holds at least 17 acres. Of this, 13 acres were purchased in 2025.

KALAVATI YADAV: President of Ujjain municipality, Mohan Yadav’s sister holds at least 17 acres in Sawarakhedhi and Kasba Ujjain.

ABHAY YADAV: Narayan and Rekha’s son, Abhay describes himself on social media as a “social worker” who “ventures in mining” and “construction” and as “director at Shree Angareshwar Mahadev Stone Crusher” — a family firm registered in 2017. He is associated with multiple mining and realty companies and LLPs as director or partner. Records

show he purchased at least 16 acres in Ujjain in 2025 alone.

GOVIND YADAV: Govind aka Bablu Yadav is the son of Mohan Yadav’s first cousin — son of the CM’s uncle Shankarlal and aunt Annapurna Yadav. Considered the mastermind of the family’s realty business, Govind purchased at least 46.5 acres — himself or with sons Siddharth and Anant or his business partners — since 2024 in Ujjain.

In March 2024, Govind set up Shree NPGK LLP with Nemichand Jain, Kashiram Patidar and Pawan Bohra for “real estate activities”. Nemichand Jain also partnered with Abhay Yadav and together purchased plots worth over Rs 5 crore in Ujjain’s Karadiya-Nawakheda in 2024.

NILESH YADAV: Govind’s brother and Mohan Yadav’s first cousin, Nilesh runs at least two companies — Shri Annapurna Construction and Shree Annapurna Enterprises — with wife Sunita. Since 2024, Nilesh and Sunita have purchased at least 108 acres

in and around Ujjain, including at least 12 acres from Mohan Yadav’s Shri Siddhivinayak Devcons.

THE COMPANIES

SHRI SIDDHIVINAYAK DEVCONS: Mohan Yadav’s family company where Yadav and wife Seema hold 73% stake. Among other shareholders are sister Kalavati and brother Narayan Yadav. Son Vaibhav Yadav is the present director. The company holds at least 27.5 acres in prime locations of Kasba Ujjain, Dhediya, Daudkhedi and Sawarakhedhi, including at least 2.6 acres purchased during 2024-25.

SHRI ANNAPURNA CONSTRUCTION, SHREE ANNAPURNA ENTERPRISES: Named after Nilesh Yadav’s mother -- Mohan Yadav’s aunt. Uses the Yadav family’s Abdalpura address. Signatories are Nilesh and wife Sunita. In 2024, the companies purchased 22 plots adding up to 4.7 acres in Nanakheda and Chandesari. Since October

2024, four new housing schemes have been registered in Ujjain under the Sawariya brand through Shri Annapurna Construction with Madhya Pradesh RERA.

SHRIVENKTESH DEVBUILD LLP: Set up in November 2023 with Abhay Yadav and local traders as partners. In July 2025, the company purchased 74 acres in Ujjain’s Karondiya.

SREYANVI DEVELOPERS: Among the signatories for a 2022 land deal in Ujjain’s Lalpur were Mohan Yadav’s brother Narayan, his wife Rekha and their son Abhay Yadav.

MANGALMURTI INFRA: Uses the Yadav family’s Ujjain address — 180, Abdalpura — as declared by Mohan Yadav on mp.bjp.org and Narayan Yadav in an application for amending the environmental clearance for a quarry in Kasuni, Ujjain. In April 2023, days before the new Ujjain Master Plan announced land use change, the company bought over 20 acres in Ujjain’s Sawarakhedhi.

Ujjain primed for urban renewal with a flurry of road and other projects

Number of property registration surges with strong investor interest in plots along high-value highway corridors and urban expansion zones

Jay Mazoomdaar
Ujjain, New Delhi, June 22

WITH SIMHASTHA Kumbh 2028 on the horizon, Ujjain is witnessing an accelerated push in road infrastructure and urban development, with several highway projects entering execution and long-term policy measures on new housing and satellite townships beginning to take shape on the ground.

On the back of multiple projects moving from planning to execution, the city is entering a high-investment phase — both public and private. Land prices are going up across Ujjain. Areas along key highway corridors and urban expansion zones are witnessing higher valuations and strong investor interest.

Sources in the revenue department said that Indore and Ujjain recorded a major surge in property registrations in 2024. Local real estate players say the combination of infrastructure upgrades and favourable policies under the new masterplan is likely to sustain upward pressure on land prices in the run-up to 2028.

While chief minister Mohan Yadav has announced several road projects in and around the holy city, Ujjain District Collector Roushan Singh listed “over half a dozen” highway projects — new construction or lane expansion — to improve connectivity to Garoth, Jhalawar, Nagda, Badnagar, Indore and Bhopal.

“Another 15-20 internal road widening works are lined up,” he said, without providing specific coordinates of the projects. To get a sense of the scale of the development works, *The Indian Express* gleaned details available in public records and spoke to a number of state officials on the ground.

The major highway projects — either greenfield or expansion — in and around Ujjain are Ujjain–Jhalawar 4-laning up-

grade, Ujjain–Garoth greenfield corridor, Ujjain–Nagda 6-laning upgrade, Ujjain–Jaora greenfield highway, Ujjain–Indore 6-laning, Ujjain–Badnagar 4-laning, Ujjain–Dewas-Bhopal expansion, and Ujjain–Maksi 4-laning upgrade.

The four-lane upgrade of the Ujjain–Jhalawar corridor has moved into the construction phase and is expected to improve connectivity with Rajasthan and reduce travel time for both freight and pilgrimage traffic. Work has begun for the upgradation of the Ujjain–Nagda road, which connects major industrial clusters in the region. While a six-lane expansion is yet to be finalised, capacity augmentation is being taken up in phases to cater to rising traffic.

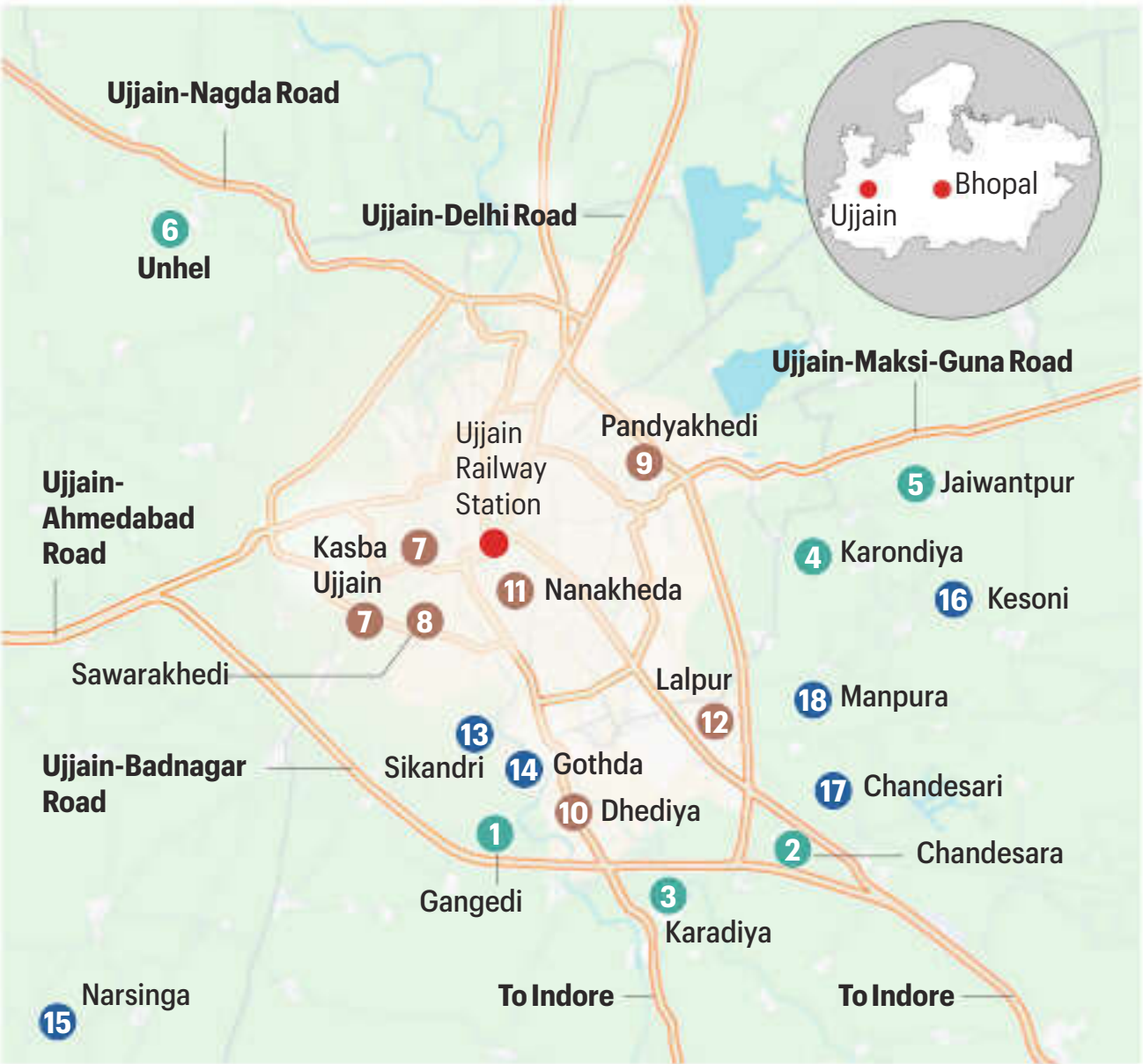
The Ujjain–Jaora greenfield highway, planned to link with the Delhi–Mumbai Expressway, has entered the land acquisition stage. However, resistance from farmers over compensation has emerged as a challenge, raising concerns over timelines.

A key regional link, the proposed Ujjain–Garoth greenfield highway (NH-148NG) is still in the early stages, with land acquisition and statutory clearances underway in parts.

Connectivity on existing corridors has also improved. The Ujjain–Indore route, among the busiest in the region, is now largely six-laned and fully operational as a key economic link. The Ujjain–Badnagar road is also undergoing four-lane expansion, with most stretches completed and the remaining sections nearing completion.

The Ujjain–Bhopal route via Dewas is operational but is being widened in phases to handle increasing traffic, particularly during peak pilgrimage periods. In addition, a four-lane project on the Ujjain–Maksi road has been sanctioned and is expected to enter the construction phase soon.

WHY YADAV FAMILY LAND IS PRIME REAL ESTATE



168 ACRES SINCE DECEMBER 2023		
NEAR NEW ROAD LINKS, HIGHWAYS	NEW LAND USE ZONES	OTHER KEY AREAS
111 ACRES Gangedi, Karadiya, Chandesara, Karondiya, Jaiwantpur, Unhel	37 ACRES Pandyakhedi, Dhediya, Nanakheda, Sawarakhedhi, Kasba Ujjain	20 ACRES Gothda, Sikandri, Kesoni, Chandesari, Narsinga

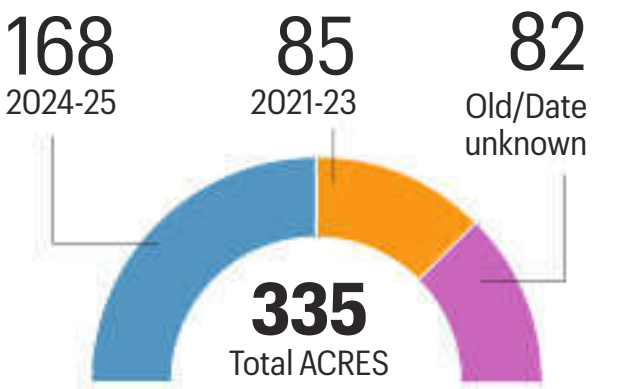
SOURCE: MP LAND RECORDS

Within the city, major arterial routes, including Indore Road, Dewas Road, Agar Road and Nagda Road, are being upgraded. The works focus on expanding carriageways, redesigning junctions and easing congestion along routes leading to key temples and ghats.

Other major focus areas are development of major ghats — such as Triveni and Mangalnath — along the 30-km Shipra riverfront, critical infrastructure including more than 14 river bridges and flyovers, 30-km Kanh diversion project to channel polluted water, sewage treatment upgrades,

and dedicated development zones such as a 1,100-acre industrial township called Vikram Udyogpuri. Also on the cards are a Medical City, an IT Park, a Science City with a planetarium.

These projects are being implemented alongside the Ujjain Master Plan 2035, which lays out a framework for the city’s expansion — development of new residential and mixed-use zones, and creation of satellite townships to reduce pressure on the city’s historic core. Some proposals, including a township near Ujjain’s Sawarakhedhi, have been revised under public pressure in



NEAR NEW ROAD LINKS (in acres)			
	2024-25	2021-23	Total
1. Gangedi	50.5	0	50.5
2. Chandesara	8.8	9	17.8
3. Karadiya	9	8	17
4. Karondiya	8	2	10
5. Jaiwantpur	6.3	0	6.3
6. Unhel	29	0	29
Total	111	19	130

IN NEW LAND USE ZONES (in acres)			
	2024-25	2021-23	Total
7. Kasba Ujjain	1.5	0.2	1.7
8. Sawarakhedhi	1	41.8	42.8
9. Pandyakhedi	18	0	18
10. Dhediya	12.1	2	14.1
11. Nanakheda	4	14	18
12. Lalpur	0	7	7
Total	37	65	102

OTHER KEY AREAS (in acres)			
	2024-25	2021-23	Total
13. Sikandri	4.1	0	4.1
14. Gothda	0.9	0	0.9
15. Narsinga	13	0	13
16. Kesoni	1.2	0	1.2
17. Chandesari	0.7	0	0.7
18. Manpura	0	1.3	1.3
Total	20	1.3	21.3
Old/undated holdings	0	0	82

view of Simhastha-related requirements.

Transport infrastructure remains a central focus of the plan, with proposals for new bypasses, improved regional connectivity and a multimodal transport hub integrating rail and bus systems. Transit-oriented development corridors are also on the cards.

However, certain challenges remain. Land acquisition and compensation disputes, particularly for greenfield projects, continue to pose hurdles. Timelines for some corridors also depend on funding approvals and regulatory clearances.

[FROM PAGE 1]

CM’s cousins turn land bank into housing projects

Within months, between July 2024 and September 2025, they handed over these plots to Indore-based Shanti Mahalok Builders in five tranches for development.

One set of plots was transferred to the builder under the agreement that Shanti Mahalok would have to develop the project at its own risk and cost in 24 months and hand over 67.8 per cent of the developed property, including dwelling units, to Govind Yadav and partners to sell or utilise independently.

The other parcels were also transferred under similar agreements but with a 60:40 ratio of ownership of the developed project between the land owner and the builder.

Asked about the two deals, Govind Yadav’s son Anant Yadav said: “Our agreement with the builder is based purely on the appreciating value of the land and the fixed cost of development.”

On the ownership of land in Ujjain’s Gangedi, he said: “My father (Govind) is not the sole owner. He has six-seven private business partners. Though registered in 2023, the land purchase agreements date back to 2020 when he (Mohan Yadav) was not even a minister. The highway work in question was cleared back in 2019. The land is not on the highway but 100m away.”

Shanti Mahalok co-owner Mehul Mehta declined to comment.

Mohan Yadav’s other cousin Nilesh Yadav, on the other hand, is developing a number of realty projects under the Sawariya brand name. Since October 2024, he has registered four new housing schemes through Shri Annapurna Construction in Ujjain with Madhya Pradesh RERA.



These are:
OCTOBER 2024: Shri Sawariya Dham in Karadiya on 7.5 acres bought in July 2023,
DECEMBER 2024: Sawariya Dreams in Chandesara on 5 acres purchased in October 2023,

SEPTEMBER 2025: Sawariya Green in Dhediya on 12.13 acres acquired from Shri Siddhivinayak Devcons in September 2024

NOVEMBER 2025: Shree Sawariya Residency in Nanakheda on 3.7 acres purchased in June 2024.

Responding on behalf of uncle Nilesh, Anant Yadav said: “Our family has been in realty business since 2010 when my father developed a 100-bigha property in Ujjain. My uncle has various Sawariya housing projects. As private individuals, we have every right to buy, develop or sell any private land. Should we shut down just because the CM happens to be from the family?”

Govind, alias Bablu Yadav, and his younger brother Nilesh are sons of Mohan Yadav’s uncle Shankarlal and aunt Annapurna Yadav. Together, the brothers have spearheaded the Yadav family’s land-purchasing drive since late 2023 — around the time Mohan Yadav became chief minister. Govind has purchased at least 46 acres — either on his own or with his sons Siddharth and Anant, or with business partners Nemichand Jain, Kashiram Patidar and Pawan Bohra — in and around Ujjain since 2024.

Nilesh runs at least two companies — Shri Annapurna Construction and Shree Annapurna Enterprises — with wife Sunita. Since 2024, they have purchased at least 78 acres in and around Ujjain.

[FROM PAGE 1]

‘Should we shut down just because the CM happens to be from the family?’

every right to buy, develop or sell any private land. Should we shut down just because the CM happens to be from the family?”

On the project in Ujjain’s Gangedi, he said: “My father (Govind) is not the sole owner. He has six-seven private business partners. Though registered in 2023, the land purchase agreements date back to 2020 when he (Mohan Yadav) was not even a minister. The highway expansion work in question was cleared back in 2019. The land is 100m from the highway.”



Anant Yadav

Speaking over phone, Mohan Yadav’s elder brother Narayan Yadav, when asked about the land holdings, told *The Indian Express* that the ongoing development work in and around Ujjain will not only benefit the holy city but the “entire nation in days to come.”

Family land holding in Ujjain doubled since 2023

government has announced multiple new road links and highways in these very areas, which, local realtors said, would boost their value in future.

Likewise, they say, land use changes opened agricultural areas to residential or commercial development, making these plots lucrative for early investment.

Two, Yadav’s family purchases since December 2023 swelled their land bank that existed even before Yadav became CM. The Yadav family, which includes Mohan Yadav’s son Vaibhav and sister Kalavati, owned at least 108 plots measuring 179 acres in and around Ujjain, of which at least 85 acres were purchased for Rs 30 crore during 2021-2023 when Yadav was Education minister, *The Indian Express* has found.

But it was after Mohan Yadav was sworn in as CM that the family went on a land-purchase overdrive.

Since December 13, 2023, when he became the CM, till December-end 2025, his family and their real estate companies have bought at least 137 plots, adding to over 168 acres. Of this, 12 acres were internal transfers within the Yadav family.

While Mohan Yadav did not respond to multiple requests for comment, a senior state government official said it was not appropriate to link the business or land dealings of the Chief Minister’s family with the Chief Minister and his office.

In 2025, even as the Madhya Pradesh government grappled with strong local re-

Political rivals claimed Yadav influenced Ujjain master plan by changing land use in areas where his family had large holdings

sistance to its proposal for pooling farmland to build permanent Kumbh infrastructure in Ujjain, Yadav’s family and their companies purchased at least 62 plots spanning 92 acres.

In Ujjain, CM Yadav himself owns at least 17 acres directly, which he declared as inheritance (4 acres) and purchases (13 acres in 1998) in his 2023 asset declaration. His wife Seema Yadav owns at least 10.6 acres directly, which were declared as purchases (2008-10) in Mohan Yadav’s 2023 asset declaration.

Mohan and Seema Yadav owned at least another 39.5 acres through Shri Siddhivinayak Devcons Pvt Ltd, a family company where they together hold 73% stake. Of this, 12 acres were sold to first cousin Nilesh Yadav in September 2024. Shri Siddhivinayak Devcons purchased at least three plots (2.6 acres) during 2024-2025.

Plots next to new roads

The Indian Express spoke with local officials and mapped Yadav family’s new acquisitions. The trends are telling:

- Of the 168 acres purchased by the family since Yadav became the CM, 111 acres are next to one of the road development projects in and around Ujjain announced by Yadav. Roushan Singh, Ujjain District Collector, listed “over half a dozen” highway projects — new construction or lane expansion — to improve connectivity to Garoth, Jhalawar, Nagda, Badnagar, Indore and Bhopal. “Another 15-20 internal road widening works are lined up,” he said, without providing specific coordinates of the projects.

- In Gangedi, strategically located close to the junction of the upgraded Ujjain-Badnagar and Ujjain-Indore highways, the family purchased at least 51 acres in 38 plots in multiple deals since April 2024.

- In the Karadiya-Nawakheda area, around 9 acres were bought on the other side of this highway crossing in October 2024.

- In Karondiya, around 8 acres were picked up close to the Panchkoshi Parikrama Marg under development between Nagziri and Undasa in July 2025.

- In Jaiwantpur, on the southern side of the Ujjain-Maksi road which is being four-laned, six acres were purchased in 12 plots during 2024-25.

- In Chandesara, strategically located between two Indore-Ujjain highways, around 9 acres were purchased last February.

- In Unhel, on both sides of the new Ujjain-Nagda highway, at least 29 acres were picked up in 16 plots last May.

15 DEAD IN FIRE AT LUCKNOW ANIMATION TRAINING STUDIO

No exit, no ventilation turned building into tinderbox

Bhupendra Pandey
Lucknow, June 22

STORED MATERIAL that caught fire, a biometric door that got locked, and the lack of ventilation are among key reasons that led to 15 casualties in Monday's Lucknow blaze.

Survivors said commodities stored on the first floor, which was being used as a warehouse, fuelled the flames. Officials are probing whether the building had any fire extinguishers.

Departments responsible for monitoring such commercial operations include the Lucknow Development Authority (LDA), the Fire Services Department, and the Power Department.

The building is located in Sector D, Aliganj, a residential area. The LDA is responsible for checking whether commercial activity is being run from a building in a residential zone.

The LDA, Fire Services, and the Power Department have yet to confirm whether the building had the requisite NOC for fire safety, had undergone annual fire audits, possessed approved construction maps, or had its electrical wiring and equipment inspected. LDA Vice-Chairman Prathamesh Kumar, Director General (Fire Services) Sujeet Pandey, and Madhyanchal Vidyut Vitran Nigam Ltd Managing Director Riya Kejriwal did not respond to calls and messages seeking a comment.

According to officials, firefighters had no access to enter the building and had to break a side wall after reaching the terrace of the adjoining house to begin the rescue operation. It took another hour for constables to use sledgehammers to make two holes in the wall to enter the building, since the front was engulfed in flames.

The only entrance to the building was a narrow staircase, which also served as the sole exit. There was no emergency exit on any floor, and no ventilation was found in any of the halls or rooms, officials said.

The biggest trap for the vic-



Rescue personnel douse the flames at the site in Lucknow's Aliganj on Monday. VISHAL SRIVASTAV

CM announces 2-member SIT

Lucknow: Uttar Pradesh Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath on Monday directed to constitute a two-member Special Investigation Team (SIT) to probe the fire tragedy in Lucknow's Aliganj area.

The SIT comprises Additional Chief Secretary (Tourism, Culture and Religious Affairs) Amrit Abhijat and Lucknow Zone Additional Director General of Police (ADGP) Praveen Kumar.

The decision was taken after a meeting attended by the Chief Secretary, Additional Chief Secretary (Home Affairs), DGP and other senior officers, it is learnt.

tims was that entry to the studios was through biometric access, which got locked after the fire



Yogi Adityanath inspects the site of the tragedy, on Monday. ANI

The SIT has been directed to submit its report within seven days and probe the reasons behind the fire and negligence on part of the departments concerned. — PTI/INPUTS

broke out, officials said. There was also a lock on the terrace door.

A frantic call, then screams: How the blaze unfolded

Manish Sahu
Lucknow, June 22

AT 2.35 pm, Ravindra Kumar, 26, a medical practitioner, received a frantic phone call from his friend, Ashutosh Saxena — he was inside a building in Lucknow's Aliganj when a fire broke out that killed 15 people.

"I was 2 km away and rushed to the spot. There was panic and confusion... Ashutosh managed to escape, but he told me the fire was spreading rapidly," recalled Kumar.

"People trapped inside were shouting for help... I could also hear the cries of animals from within the building," he added.

The building housed a pet clinic and shop on the basement, ground and first floors. A graphics animation centre and



Rescue personnel had to make two big holes in an adjoining building to enter the structure that was engulfed in flames. ANI

a library were on the second floor.

As reports emerged that the fire was severe, senior police, administrative and government officials hurried to the scene to oversee the response. Among those who rushed the site were

Demolition order issued against building in 2016, later withdrawn

Express News Service
Lucknow, June 22

THE BUILDING in Aliganj where fire claimed 15 lives on Monday had faced demolition proceedings a decade ago for alleged unauthorised construction, according to records of the Lucknow Development Authority (LDA), officials said.

The demolition order, however, was withdrawn less than two months after it was issued.

Officials said the property, MS/102/D in Sector D of the Aliganj Scheme, was originally allotted to Vijay Kumar under the LDA's hire-purchase scheme through a lottery on July 11, 1980. Following execution of the agreement in November 1980, possession of the property was handed over to the allottee.

The property was later registered in the names of Vijay Kumar and his wife Usha



A rescue personnel holds a cat that was injured in the fire. PTI

through a sale deed in 2005. On January 19, 2013, the couple sold the property to Virendra Pratap Shukla and Surendra Pratap Shukla, after which the LDA carried out mutation in their favour on August 7, 2014.

Officials said the 1,992 sq ft plot was granted approval for a residential building plan on August 20, 2014, under the

authority's self-certification scheme.

Subsequently, the LDA found alleged unauthorised construction at the site and registered a case against Virendra Pratap Shukla. After examining the matter, the competent authority passed a demolition order on May 10, 2016.

Records show, however, that the demolition order was set aside on July 5, 2016, less than two months later. Officials did not specify the reasons behind the withdrawal of the order.

The building's regulatory history and compliance status have come under focus in the wake of Monday's fire. Officials said relevant records relating to approvals, ownership changes and enforcement actions are being reviewed as part of the ongoing examination following the incident.

Thick black smoke and flames engulfed large sections of the building. Videos recorded by bystanders showed people leaping from the upper floors in a desperate attempt to escape.

Virendra Saxena, a local resident present at the spot, described how cries for help echoed from inside while rescuers searched for survivors.

To speed up rescue operations, emergency teams broke a section of the boundary wall surrounding the premises.

A fire department official said more than a dozen fire tenders were deployed, including a hydraulic platform vehicle used to reach the upper sections of the building. Officials also established a security perimeter around the area, cordoning off nearly half a kilometre around

the affected building to facilitate rescue and firefighting operations. Traffic was halted, and no vehicles were allowed to enter the narrow lane in Sector D of Aliganj where the building is located. Around 5.30 pm, the fire was brought under control.

A senior police official said preliminary findings suggest that the fire broke out on the second floor of the building before spreading rapidly. "From the information gathered so far, it appears that some of the victims, unable to find a safe way out, took shelter inside a washroom," the officer said.

Officials said the exact cause remains under investigation. Police are also piecing together the sequence of events that unfolded in the crucial minutes after the fire broke out.

EXPRESS special

Shivakumar's first big challenge: Farmers stir, Opp lends support against township project

Akram M
Byramangala, Bengaluru Rural, June 22

FARMERS CHANDRA Reddy and Ashwath Reddy are neighbours in Kempayyana Palya village, near Bidadi in Bengaluru South district. Around 10 days ago, both received final notices from the Greater Bengaluru Development Authority for their land, being sought for the Greater Bengaluru Integrated Township (GBIT) Project — a 9,000-acre, 20-year-old plan, which now has the weight of Chief Minister D K Shivakumar behind it.

Chandra, 60, is happy about the acquisition of his 2.5-acre land, in exchange for development rights on the land acquired. But Ashwath, who owns four acres, has said no. "They tried giving the offer. I declined," he said. However, with Shivakumar taking over the top post recently, Ashwath feels his options are closing.

On June 12, over a week after he replaced Siddaramaiah as CM, Shivakumar issued the



One of the plots marked for acquisition in Bannigiri village in Ramanagara district of Karnataka. AKRAM M

order for the final acquisition of 499 acres — across Kempayyana Palya, Vaderahalli and Mandalahalli villages — for GBIT. The order asked landholders to raise objections if any within 30 days.

The Opposition BJP and JD(S) are supporting the protesting farmers, while several of those affected by the project have written to Congress MP Rahul Gandhi — posing the first major administrative challenge to the new CM.

The project

Earlier called the Bidadi Integrated Township, the project

was proposed in October 2006 by the then JD(S)-BJP coalition government as a housing solution for the fast-growing Bengaluru city. The CM then was JD(S) leader H D Kumaraswamy. He floated a global tender to develop the region under the PPP model. DLF emerged as a development partner in 2007, but withdrew following the global economic crisis of 2008-09.

By 2011, the project was in abeyance as the government awaited amendments by the Central government led by the UPA to the land acquisition Act.

In 2016, the land under which the project was expected to come up was renamed the Greater Bengaluru Bidadi Smart City Local Project Area, and a planning authority was formed. Karnataka then had a BJP government, led by B S Yediyurappa.

In March 2023, the Congress came to power. Months later, in November 2023, the Greater Bengaluru Bidadi Smart City Project Authority was upgraded to Greater Bengaluru Development Authority. Shivakumar, then Deputy CM in the Congress government, with Bengaluru seen as his turf, soon adopted the plan as a pet project, pitching GBIT as an AI city.

In March last year, the government issued the primary notification to acquire 7,481 acres across nine villages — Aralalusandra, Bannigiri, Byramangala, K G Gollaparapalya, Hosur, Mandalahalli, Kempayyana Palya, Kanchugaranahalli and parts of Vaderahalli.

Ever since the March 2023 notification, farmer groups have been holding protests against the project. Umesh, a

farmer from Bannigiri, asks why there are two sets of rules for them and Shivakumar's own constituency. "At Kanakapura, the CM tells his constituents not to sell their land, to do agriculture, animal husbandry and sericulture... If they are children of farmers, are we not?" Umesh says.

On Sunday, the JD(S) began a padyatra across the affected villages, led by its Youth Wing president Nikhil Kumaraswamy. The party calls the project a "massive real estate deal", with around Rs 33,000 crore profits envisaged after acquiring land for around Rs 2.5 crore per acre. "Why has Shivakumar made this project a matter of prestige and is doing injustice to farmers?" Nikhil said.

BJP state president B Y Vijayendra said fertile land is being taken over. "The CM is doing real estate work."

Shivakumar has countered that the project has been appreciated by PM Narendra Modi, among others, and accused the BJP and JD(S) of attempting to "stop development" in the state.

Tamil Nadu NEET aspirants' suicides trigger louder calls for state to be exempted

Arun Janardhanan
Chennai, June 22

TOP STATE government officials and police have confirmed the suicides of three NEET aspirants in Tamil Nadu over the four days before the June 21 re-examination, deepening political anger in the state over the national medical entrance test.

The deaths were reported from Salem, Dharmapuri and Krishnagiri districts. Police have identified three of the students as S Gopika, 19, of Vellalapuram near Edappadi in Salem district; R Roshini, 19, of Endapatti near Palacode in Dharmapuri district; and C Vetri Anandan, also reported as Vetriyanantham, 20, of Bagalur Road near Hosur in Krishnagiri district.

The Indian Express has previously reported that at least 12 NEET aspirants had died by suicide in different parts of the country since May 3.

Gopika's relatives said her father worked in a salon as a daily wage worker. She had appeared for NEET three times. According to a senior police officer, she had earlier told her father that she was under severe stress because of the growing difficulty of preparing for the exam, and that the announcement of the re-test had increased her anxiety.

In Dharmapuri, Roshini had studied at a coaching centre in Namakkal before returning home two months ago to continue preparations. Police said her father returned home on Saturday evening and found her dead. Police said they were investigating the case.

In Krishnagiri, Vetri Anandan had been preparing from home after failing to clear the exam in earlier attempts and had appeared again on May 3. Police sources said he believed he had done well but became frustrated after the exam was cancelled. On Saturday after-

Bihar: 'Dummy candidate' racket busted, 30 held

Patna: Police in Bihar said on Monday they had uncovered an alleged impersonation racket during the NEET re-examination in Lakhisarai district, leading to the arrest of 30 people, including purported dummy candidates, alleged facilitators and those involved with biometric verification.

During the re-test on June 21, authorities received information that attempts were being made at certain centres to seat "fake/scholar/dummy candidates" in place of genuine aspirants. The investigation led to action at three of the four centres in the district where police apprehended several individuals allegedly linked to the operation.

Police alleged that dummy candidates were allowed to enter examination halls and appear in place of actual candidates with the "facilitation and cooperation" of biometric personnel deployed at the centres. ENS

noon, he died by suicide at home.

The deaths have triggered sharp criticism from political parties in Tamil Nadu. The DMK students' wing said it would hold a protest on Tuesday, accusing the BJP government at the Centre of being responsible for the continuing distress around NEET. PMK leader Anbumani Ramadoss said the deaths showed that NEET should either be abolished across India or, at least, Tamil Nadu should be exempted. VCK chief Thol Thirumavalavan urged the Tamil Nadu government to take legal steps to secure an exemption for the state.

Soon, puncture repair facilities along national highways, e-ways

Dheeraj Mishra
New Delhi, June 22

ONE PROBLEM that people travelling through highways and expressways face is hunting for a mechanic if their vehicle suffer a breakdown mid-journey.

To fix such situations, national expressways and highways in the country will soon get puncture-repair services and vehicle-repair shops at dedicated spaces along the roads.

National Highways Logistics Management Limited has recently directed its field offices to prioritise the establishment of vehicle-repair shops and puncture repair facilities at the Wayside Amenities (WSAs). Built along national highways and expressways, WSAs provide a range of amenities such as restaurants and washrooms.

"... a larger number of vehicle and puncture repair services are required... which will enable users in availing timely mechanical assistance, avoiding inconvenience, delays, and potential safety concerns," said an NHAI official.

ceived regarding tampering with the RPSC recruitment portal in the 2024 exam.

According to officials, against 24 vacancies, there were 78 candidates in the provisional list issued in July 2025; the 24 included one vacancy under the ST category. Here, six ST candidates had made it to the provisional list against that one vacancy.

To improve his chances, Rahul Meena, who was second on this ST list, withdrew the application of Ashish Meena, the first candidate just above him in the merit list. However, worried about raising suspicion, he withdrew two more names on the list, the 4th and 6th candidates.



Rahul Meena has been working in SAIL, Jharkhand, since 2019

Khan said that an SMS went to all the three candidates that their application has been withdrawn as per their request. "One of them, Ravi, then approached RPSC questioning how his application had been withdrawn when he did not do

so, and RSCP subsequently informed the Department of Information Technology and Communication (DoIT&C), which handles the RPSC recruitment portal," he said.

At the time the applications were withdrawn, the option to withdraw them was closed, officials say. Investigation revealed that the same Single Sign-On (SSO) ID was employed to withdraw all three applications; SSO is a unique Digital Identity issued by the Rajasthan government to every registered citizen, business, and government employee.

This SSO ID, allegedly a fake, was created in the name of one Rahul Sinha. Investiga-

tors found that the same IP address was used by applicant Rahul Meena to create his login credentials as well.

Further investigation revealed the IP address to be from the Steel Authority of India Limited (SAIL) compound in Jharkhand. "During investigation we found that Rahul Meena had been working in SAIL, Jharkhand, since 2019; this was the same place from where the applications were withdrawn," DSP Khan said.

Once it was confirmed that Rahul is the person they've been looking for, investigators went looking for him in his hometown Dausa. To nab Meena, a police constable then

called up his brother pretending to be from a courier service, telling him that the courier will be returned unless Rahul's exact address is shared. Once the police had Rahul's address, a team went and caught him.

"During questioning, Rahul said that he had completed his BTech in Mining Engineering from Banaras Hindu University and has been working with SAIL in Jharkhand since 2019. He said that in his free time, he had a hobby of crawling sites on 'inspection mode'," the DSP said. Rahul allegedly employed AI chatbots including ChatGPT, Grok, Deepseek, etc. to try and change the coding of websites.

New Delhi

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If there are questions of current or contemporary relevance that you would like explained, please write to explained@indianexpress.com

ENVIRONMENT

ESA for Western Ghats: Why conservation is key



NIKHIL GHANEKAR

THE WESTERN Ghats, a 1,500-km long chain of largely unbroken mountains which fringes off the western coast of India, is one of the country's most famous natural ecosystems, next only to the Himalayas. Unlike the Himalayas, the Western Ghats are densely populated and have been an economic hub for states abutting India's west coast, and is home to famous cash crops.

A special regime of legal protection, conservation, and sustainable development prescribed for this fragile ecosystem has been hanging fire due to objections and concerns of the six state governments — Gujarat, Maharashtra, Goa, Karnataka, Kerala, and Tamil Nadu — where the Ghats extend.

Separate protections for the Ghats region were initially prescribed by the famous Madhav Gadgil-led expert panel, and later by a high-level working group, chaired by former Indian Space Research Organisation chief K Kasturirangan.

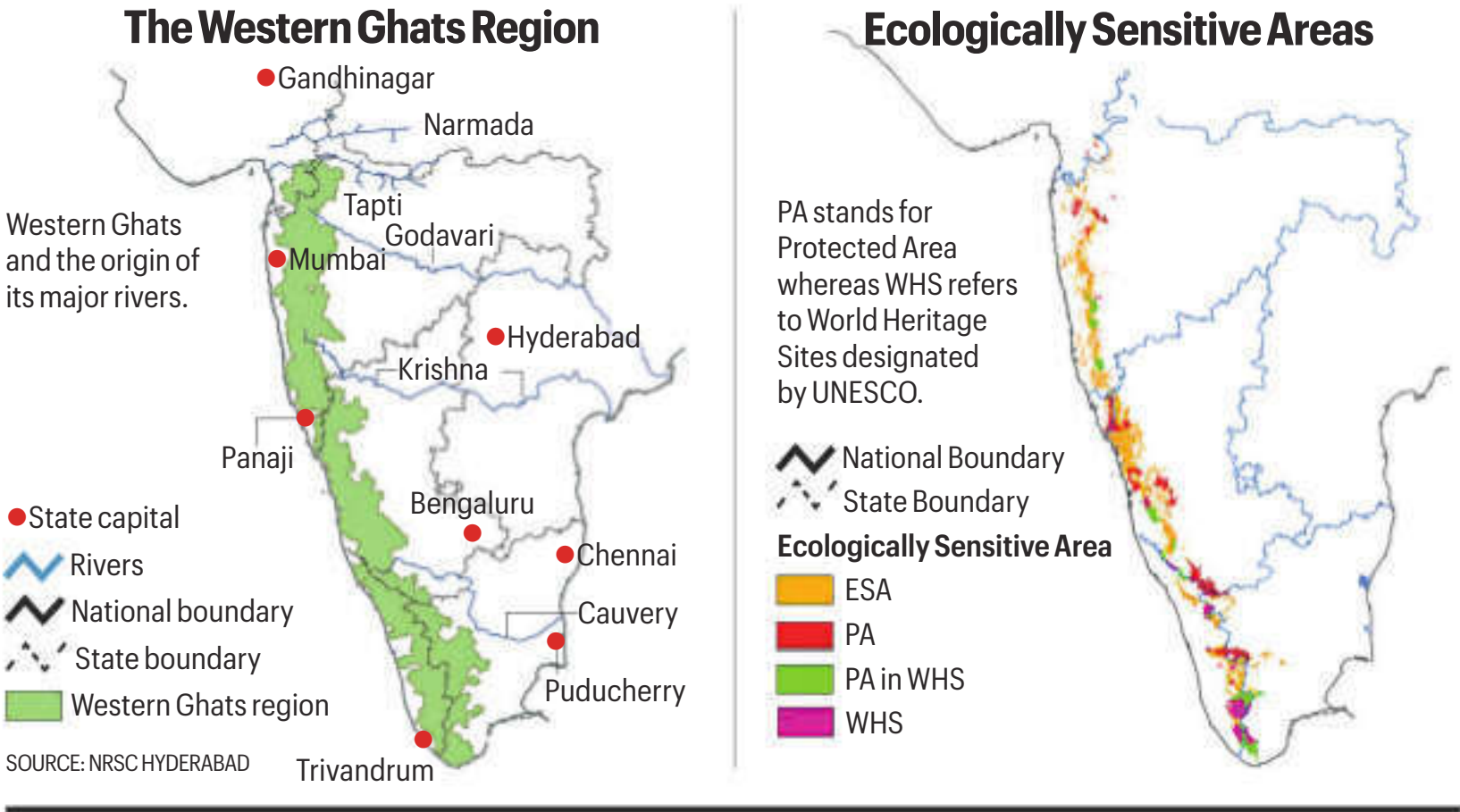
It is in this backdrop of the Kasturirangan panel's 2013 report that the Centre demarcated 56,825 sq km as ecologically sensitive area (ESA) in a draft notification. With a lack of consensus that continued till 2022, the Centre constituted a fresh expert committee with the task of re-examining the objections by the six states, keeping the Ghats' conservation and needs of the region in mind.

The story so far

The Kasturirangan panel's report identified an area of 1,64,280 sq km, whereas the Gadgil panel identified 1,29,037 sq km as the Ghats's extent. Compared with the Gadgil panel — which recommended that the entire area be designated as ESA with heavy cross-sectoral restrictions — the Kasturirangan panel adopted a different approach.

Its analysis found that 60% of the Ghats region was already under "cultural landscape", which was human dominated and where land was under settlements, plantations, or agriculture. The remaining 40% — 60,000 sq km — was classified as "natural landscape", a high biological richness,

THE EXTENT OF DEMARCATION



low fragmentation, low population density, and inclusive of national parks, and tiger and elephant habitats.

The panel proposed that this 60,000 sq km be notified as ESA along with a ban on mining, quarrying, red category polluting industries, thermal power plants, and large constructions and townships. In the past, ESAs have been notified in Dahanu, Mahabaleshwar-Panchgani, and Doon valley taking into account the area's biological diversity and need to regulate activities.

The then United Progressive Alliance government accepted these recommendations in-principle. But on the back of concerns raised by state governments on wide restrictions on industries, it asked the six states time to submit their views before finalising the ESA boundaries in December 2013.

Later, in March 2014, the Centre also issued a draft notification, demarcating 56,825.7 sq km as ESA. The area was reduced by over 3,000 sq km on account of Kerala's submission, based on their own ground truthing exercise, that sought omission of several agricultural areas, orchards, horticultural plots, plantation and residential areas outside the remit of ESA.

Six iterations of the draft notification have been issued since 2014, with the latest one issued on July 31, 2024, and valid until the end of July 2026. The latest notification

Biodiversity hotspot

The Ghats are home to nearly 2,000 species of plants, 84 species of fish, 87 species of amphibians, 89 species of reptiles, 15 bird species, and 12 mammals, which are endemic or only found there.

There are 61 protected areas — national parks or sanctuaries — notified in the region.

made a subtle but crucial deviation from the past ones, and inserted a provision proposing to finalise or publish ESA demarcation in either a phased, state-wise manner, or through a combined notification. This was done ostensibly to not hold back ESA declaration in states where a consensus with states is around the corner.

After each round of re-notification, the Environment Ministry has attempted to get state governments to sign-off on the final ESA extent, only to be pegged back by either fresh demands, or deadlock over unresolved disputes.

Inching towards partial resolution

The expert committee appointed in 2022, under Sanjay Kumar, former Director General of Forests, Environment Ministry, has held several meetings with state governments, and has undertaken field visits in all states except Kerala. Sources aware of developments said that some of the fundamental issues the committee has sought to resolve are reconciliation of village-level data, names, revenue details, based on satellite imagery, and information provided by state governments.

It has also considered formulations on providing some sort of financial incentives to the six states for protecting the Ghats, which could eventually be recommended in its final report to the Centre. The Kastu-

rirangan panel had recommended that the six states "should come together to negotiate for a grant-in aid" from the Centre in return for protecting natural resources. It also recommended some financial arrangement for payments for ecosystem services accruing from ESA and non-ESA regions with the Ghats.

Even as there has been progress on resolution, states have proposed further reduction in the ESA. It remains to be seen whether the expert committee will agree to the reductions in its final report.

Kerala and Karnataka remain the two states where consensus is not any closer. Karnataka has been steadfast in its total rejection of the Kasturirangan panel recommendations. Kerala, meanwhile, has sought to reduce the earlier 9,993.7 sq km area by another 1,000 sq km or so, arguing to omit villages from Idukki due to plantation, agriculture activities, especially in Cardamom Hills.

In Maharashtra, the state government has sought exclusion of 378 villages from the 2,133 notified in the draft notification, according to reliable sources. Sources said that the state has argued to omit villages for industries, mining, and because some villages are distant from ESAs.

Why the Ghats need protection

The Ghats find their formation in a combination of factors such as tectonic movements, volcanic eruptions, and years of erosion. The continuous mountain chain, with a break at Palakkad Gap, is a treasure trove of biodiversity, harbouring hundreds of plants and animals only found in this region, and is one of the eight "hot-test hotspots" of biological diversity.

Its landform influences the monsoon by acting as a physical barrier against moisture-carrying winds, giving bountiful rain on the coastal side of the Ghats. The abundant rain and dense forests also nurture springs, and give life to Godavari, Krishna, Cauvery, Periyar, and numerous other rivers, which drive economic growth and sustain livelihood.

Moreover, this region is not sparsely populated and has historically seen plantations and cultivation of pepper, cardamom, cinnamon, mango, and jackfruit. This necessitates conservation of the region from polluting industries.

Kerala has seen civil society protests arguing for more protection and omission of villages from ESAs. Similar protests have also been seen in Goa, Karnataka, and Maharashtra.

HISTORY

Two Suhrawardys and a road: The row over Kolkata street name

Vikas Pathak

New Delhi, June 22

THE NEWLY elected BJP government in West Bengal has renamed Kolkata's Suhrawardy Avenue, a prominent arterial road in the city's heart, as Gopal Mukherjee Road, after "Gopal Patha", who is remembered for having organised the Hindu retaliation during the Calcutta riots of 1946.

Welcoming the announcement of the Kolkata Municipal Corporation, Chief Minister Suvenud Adhikari said, "For decades, a major artery of our City bore the name of someone who wilfully misused state power as a weapon, orchestrating the massacre of innocent citizens for sheer political gain. By renaming it after Shri Gopal Mukherjee, the fearless soul who stepped up as a protector-in-chief to defend and save thousands of innocent lives, finally restoration of historical justice will be achieved by honouring a true guardian and savior. It's time, West Bengal remembers, corrects and honours the Real Heroes."

While the CM's post seems to allude to Huseyn Shaheed Suhrawardy, the Prime

Minister of Bengal in 1946-47 when riots broke out in Calcutta, the road is named after his uncle, Hassan Suhrawardy.

Hassan Suhrawardy

The naming of the street is discussed in P Thankappan Nair's book *The History of Calcutta's Streets*. Hassan Suhrawardy was a renowned surgeon in the British Indian army who went on to become the first Muslim Vice Chancellor of the University of Calcutta. He served in that position from 1930 to 1934.

"The Corporation at its meeting held on Wednesday, March 8, 1933, christened the new (100 f.) road constructed by the C.I.T. from Park Circus to the junction of Kassi-para Lane (and lying to the north of the Park) on which stands the house of Sir Hassan Suhrawardy, Vice-Chancellor of the Calcutta University, as Suhrawardy Avenue," Nair's book says.

Born in 1884, Hassan Suhrawardy has many firsts to his credit — he was the first elected Deputy President of the Bengal Legislative Council, the first Indian consulting surgeon to the Medical College

The uncle, not the nephew

While the CM's post seems to allude to Huseyn Shaheed Suhrawardy, the PM of Bengal in 1946-47 when riots broke out in Calcutta, the road is named after his uncle, Hassan Suhrawardy.

Hassan Suhrawardy was a renowned surgeon in the British Indian army who went on to become the first Muslim Vice Chancellor of the University of Calcutta.

Hospitals, the first Indian Civil Surgeon of Howrah and the first Indian Chief Medical Officer of a State Railway in India and Burma.

Hassan Suhrawardy also wrote a book called *Calcutta and Environs* "to serve as a guide for visitors to Calcutta during the 8th session of the Indian Science Congress in 1921", says Nair. Hassan Suhrawardy died at 62 on September 18, 1946.

Huseyn Shaheed Suhrawardy

On May 16, 1946, the British Cabinet Mission plan proposed an interim government structure. On July 29, 1946, the Muslim League under Muhammad Ali Jinnah rejected the May 16 plan and called on Muslims to observe a "Direct Action Day" in protest on August 16.

"The Calcutta Riots of 1946, also known as the 'Great Calcutta Killing', were four days of massive Hindu-Muslim riots in the capital of Bengal, India, resulting in 5,000 to 10,000 dead, and some 15,000 wounded, between August 16 and 19, 1946," historian Claude Markovits says in his paper "The Calcutta Riots of 1946".

"The leader of the Muslim League in Bengal and Chief Minister of the province was Hussain Suhrawardy, a rival of Jinnah for the leadership of the League, a controversial, albeit colorful personality who became very unpopular amongst large sections of the Hindu population for his alleged responsibility in the great Bengal famine of 1943, which had resulted in the death of two to three million people. However, he was idolised by many Muslims in Bengal, particularly by the Urdu-speaking Muslims from Northern India, who formed the majority of Calcutta's Muslim population (Bengali Muslims, who accounted for the bulk of the Muslim population in the province, were mostly concentrated in the countryside)," Markovits further writes.

He offers details of the charges against Suhrawardy in pro-Congress accounts of the time: Suhrawardy "positioned himself with his cronies in the Police Control Room, and thus prevented the Police Commissioner, a British national who was technically in charge of law and order, from attending to the trouble with a free mind."

LAW

Right to walk on footpaths: Behind SC order, surge in pedestrian deaths

Dheeraj Mishra

New Delhi, June 22

THE SUPREME Court Friday recognised walking on demarcated footpaths as a fundamental right that shall override the privilege of a motor vehicle. The court also urged the government to introduce a law to bring this right into effect, which would be crucial to holding officials and departments accountable for addressing violations of pedestrian rights.

The genesis of the case lies in the death of a five-year-old boy, who was struck by a tanker while walking to school with his father.

Pedestrians are among the most vulnerable road users in India. The little space available to them is frequently encroached upon by two-wheelers or shops. Pedestrian deaths have more than doubled in 10 years and now account for the second highest road death share after two-wheeler fatalities.

An analysis by *The Indian Express* shows that while total road fatalities increased by 21.24% between 2015 and 2024, pedestrian deaths surged by nearly 163%, or 2.63 times. The number of pedestrians killed in road accidents rose from 13,894 in 2015 to 36,526 in 2024. Their share in total road fatalities also more than doubled, from 9.5% to 20.61% during the period. Pedestrian fatalities continued to rise even during the Covid-19 pandemic years (*see table*).

INDIA'S DEADLY ROADS

	Year	Total road deaths	Pedestrian deaths	Share (%)
	2015	1,46,133	13,894	9.5
	2016	15,0,785	15,746	10.5
	2017	1,47,913	20,457	13.8
	2018	1,51,417	22,656	15
	2019	1,51,113	25,858	17.1
	2020	1,31,714	23,483	17.8
	2021	1,53,972	29,124	18.9
	2022	1,68,491	32,825	19.48
	2023	1,72,890	35,221	20.37
2024	1,77,175	36,526	20.61	

SOURCE: ROAD ACCIDENT IN INDIA, MORTH NOTE: 2020 AND 2021 ARE COVID-19 YEARS

Right to walk

In its judgment, the SC traced the issue back to the most basic human activity — walking. The court highlighted the irony that while walking predates wheeled transport by millennia, road infrastructure today is overwhelmingly designed for vehicles.

It observed that the Motor Vehicles Act has, in many ways, undermined the rights of pedestrians.

The court went on to say that the absence of safe and comfortable footpaths, and their subjugation to motor transport, has been a "civilisational problem".

Piyush Tiwari, founder and CEO, SaveLIFE Foundation, said that the court has reversed the hierarchy over motorised vehicles, since pedestrians account for one in five road deaths in India. "For municipal bodies and road-owning agencies, a safe, unobstructed footpath is no longer discretionary; it is a constitutional duty wherever a road exists," he said.

Motor Vehicles Act

The court came down heavily on the Motor Vehicles Act, 1988, an exhaustive legislation governing the vehicles and rules of the road. The court said that the law is not for protecting the right to walk on footpaths and only lays down infrastructure for vehicles, which is its mainstay.

"The Motor Vehicles Act is built upon 'vehicle' as the subject of the legislation, while 'human' interests are incidental, which a motor vehicle must avoid violating — that's all, and no further," said the court.

In 2017, the Ministry of Road Transport and Highways notified the Motor Vehicles (Driving) Regulations, which says that drivers should take special precautions to ensure safety of vulnerable road users such as pedestrians, cyclists, children, etc.

The court, however, said that these regulations are just guiding principles and they neither recognise the fundamental right to walk on demarcated footpaths nor prioritise the right to footpath over a motorised road.

GLOBAL

Keir Starmer steps down as British PM, leader of Labour Party: What went wrong



EXPERT EXPLAINS

AMAN K PANDEY

RESEARCH ASSOCIATE, INDIAN COUNCIL OF WORLD AFFAIRS, NEW DELHI

TWO YEARS after routing the Conservatives, British Prime Minister Keir Starmer has resigned both as PM and leader of the Labour Party. His election in 2024 had brought Labour back to power after 14 years by winning 412 seats. This kind of resounding electoral majority was last seen in 1997, under the leadership of Tony Blair.

Although Starmer campaigned on the promise of "Change" to create a "fairer, healthier, and a more secure Britain", he

struggled to deliver and fell to the same post-Brexit malady that has troubled British politics and economy for a decade now.

A rocky start

Trouble began to brew in the very first 100 days of his government when he and some other Cabinet Ministers faced huge public backlash after being accused of accepting gifts and free tickets for football and concerts. Although Starmer reimbursed the costs and put in place strict donation rules, the damage was already done. Within two months of taking office, 43% of the electorate started seeing him unfavourably. By June 15, 2026, it went up to 73%.

His attempts to strengthen the National Health Service at the cost of cutting subsidies for winter fuel, his decision to release 1,700 prisoners before the completion of their sentence, and promised spending cuts of approximately \$8 billion for the next financial year were not received well among the public, party members, and MPs.

Another issue that brought him into



British PM Keir Starmer announces his resignation outside 10 Downing Street in London on Monday. AP

conflict with his own party MPs was his decision to continue with the "two-child benefit cap". The controversial policy, meant to limit child support for parents, was hugely unpopular in Britain and was abolished by Starmer only this April.

The Brexit conundrum

Starmer's resignation came a day before Britain observes 10 years of Brexit, its decision to exit the European Union (EU) following a public vote. A decade later, the mood has significantly changed.

Brexit supporters had mainly voted on issues of sovereignty, immigration, and economic prosperity. Today, however, Britain is still struggling. An estimated 2-8% contraction in economic growth, decreased revenue, high borrowing and tax hikes, a spectacular failure on non-EU immigration, struggling businesses, customs complications, and rampant inflation has made at least 57% of Britons think that the UK was wrong to leave the EU.

Although Labour supported the UK's

membership of the EU, Starmer's position has been a UK-EU "reset" without re-joining the bloc and thus, lacked the space for political manoeuvring — especially at a time when the Covid-19 pandemic and the wars in Ukraine and Iran further impacted the British economy.

A weakened duopoly

The one man who has gained the most out of Brexit is Nigel Farage and his Reform UK party. Farage, one of Brexit's prominent supporters, has gained considerable strength in recent years, mostly on his anti-immigration rhetoric. In doing so, he has managed to challenge the Conservative-Labour duopoly in British politics.

The collapse of Labour and the subsequent surge of Reform UK in recent local elections further weakened Starmer's position, prompting many in his own party to question his ability to govern.

Many Labour supporters have also flocked to the Green Party, which is also rising in popularity especially in the cities,

with its support for Palestinian rights and programmes to tax the rich.

A weakened Labour has also made the EU cautious. Brussels may wait and watch until 2029 before any new deals.

Deals abroad, troubles at home

Starmer's domestic failures were too stark to be compensated for his successes on the foreign policy front. He built a cordial relationship with US President Donald Trump (until the Iran War began), secured a favourable tariffs deal, and signed major trade deals with India, Australia, and New Zealand.

Last September, the Starmer-led government also sacked Peter Mandelson as ambassador to the US, saying that he had not disclosed the extent of his ties to convicted child sex offender Jeffrey Epstein.

The recent victory of Andy Burnham, the former mayor of Greater Manchester, in a parliamentary byelection further raised prospects of a leadership challenge. It became the final blow to Starmer's leadership, pushing him to step down.

As El Niño looms, guard against food inflation

THE SOUTHWEST monsoon is in serious deficit territory, with cumulative all-India rainfall this season (June-September) till June 22 being 42.8 per cent below the normal average for this period. Significantly, this is even before El Niño's impact is to really kick in. The deficit for now is being attributed mainly to weak monsoon winds in general. The monsoon arrived three days late over Kerala on June 4. After some initial progress, the onset pulse weakened, with stronger northwesterly dry winds suppressing the incoming monsoon currents and no active eastward-moving Madden-Julian Oscillation system carrying clouds and moisture. The monsoon, in fact, made no progress between June 15 and June 21, before showing signs of revival on Monday.

Rainfall being deficient in June isn't a good augury, as most global climate agencies are forecasting the current El Niño to intensify into a "strong" event towards August-September and "very strong" over October-January. In other words, one must expect no turnaround from a bad start and brace for the worst as El Niño gathers momentum. The last two strong-to-very strong El Niño events in 2023-24 and 2015-16 produced drought years. 2026-27 could turn out no different. The only consolation is that it comes after two consecutive good agriculture years: 2024-25 and 2025-26 saw farmers harvest bumper crops both in India and globally, with record outputs of wheat, rice, maize, sugar and even soyabean, rapeseed and palm oil. Not surprisingly, international food prices haven't followed the course of crude petroleum, natural gas, coal, fertilisers and metals. Their prices have all surged following the US-Israel war on Iran, whereas the abundant stocks from all-time-high production have prevented food inflation spikes — at least so far.

That might change. The worst of the West Asia conflict is over. But El Niño's effects will be felt not only during the ongoing kharif season, where sowing acreages are trailing for want of rain. El Niño is known to also raise temperatures. If this event peaks through October-January, it is the rabi (winter-spring) crops that will bear the brunt. That could, in turn, be a harbinger of future food inflation. The situation calls for deft planning and supply-side management. The government must keep the import window open, which is preferable to knee-jerk export bans/restrictions on farm produce as resorted to in the past. Simultaneously, there is a need to protect farmers against prevented/failed sowing or yield loss through expedited crop surveys and insurance payments. Last but not least, make VB-G RAM G a model rural employment programme in its launch year, from July 1.

A tough inheritance awaits Britain's next PM

WITH KEIR Starmer announcing his intention to resign, Britain is set to get its seventh prime minister in a decade. Coming in the midst of a political realignment, as a two-party system fragments into a five-party one, this raises a question: Is Britain ungovernable? On the one hand, there is Starmer's record in office, which has included a slew of policy U-turns and a pivot to the right that alienated much of Labour's traditional base. On the other hand, there are structural factors, such as the impacts of the 2008 financial crisis and Brexit, and the erosion of state capacity, that any PM might have struggled with. But beyond these lies declining public trust in, and heightened scrutiny of, the political class — doubtless exacerbated by Starmer's own failures such as the Peter Mandelson scandal — which has forced a prime minister out of office just two years after he was elected with a historic majority.

That is the circle Starmer's successor will have to square: To regain the trust of a public deeply divided over issues ranging from immigration, where resentment has boiled over into race riots, to welfare. And to do what Starmer consistently failed to do: Communicate a positive narrative of genuine achievements in governance — neither a sharp fall in net migration nor hitting a key target for NHS waiting times saved the PM. If former Greater Manchester mayor Andy Burnham, whose by-election victory triggered Starmer's exit, becomes Labour leader and PM, he will be significantly more popular than Starmer, opinion polls show. He will need to harness that goodwill to restore some measure of political stability and stem the ethnonationalist tide.

On the world stage, Starmer had been agile in dealing with Donald Trump and negotiated a trade deal with the US, but relations soured amid the war on Iran. His successor will have to navigate that volatile relationship as well as ties with Europe, both of which will be expecting Britain to maintain its security commitments — Defence Secretary John Healey's resignation this month over insufficient funding will be a matter of concern for the next PM. Above all, Starmer's successor will need to articulate a larger national vision of a diverse 21st-century Britain and its place in the world.

Millennials in the middle

THE MIDDLE children of history," to borrow Chuck Palahniuk's phrase, have neither the confidence and comforts of their elders nor the attention-seeking social-media-facing self-absorption of those who came after. As they enter middle age, bearing the burdens of taxes, children and parents, it is becoming increasingly clear that those born between the early 1980s and mid-1990s are not just the middle children of modern history, but perhaps its step-children as well. Research by the British think tank Resolution Foundation shows that millennials are the first generation to have less disposable income than their predecessors. And Gen Z, for all their performative gloom and doom, have a real weekly pay that outpaces millennials' at the same stage of their career by 12 per cent.

Most millennials were early in their careers around 2008 and its aftermath, when the global economy collapsed and, in India, the heyday of the post-liberalisation boom began to subside. Social safety nets and public goods began to shrink, and their private-sector replacements add to the burgeoning set of expenses on stagnant pay cheques. Born into an analogue world, this cohort spent much of their adult lives becoming "digital natives" only to be told, now, that they are to be rendered obsolete by artificial intelligence(s) that their work has helped train.

There is, though, a quiet dignity to the millennial tragedy. They bear the burden of being the tax base, the mid-level workers who keep companies running, while listening to the lectures of those who came before and the algorithmic righteousness of those who came after. In the end, in an increasingly virtual world, there's something commendable about being made of stern stuff.

The Editorial Page

From farms to factories, trade pact with UK opens new opportunities in India

THE LANDMARK India-UK Comprehensive Economic and Trade Agreement (CETA) will help Indian farmers, fishermen, artisans and small businesses prosper globally and accelerate job creation. It will enable the common man to access high-quality goods at competitive prices, contributing significantly to Prime Minister Narendra Modi's Viksit Bharat 2047 mission. The transformational win-win agreement, which comes into force on July 15, will ensure comprehensive market access for Indian goods in the UK across sectors, particularly labour-intensive ones. It will immediately eliminate tariffs on about 99 per cent of tariff lines, covering almost 100 per cent of trade value, creating enormous opportunities for Indian exports.

A people-centric agreement, CETA was signed last year in the presence of PM Modi and British Prime Minister Keir Starmer. It delivers benefits across society. Farmers gain access to premium export markets without compromising their domestic interests. Fisherfolk benefit from enhanced seafood exports to the vast UK market. Workers gain new employment opportunities in labour-intensive sectors. Women entrepreneurs, youth, start-ups and MSMEs receive improved access to global value chains. Professionals benefit from enhanced mobility and recognition opportunities.

CETA unlocks the premium UK market for Indian farmers, matching or exceeding the benefits enjoyed by other European nations. Turmeric, pepper, cardamom and processed goods such as mango pulp, pickles and pulses will receive duty-free access. Higher agricultural exports will boost farm incomes and create greater incentives for quality, packaging and certification. It will also generate numerous jobs across the

agricultural value chain. At the same time, CETA excludes India's most sensitive agricultural sectors to protect domestic farmers, particularly those involved in dairy products, cereals, millets, apples, oats and cooking oils. These exclusions reflect the government's strategy of prioritising food security, domestic price stability and vulnerable farming communities.

Immediate duty-free access to the vast UK market will rev up Indian manufacturing, allowing traditional artisans, large-scale factories, and regional industrial hubs to compete effectively. Small businesses will prosper as Indian products gain a clear competitive edge over rivals. Companies manufacturing soccer balls, cricket gear, rugby balls and toys, among other products, are poised to significantly expand their business in the UK. The removal of duties addresses longstanding tariff barriers, particularly in labour-intensive sectors, and is expected to generate immediate gains in export competitiveness and scale. From the looms of Tiruppur to the labs of Bengaluru, from diamond artisans in Surat to coders in Hyderabad, this agreement touches the real economy.

The UK has provided one of its most comprehensive service commitments ever, covering all major service sectors and 137 sub-sectors of export interest to India. Enhanced market access and regulatory certainty will support Indian service providers in IT and IT-enabled services, financial services, professional services, healthcare, education, engineering, telecommunications and consultancy services. India has secured favourable mobility provisions for skilled professionals, including contractual service pro-



PIYUSH GOYAL

Trade agreements have also ensured the gradual opening up of the domestic market. This makes the Indian market more competitive and encourages local manufacturers to produce high-quality goods at competitive prices

viders, business travellers, investors, yoga instructors, musicians and chefs. The agreement also provides predictable mobility pathways for business visitors, intra-corporate transferees, contractual service suppliers, independent professionals and investors. Further, 1,800 Indian chefs, yoga instructors and classical musicians will be able to access dedicated mobility opportunities annually under the agreement.

Under PM Modi's leadership, FTAs go far beyond goods and services and set new benchmarks. With the EFTA countries — Switzerland, Norway, Iceland and Liechtenstein — India secured a commitment of \$100 billion in investment, expected to create 1 million direct jobs. In the FTA with New Zealand, the country secured an investment commitment of \$20 billion over 15 years, while the Australian FTA resolved the double-taxation issue that had troubled Indian IT companies.

A significant aspect of the agreement with the UK is the Double Contribution Convention. This landmark arrangement, entering into force alongside CETA, exempts Indian workers and employers from making dual social-security contributions in the UK during temporary assignments. More than 75,000 Indian professionals and over 900 companies are expected to benefit from continued social-security coverage for employees on temporary overseas assignments.

In 2014, the economy was struggling, with potential investors losing confidence. India was regarded as one of the "Fragile Five" economies after a decade marked by policy drift and corruption scandals involving astronomical sums. The Modi government adopted a

● WORDLY WISE
Capital is only the fruit of labour, and could never have existed if labour had not first existed.
— Abraham Lincoln

determined approach to rebuild global confidence in the Indian economy and make it attractive for investors. Signing FTAs with developed countries was the next step. FTAs also enhance investor confidence by reducing uncertainty around trade policies. The government pursued FTAs with developed economies that offer large markets while not directly competing with India's core trade interests. This creates a win-win situation, unlike the previous government's approach of endangering Indian businesses by recklessly opening India's doors to competitors.

Under PM Modi's leadership, India is now widely respected as a resilient economy and a trusted partner in a volatile world. It has established itself as a reliable partner with an attractive market and remains the world's fastest-growing major economy. Game-changing reforms, improvements in ease of doing business, the decriminalisation of minor offences, and the PM's global stature have helped position India as a compelling investment destination. Today, the world wants to participate in India's growth story — and sign FTAs.

These trade agreements have also ensured the gradual opening up of the domestic market. This makes the Indian market more competitive and encourages local manufacturers to produce high-quality goods at competitive prices, which is a key element of the PM's Viksit Bharat mission. CETA is a benchmark for equitable and ambitious trade agreements between major economies. It opens attractive global opportunities for the underprivileged without compromising India's core interests. It is a shining example of how New India does business.

The writer is Union Minister of Commerce and Industry, Government of India

Economy is growing, but that isn't translating to well-being



PULAPRE BALAKRISHNAN

THE RIPPLE effect of the war in west Asia has led to a discussion on the state of the economy. The diagnosis, however, is mostly wrong. Observers have claimed that the growth model pursued by the government has run out of steam. According to reports, the deliberations at the most recent meeting of the Prime Minister's Economic Advisory Council revolved around how to ensure that growth does not falter and how reforms can advance "ease of living". What's missing in both cases is the realisation that while the economy is growing quite fast, it may not be delivering the outcomes we would like.

For well-being, we should be looking at consumption and the standard of living. Serial NSS household expenditure surveys point to slower growth of consumption after 2011-12. The Household Consumption Expenditure Survey 2023-24 also enables an assessment of the standard of living. From it, we find that the consumption expenditure on food does not translate to two thali meals at Rs 30 each per day for 50 per cent of the rural population and 20 per cent of the urban population. Food subsidy raises their consumption level, but the all-India figure for those who consume less than two thali meals a day is 30 per cent. This reflects high food deprivation. It may be read along with data from the UN's Food and Agricultural Organisation on the affordability of a healthy diet, which shows that 50 per cent of India cannot afford one.

Let us turn to employment next. While the unemployment rate has declined over the past five years, in 2025 it was still higher than it was in 2011-12, when growth was actually lower. The same pattern holds for youth unemployment, except that in 2025 it was still close to 10 per cent, which is thrice the figure for the labour force as a whole.

The high unemployment rate and low food consumption level show that the relatively high growth of the past three years is not trickling down to a large section of the population. It has been claimed that inequality in India has been growing

from what is already a high base. While precise numbers on the income distribution may not be available, we have data consistent with rising inequality. I refer to the decline in real wages over the past five years. Real wages decline when the cost of living rises, as it is now. We also know that the cost of living rises mainly due to rising food prices. With expenditure on food being a large part of household budgets, less will be available for other goods and services when food becomes costlier. As food prices rise, the consumption of other goods by workers slows. This gets reflected in employment. This is the chain that links the food price, real wages, consumption and employment. Rising profits, which may accompany declining real wages, would lead to higher demand for relatively capital-intensive goods, whose employment-generating impact is less.

The solution offered by some economists that India needs "more reforms" is off the mark. It has been suggested that reforms should be undertaken to attract foreign direct investment. While foreign investment is an important source of foreign exchange, given its form and size in relation to the economy, it is not the factor behind high unemployment or low standard of living. That factor is food price. The real price of food, which is its price relative to that of all other goods, has risen by over 30 per cent since 2011-12.

The PMEAC reportedly discussed ease of doing business in India, an important dimension pertaining to non-agricultural activity. But this segment is facing a demand shortage, while ease of doing business is concerned with the supply side. If the rising price of food is the problem, then its production is what we should be focussing on. Reforms would have a role if they can contribute to steadying, if not lowering, the real price of food. Yield is the critical factor in restraining that price. Interventions to raise it are what is most needed now.

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RADHIKA JAGTAP

Director Curry Barker's work makes viewers question the power imbalance in romantic relationships, but here's a concern: One cannot unsee how the plot did not spend even a few seconds on the horror experience from inside Nikki's head

In 'Obsession', the horror of being recast for male desire

HORROR IS what men inflict; women suffer its consequences — the Hollywood release *Obsession* seems to remind us of this. As someone watching it in India, where the nation's prime-time has recently been dominated by images of a deceased young woman, allegedly a victim of dowry death, and her accused mother-in-law calling her out for not "fitting in", it hits close to home that *Obsession*'s Nikki represents a woman who is forced to distort her personality to "fit into" a man's idea of love and possession. Aren't women forcibly domesticated into relationships and marriages to fit gendered expectations? The never-declining rate of marital and intimate-partner violence indicates that modern relationships are failing, and they are failing women first.

Simone de Beauvoir used the word "mutilates" in her *The Second Sex* (1949): "...the drama of marriage is not that it does not guarantee the wife the promised happiness — there is no guarantee of happiness — it is that it mutilates her; it dooms her to repetition and routine". There is no marriage in *Obsession*, but its protagonist Bear does try to retain control over Nikki — by making a wish that sets things into motion — and in the process, Nikki loses control of herself, inflicting violence on those around. Bear inflicts violence on Nikki; she embodies its consequences.

Nikki's portrayal of the "crazy girlfriend" follows the aesthetics of the "Overly Attached Girlfriend" meme popularised by YouTuber Laina Morris in 2012. Director Curry Barker's work makes viewers question the power imbalance in romantic relationships, but here's a concern: One cannot unsee how the plot did not spend even a few seconds on the horror experience from inside Nikki's head. Where is her mental frame? In a few scenes, Nikki tries to differentiate between herself and the entity inside, but could Barker subtly want us to blame the entity and not Bear for her condition? Are men resonating with the violation of consent because a man is bearing the consequences of it? Is *Obsession* trying to normalise the idea that women's emancipation, and the acknowledgement of their suffering, is heavily dependent upon how men perceive it? That men will only listen to other men about women's experiences?

Obsession also suffers from the "final girl" trope, as argued by academic Carol Clover in *Men, Women, and Chainsaws* (1992), her book on slasher movies. She argues that men resonate with and align with the "final surviving girl" archetype in slasher movies like *The Texas Chain Saw Massacre* (1974). While Clover's work was later critiqued by Black and non-cis scholarship, it could be possible that *Obsession* provides a revision of the theory by making men side with Nikki against the control of male desire, but sadly without demanding Nikki's retelling. In that case, perhaps horror is not the genre of the movie; perhaps it lies in the consequences of not reading its politics deeply enough.

The writer teaches at the School of Law, UPES Dehradun

40 YEARS AGO

June 23, 1986



Maharashtra building collapse

IN THE worst-ever industrial unit collapse in Maharashtra, at least 100 persons were feared killed and 20 others injured in the industrial area of Talaja. While bodies of two victims were recovered within two hours of the collapse of the two-storey building, one more was extricated from the rubble towards the evening. The factory building of Beekalene Fabrics crashed around 9.45 am when employees of the first and general shift were busy with their work.

Punjab: 3 kids among 11 killed

ELEVEN PEOPLE, including three children and four suspected terrorists, were killed and

at least eight injured in scattered incidents in Punjab during the last 24 hours as mob violence continued for the second successive day in Amritsar city. Armed men raided the house of a former sarpanch at the Tarsika Chowk area of Amritsar district and shot him dead. Four miscreants forced their way into a house barely 10 metres from a police post on the Moga-Amritsar road in Faridkot district, killing three children and injuring two others.

Punjab rejects reference

THE PUNJAB Government has rejected the amended terms of reference of the Desai Commission stating that even these were not in consonance with the Punjab accord. The Punjab Finance Minister, Balwant

Singh, told newsmen that the state cabinet in its meeting had taken note of the amendments and felt that they were still a "departure" from the Punjab accord.

Zia's apology to PM

THE PAKISTAN President, Gen Zia-ul Haq, has conveyed his personal apologies to the Prime Minister, Rajiv Gandhi, for the attack on Indian diplomats in Lahore by Canada-based Sikhs. Gen Zia told N P K Salve, a senior Congress (I) leader, that Pakistan would exercise full vigilance to avoid the recurrence of such ugly incidents. Gen Zia claimed that the Pakistan authorities lost no time in taking action against the culprits.



Opposition must move from seeking to regain power to reclaiming the Republic



DESHKAAL

BY YOGENDRA YADAV

RESISTANCE. THIS one word summarises Rahul Gandhi's June 8 address to the INDIA bloc leaders, clearly one of the most consequential political speeches delivered by an Opposition leader in recent years.

It is consequential not for reasons that have attracted public attention so far. The reference to other Opposition parties like the CPI(M) and DMK has invited reactions, understandable once indoor comments were made public. Yet this expression of disagreements was and should be seen as underlining a fundamental unity of purpose of the entire Opposition. A subsequent article by Dipankar Bhattacharya, general secretary of the CPI(M-L), puts this idea in a more inclusive and wider perspective. Similarly, the remark that the "Congress party is a resistance movement" should be read as a reclamation of an ideal rather than a statement of current ground reality.

The true significance of the speech lies in its diagnosis and prescription. This is the first clear-eyed recognition by the Opposition of a watershed moment in our political life: India's transition from competitive authoritarianism to electoral autocracy. This is also the first coherent articulation of a strategic shift: The Opposition's transition from politics of electoral contestation to politics of resistance. Both these pivotal ideas need to be unpacked, disseminated, debated and refined.

Rahul Gandhi's diagnosis goes beyond the rhetoric of lament. He puts his finger on the real issue: "The problem is the capture of the instruments of the Indian state by the RSS... The entire architecture — media, social media, the legal system, bureaucracy, intelligence agencies — is aligned to keep this government in power." He is clear that the situation is going to get worse: "In the near future, even those few instruments that used to work will stop working, because the BJP

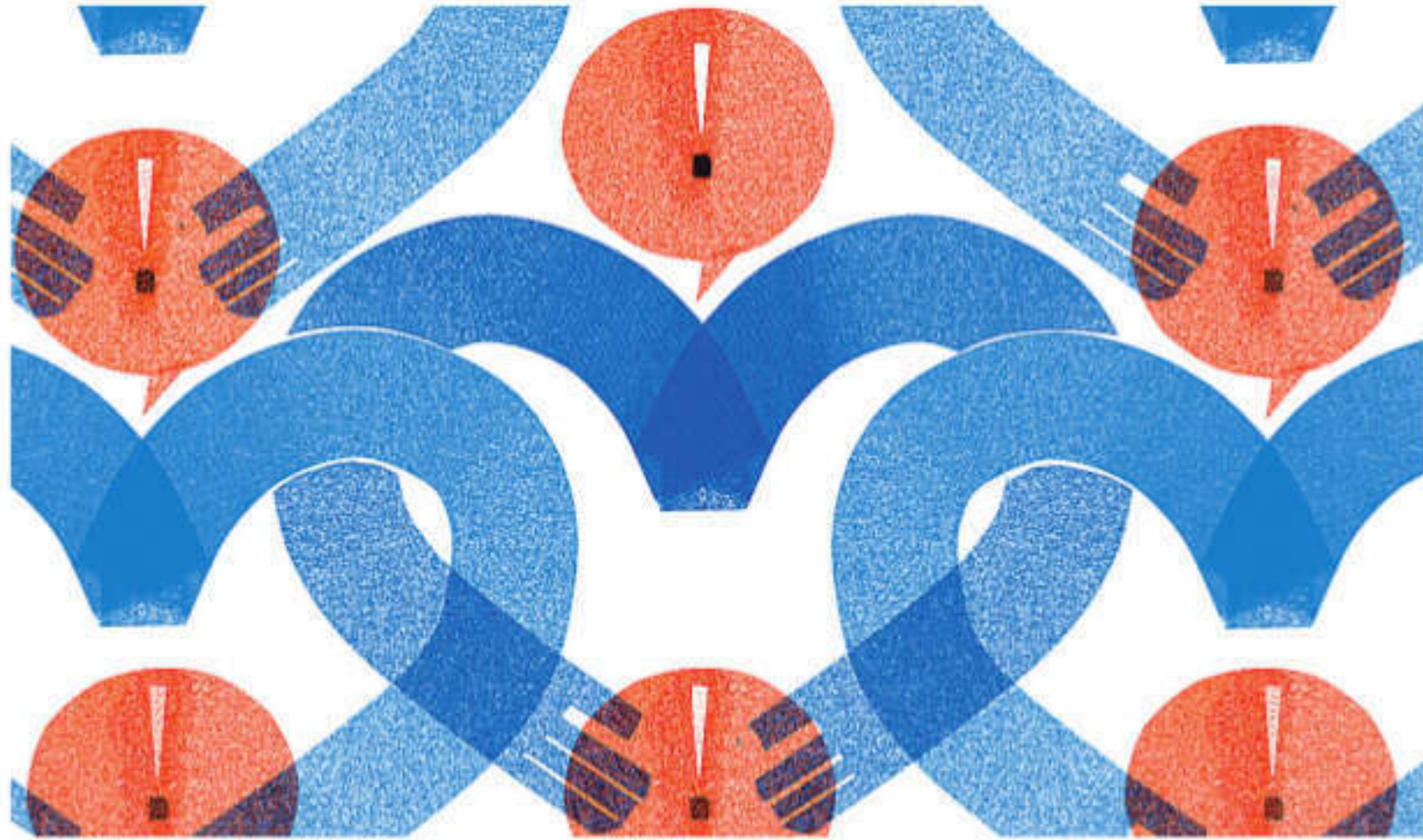


ILLUSTRATION: C R SASIKUMAR

and RSS are tightening their grip on the Indian state." The fortnight after his speech has already deepened this capture. The Supreme Court's refusal to intervene in the rejection of Meenakshi Natarajan's nomination as a candidate for the Rajya Sabha and the open use of state and money power to break the TMC and the Shiv Sena have offered further evidence for the institutional capture that the Leader of the Opposition spoke about.

These observations about India resonate with a global trend noticed by political scientists. Beginning with Juan Linz's classic book *The Breakdown of Democratic Regimes* (1978), we now have a growing academic literature on the transition from democracy to authoritarianism. We know that this transition does not happen overnight. Adam Przeworski famously defined democracy as "institutionalised uncertainty", a system where the rulers agree to take the risk of losing power. The backsliding of democracy is all about rulers tweaking democratic institutions so as to reduce and eventually eliminate this risk.

There are two intermediate stages in this descent from democracy. "Competitive authoritarian-

This historic responsibility must involve a fusion of energies: Opposition parties in and outside the INDIA bloc, non-party but political movements, organisations of workers and farmers, spontaneous and unorganised protests as well as civil-society organisations and citizens

ism" is a system where political competition does exist but is limited to the brief period of elections, where the ruling party does run the risk of losing elections, though the competition is unfair. The next step is "electoral autocracy", where the rulers manage to reduce the risk of losing power to a bare minimum by compromising all institutions and procedures, including electoral fraud, if needed.

India is currently between these two stages. We have been a competitive authoritarian state since 2019. India's descent into an electoral autocracy was stalled by the popular verdict in 2024. Since then, the ruling dispensation has left no stone unturned to reduce the political risk of losing any election. This involves a threefold mon-

opoly: *Soochana* (information control through media), *sansadhan* (monetary resources) and *sanstha* (institutional capture). This is being supplemented by a redesign of the *desh-kaal-patra* (time-space-actor) of elections: Reallocating and redrawing the constituencies through the proposed delimitation, rearranging the calendar of elections through One-Nation-One-Election and rewriting the voters' list through the SIR. Once this process is completed, we will be firmly

an electoral autocracy with a negligible chance of a normal, democratic transfer of power through elections. The Opposition is finally confronting this dark truth.

Rahul Gandhi's speech does not limit itself to an analysis. What makes it a defining speech is a clear delineation of its implications for political action. The political instruments used by the Opposition thus far "only worked when the Indian state provided a fair field for them to operate in. That field does not exist any more... If political parties can't function, what functions? Resistance functions." He calls for moving away from over-reliance on electoral politics: "The problem is that [the Opposition] will not have a free and fair election to win. And so, we have to go into the mode of resistance." He insists that resistance is a spirit, a mind-set, not an organisation.

This indicates a paradigm shift in oppositional politics — from the *sansad* to Jantar Mantar, from electoral contestation to ground mobilisation, from politics of regaining power to politics of reclaiming the republic. This resistance has to be democratic and non-violent. History tells us that the use of violence is both ineffective and counterproductive. What happened in Bangladesh or Nepal is not a template that can or should be replicated in India. We must carve out a democratic path to regaining democracy. This historic responsibility does not rest only with the INDIA bloc, or political parties in general. It must involve a fusion of energies: Opposition parties in and outside the INDIA bloc, non-party but political organisations and movements, organisations of workers and farmers, spontaneous and unorganised protests as well as civil-society organisations and citizens. This entails linking the diverse and often contradictory pain points of We The People.

This focus on resistance is by no means a reckless call to abandon constitutional and parliamentary democracy but a plea to reconnect politics to the people. As Ram-manohar Lohia reminded us: *Jab sadaken sooni ho jaati hain tab sansad awaara ho jati hai*. (Parliament turns rogue when streets go empty).

The writer is member, Swaraj India, and national convenor, Bharat Jodo Abhiyaan. Views are personal

Supreme Court has put pedestrians first. Cities must, too



KAUSHIK DAS GUPTA

IMAGINE A city where streets are not merely conduits for vehicles but public spaces where people can walk safely — through neighbourhoods, and to schools, markets, workplaces and recreation centres. In the Indian context, such a vision remains fraught. An analysis in this newspaper shows that while overall road fatalities rose by 21.24 per cent between 2015 and 2024, deaths among those travelling on foot surged by nearly 163 per cent. The number of people killed while walking increased from 13,894 in 2015 to 36,526 in 2024. That's why the Supreme Court's judgment — it held that the right to walk safely on demarcated footpaths is a fundamental right flowing from Article 21 of the Constitution and must take precedence over the movement of motor vehicles — is significant.

All too often, the pedestrian is marginal to urban planning. That is despite data from the last Census showing that more than 4 crore Indians engaged in non-agricultural pursuits walk to work every day. For another large section, the journey involves walking to bus stops and Metro or train stations. Yet, urban development is routinely equated with wider roads, flyovers and faster traffic flows. Footpaths, where they exist, are often narrow, broken, encroached upon, or abruptly disappear. There is very little regard for safe crossings for the elderly, children or persons with disabilities.

Policymakers should pay particular heed to the Court's criticism of the inequality that lies at the core of this automobile-centred urban imagination. "It could also be elitism to start with, for machines with wheels were only for the rich, but as economies progressed and cheaper motor vehicles were introduced, the entire spectrum of motorised transportation dominated the roads, pushed aside the walkers to the extent that they are treated as a nuisance for the drivers who routinely run over the walkers and their footpaths," it said while delivering its verdict in a road-accident case that resulted in the death of a five-year-old walking to his school.

Despite several amendments, mechanised transport continues to hold centre stage in the Motor Vehicles Act. As the Court



ILLUSTRATION: TANUSHRI MITRA

pointed out, even the latest regulations, incorporated in the Act nine years ago, "neither recognise the fundamental right to walk on demarcated footpaths nor prioritise the right to footpath over a motorised road". Urban planning around the world is increasingly recognising that walkable cities are also more liveable cities. Studies and real-world examples show that pedestrian-friendly urban centres lower pollution and congestion, strengthen social interaction, and even stimulate

economic activity. Copenhagen has made walking and cycling integral to everyday life, while Bogotá and Kigali's transport models recognise that every public commute begins and ends on foot. The lesson is equally evident in India. A 2019 ITDP study found that the construction of new footpaths in Chennai reduced dependence on motorised transport by 9 to 27 per cent, cut greenhouse-gas emissions and expanded economic opportunities for women and persons with disabilities. The message — that a city that enables its residents to walk safely is likely to be a healthier and cleaner one — is salient given the country's struggle with pollution and lifestyle diseases.

Of course, there can be no template to democratise mobility. Several of the interventions adopted elsewhere may not be completely transplantable to Indian cities that have high population densities, large informal settlements, mixed land use and severe constraints on urban land. Even then, the SC verdict invites planners to engage with a more fundamental question: Can cities be designed to enable people to go about their daily commitments regardless of whether they own a vehicle? Retrofitting older cities, with their narrow roads and entrenched patterns of development, could prove difficult and expensive. But as the SC has underlined, unobstructed footpaths are not extravagant interventions but minimum conditions for the exercise of the fundamental right to movement. In that sense, its verdict should be seen as an invitation to organise cities around accessibility.

The judgment is also consequential because India's urban story is still being written. Dozens of new urban centres and peri-urban settlements are expected to emerge in the coming decades as the country's population becomes increasingly urban. The choices will determine whether these cities replicate the mistakes of automobile-centric planning or embrace a more equitable model.

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LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Trade deal

THE TRADE deal with the US took almost a year to iron out differences comprehensively ('India has spelt red lines to US. Now seal trade deal', *IE*, June 22). Such agreements are meant to maintain cordial relations and should be based on mutual trust and mutual benefit for the peoples of both nations. The US Supreme Court has scrapped the present level of tariffs; therefore, the deal may have to be reworked. Setting aside political self-interest, both sides should seal the agreement in a manner that strengthens friendship, deepens bilateral relations and benefits their citizens.

Subhash Vai, New Delhi

THE EDITORIAL does well to exhort India to tread cautiously, as it faces the twin challenges of preserving both the partnership and its strategic autonomy while finalising its crucial trade deal with the US ('India has spelt red lines to US. Now seal trade deal', *IE*, June 22). While this may be easier said than done, given Donald Trump's maverick style of statecraft, Prime Minister Narendra Modi's well-articulated approach at the recently concluded G7 summit in France may prove useful during US Trade Representative Jamieson Greer's visit to India this week.

SK Gupta, via email

Complete justice

POLITICIANS HAVE been using Article 329 to their advantage, delaying justice and thereby effectively denying it ('Electoral wrongs can be corrected before it's too late', *IE*, June 22). Courts have been slow to address this exploitation of a constitutional loophole. It is high time the judiciary found a creative solution that honours Article 142's mandate of "complete justice", thereby balancing the competing concerns. Out-of-the-box thinking, which can come only from the legal luminaries who adorn our benches, is the need of the hour. After all, it is for justice that we have the courts.

Amitabh Nigam, Ahmedabad



PALLAV SHISHODIA

THE SUPPORT of a majority of legislators in the Lok Sabha and Vidhan Sabha is needed to form a stable government. This stability has often been missing due to the defections by "aaya Rams, gaya Rams" toppling elected governments. To address this, in 1985, the Tenth Schedule was added by way of the 52nd Amendment to the Constitution "for outlawing defection" by disqualifying any elected members who defect from or defy the whip of the political party to which they belong, except in the case of a split or merger. The underlying premise of this Schedule is that the elected representatives cannot be trusted with political morality, loyalty to their own party, and independent judgment beyond party lines.

The Tenth Schedule's validity was challenged in the *Kihoto Hollohan* case as violative of the fundamental rights to freedom of speech and conscience, and to dissent and to dissociate from the party line. And that it suppressed democratic debate, dialogue, and disagreements. The challenge was negated by a Constitution Bench of the Supreme Court in favour of party discipline to check the unprincipled and unethical flight of members of the House. Then followed several judicial decisions with nuanced interpretations of defection, the role of the Speaker, and the relationship between a political party and its

The ruling parties, at whatever level, rule with the iron fist of a whip on their members and the parties in opposition remain vulnerable to poaching, despite the seemingly high threshold for split and merger

legislative wing. By the 91st Amendment in 2003, the exemption from disqualification in the case of a split was removed, leaving only the possibility of a merger requiring the agreement of two-thirds of the members of the legislative party.

The shifting loyalties and fluidity of our politics make our elected representatives cross over to political opponents time and again, despite the Tenth Schedule. The force of the original electoral verdict has often been dismantled by split-and-merger. Rarely is the elected representative who defects disqualified, particularly when the defection is with the blessing of the ruling party. In very few cases, the resignation of elected representatives is followed by their re-election under the banner of a new party.

In the ongoing crisis of the TMC, the defection, described as a split, is followed by a merger with a nondescript NCP to save the remaining tenure of the rebel MPs. A major faction of Shiv Sena (UBT) is on the same path. In all probability, the original TMC/Shiv Sena (UBT) leadership will challenge this as defection to seek the disqualification of rebel MPs. The status quo pending the challenge will suit everyone.

Elected representatives in mature democracies, like the UK, often take a political position different from their political party. In

It's time to reimagine the anti-defection law

Pricey oil is advertising for everything Chinese

couldn't control, an economy about to wobble. But Beijing had been planning for this exact morning for years, pulling from petroleum reserves it had spent a decade stockpiling, drawing crude through pipelines from Russia and Central Asia that no warship can interdict, and leaning on a fleet of off-the-books tankers built to keep discounted oil flowing no matter what. But the deeper edge wasn't in the reserves or the pipelines. It was in the strange shape of China's energy system itself. The country still runs heavily on coal. Fossil fuels supply well over half of its power.

Yet China has also built the largest fleet of wind, solar, and hydro on the planet, with renewables now past 30 per cent of its electricity and climbing fast. That in-between mix gets treated in Washington as a transition stalled halfway, a contra-

diction waiting to be punished. In this war, it worked like armour. A country that can fall back on cheap domestic coal while selling the world its solar panels, batteries, and electric cars simply doesn't flinch when a tanker lane shuts in West Asia. Expensive, jittery oil is free advertising for nearly everything China makes. Every jump at the pump nudges a buyer towards a Chinese EV. Every blocked tanker turns Chinese solar panels from a green indulgence into plain arithmetic.

Every jump at the pump nudges a buyer towards a Chinese EV. Every blocked tanker turns Chinese solar panels from a green indulgence into plain arithmetic

At the same time, China keeps bringing nuclear plants online, the steady baseload power that makes a renewables-heavy grid hang together.

The assumption that we will automatically revert to the day before the war erupted is a fantasy. And most importantly, the war has fortified China's economy. Beijing now operates with greater confidence that it can absorb or even profit from future crises in distant choke-points while pressing its core interests closer to home. Beyond the economic consequences of the war, Beijing now deals with Washington as an over-stretched superpower and responds by pressing harder on core red lines, mainly Taiwan. The outcome of the war in Iran will now inform how China should manage Taiwan and American power in Asia,

while raising profound questions and suspicions about American power and its limits as the global balance of power continues to shift toward multipolarity.

For China, the Iran war therefore serves as a real-time stress test of US power projection, logistics endurance, and political will in Asia, reinforcing calculations that Washington may struggle to mount or sustain a high-intensity defence of Taiwan without unacceptable trade-offs elsewhere. This dynamic not only informs Beijing's mix of coercion, diplomacy, and timing but also amplifies regional doubts about American deterrence as US-China competition intensifies.

The writer is the author of West Asia, a senior fellow at the Middle East Institute and a director at McLarty Associates

LABOUR BEGINS LEADERSHIP CONTEST PROCESS, NEW LEADER COULD BE IN PLACE BY SEPTEMBER

From sidelines to centre stage, Andy Burnham on course to be UK’s next PM



Andy Burnham with Labour colleagues in Westminster Hall at the Houses of Parliament in central London, on Monday. REUTERS

Stephen Castle
London, June 22

ANDY BURNHAM has twice run unsuccessfully for the leadership of Britain’s governing Labour Party. Now his decisive victory in a special parliamentary election puts him within reach not just of that goal, but of entering Downing Street as prime minister.

A fluent communicator known for his bonhomie and charisma, Burnham has for nine years been mayor of Greater Manchester, where he cultivated an image of optimism, activism and the type of authentic plain speaking characteristic of northern England.

With a seat in Parliament representing Makerfield, in northwest England, Burnham will need the support of 80 fellow Labour lawmakers to mount a leadership challenge to the country’s unpopular

prime minister, Keir Starmer.

Supporters see Burnham — who in Manchester won the nickname “king of the North” for his defense of the area during the COVID-19 pandemic — as Labour’s potential savior against the populist right-wing Reform UK party, led by Nigel Farage. Critics portray Burnham as a political chameleon who would face the same economic constraints that have stymied Starmer’s lackluster government, and the same restless, impatient electorate.

Either way, he would be a different kind of leader from the one he wants to replace.

“He’s just optimistic and happy and seems to enjoy being a politician,” said John McTernan, an adviser to Tony Blair when he was prime minister and someone who has known Burnham since his days as a researcher for a lawmaker in south London. NYT

Starmer resigns, paving way for orderly transfer of power

Burnham looks set to be appointed without a contest

Reuters
London, June 22

PRIME MINISTER Keir Starmer said on Monday he was quitting, paving the way for what is expected to be an orderly transfer of power to frontrunner Andy Burnham, who could become Britain’s seventh leader in 10 years as early as next month.

In an emotional speech, Starmer said he had listened to his governing Labour Party and realised that he was no longer the man who should lead it into a national election due in 2029.

After making his announcement on the steps of his Downing Street office and London residence, Starmer’s move to stand down could have triggered a divisive leadership contest, but several Labour lawmakers said they now expected more of a coronation.

Burnham, a 56-year-old career politician, quickly won the support of another potential leadership rival, former health minister Wes Streeting, with one Labour lawmaker saying it was more likely the former mayor would now be installed as leader.

He entered parliament to cheers from Labour lawmakers, and the odd heckle from the op-

•SIX PRIME MINISTERS IN 10 YEARS

Starmer’s resignation paves way for UK’s seventh leader since the 2016 Brexit vote



JULY 2024 – 2026, KEIR STARMER: Resigned amid sinking poll ratings, Labour infighting, and public anger on slow progress on growth, living costs.



2019 – JULY 2022, BORIS JOHNSON: Forced to quit after a wave of resignations over his handling of allegations against a deputy chief whip.



SEPTEMBER 2022 – OCT 2022, LIZ TRUSS: Resigned after just 50 days, following her “mini-budget” of unfunded tax cuts that caused market turmoil.



2016, DAVID CAMERON: Resigned after losing the EU referendum he called.



2016 – 2019, THERESA MAY: Stepped down after Parliament rejected her Brexit deal 3 times.



OCTOBER 2022 – JULY 2024, RISHI SUNAK: Lost the 2024 general election to Keir Starmer after failing to revive growth or ease the cost-of-living crisis.

position, including one person who shouted out: “He’s not the Messiah.”

He then pledged allegiance to King Charles to take his place as a lawmaker, a necessary step

to be able to become the new leader of Labour and Britain.

The Labour government is the latest to fall foul of voter anger over politicians’ failure to deliver on their promises of change, 10 years after the vote to leave the European Union.

Starmer said he would ask the Labour Party’s organising committee to set out a timeline for a leadership contest to find his replacement. Nominations would open on July 9, close by mid-July, and if there is a contest, a new leader will be in place by September. A coronation could mean a new leader would enter office by mid-July.

“The question my party is asking now is whether I am best placed to lead us into the next general election. I have heard the answer from my parliamentary party to that question and I accept that answer with good grace,” he said.

After describing the achievements his government had secured in his two years of power, a man who was often criticised for being robotic became visibly emotional, his voice cracking when he thanked his family for their support.

“When I leave the biggest job in the country I will spend more time on the most important job, being the best husband I can to my fantastic wife Vic who has been a rock by my side through good times and bad, and being the best dad I can to my beautiful children who are my pride and my joy.”

•BRIEFLY

SPAIN

Former transport minister gets 24-year jail term for corruption



Spain’s former transport minister Jose Luis Abalos. FILE

SPANISH PRIME Minister Pedro Sanchez’s former transport minister, Jose Luis Abalos, was sentenced on Monday to 24 years in prison for a slew of offences involving corruption, the first verdict in a series of court cases linked to the ruling Socialist Party. The unusually long sentence reflected the accumulation of felonies committed, including kickbacks from facemask purchases during COVID-19 pandemic, and the damage to public trust caused by a minister of Abalos’ rank breaching rules, the verdict said.

THE PHILIPPINES

2 students held after shooting at high school kills 3

TWO STUDENTS armed with hand guns opened fire in a high school in the central Philippines on Monday, killing three fellow students and wounding another seven, police said. The suspects, aged 14 and 15, were arrested. The suspects and the victims were students of the San Jose National High School in Tacloban city, regional police chief Brig. Gen. Jason Capoy said. AP

UNITED STATES

Strikes on alleged drug boats kill 2, leave 6 survivors

THE US military has conducted another strike Sunday against a boat accused of smuggling drugs in the Caribbean on Sunday, killing two people and leaving six survivors. It is unclear if the survivors of this strike were rescued. The latest attack brings the number of people who have been killed in boat strikes by the US military to more than 210 people. AP

•NEIGHBOURHOOD WATCH

PAKISTAN

14 injured after vehicle ploughs religious event

AT LEAST 14 people, mostly women and children, were injured when a speeding car rammed into a Shia religious congregation in Karachi city, police said on Monday. The incident occurred on Sunday when people had gathered at an Imambargah for a Muharram congregation in Karachi’s Defence Housing Authority area, police said. PTI

NEPAL

Former finance minister held for money laundering

NEPAL’S FORMER finance minister Bishnu Prasad Paudel was arrested on Monday for his alleged involvement in a money laundering case, police said. Paudel, who is the vice president of the Communist Party of Nepal was the finance minister in the K P Sharma Oli-led government that was toppled during the Gen-Z movement in September last year. PTI

Trump-backed De La Espriella wins tight Colombia presidential race

Reuters
Bogota, June 22

COLOMBIAN RIGHT-wing candidate Abelardo De La Espriella has clinched a narrow victory in Sunday’s presidential election, according to an initial ballot count, as voters bet on his Donald Trump-endorsed promise of a crackdown on crime and a stronger economy.

De La Espriella had 49.66% of the vote while his rival, Senator Ivan Cepeda, trailed by some 250,000 votes at 48.70%, accord-

ing to the national registrar’s tally of just under 100% of ballots in the runoff election.

Cepeda, 63, had pledged to maintain the policies of President Gustavo Petro, a former rebel and the country’s first leftist president, including state pension payments for the poor, union-backed labor reforms, a moratorium on new oil projects, and continued peace talks with armed groups.

De La Espriella has blamed Petro for the country’s economic and security troubles, including



Abelardo de la Espriella

an expansion of armed groups, and vowed to end talks with rebels and criminal groups while

boosting the oil and gas sector, lowering taxes and reducing the size of the state by up to 40%.

He has said, however, that he will preserve Petro’s 23% increase in the minimum wage, along with other popular social measures. “I will govern for all Colombians, for those who voted for me and for those who chose the other candidate,” De La Espriella told a crowd of supporters gathered in the coastal city of Barranquilla, promising to respect all citizens’ rights.

He earlier celebrated a con-

gratulatory call from US President Donald Trump, who previously endorsed him. De La Espriella is also a citizen of the US and Italy and has homes in multiple countries.

“It is a victory for Colombia — a change after four lost years with no clear direction,” said Viviana Olivios, a 46-year-old mechanical engineer who attended the celebration.

The closeness of the race, with less than one percentage point separating the two candidates, will likely force De La Es-

priella to water down some of his proposals in order to get support from a divided Congress.

Cepeda’s Historic Pact party has more seats than any other party in both the Senate and the lower house, although no party has a majority. De La Espriella, a lawyer with no prior political experience, will also have to grapple with high public debt.

He has presented himself as a businessman, but an investigation by local outlet La Silla Vacía found that many of his businesses have been dissolved.

Moscow downs over 80 drones; Russian attacks kill 6 in Ukraine

Reuters
Moscow, June 22

MOSCOW SHOT down dozens of drones in the early hours of Monday, just days after a repeated Ukrainian strike on the city’s oil refinery, while Russian attacks in Ukraine killed at least six people, including a boy and his father, authorities said.

Eighty-four drones headed for Moscow were downed in the past 24 hours, Mayor Sergei Sobyannin said on Telegram. He said emergency services had been dispatched to the areas where drones were downed but gave no further information.

The airports of Sheremetyevo, Domodedovo and Vnukovo, as well as Zhukovskiy near the Russian capital, had temporarily suspended flights, the aviation watchdog said separately. Ukraine’s military said it



Firefighters work at the site struck by a Russian drone in Sumy region, Ukraine, on Monday. REUTERS

struck the Dubna satellite communications centre in the surrounding region.

In total, Russian defence systems downed 301 drones overnight, local newswires said, citing the defence ministry. That tally included Russian-occupied areas of Ukraine. The latest raids follow a

drone strike that hit Moscow’s sole oil refinery last week, in one of the biggest air attacks on the city since Russia’s full-scale invasion of Ukraine in 2022.

The drone attack early on Monday in Ukraine’s Sumy region killed a 13-year-old boy, his 36-year-old father and 73-year-old grandmother.

France heatwave leaves 18 dead as Europe swelters

Paris: At least 18 people died in France, including two children left in a hot car, as a heatwave hung over Europe, smashing temperature records in several cities on Monday.

As schools in France closed or modified timetables, forecasters in Britain predicted temperatures could break records for June this week.

The temperature in Bordeaux in France’s western wine country rose to 41.9 degrees Celsius (107.4 degrees Fahrenheit), breaking a record set last August. In Poitiers in central France it reached 41.2C, beating a previous high set in 1947.

First responders were unable to resuscitate two children, aged 2 and 4, who were found unconscious by their mother in the family car outside their home, said a prosecutor in Carpentras, southeast France. REUTERS

Bangladesh, Malaysia boost trade, defence ties

Press Trust of India
Dhaka, June 22

BANGLADESH PRIME Minister Tarique Rahman on Monday met his Malaysian counterpart Anwar Ibrahim and they decided to enhance cooperation in the fields of trade, defence, energy and investment, according to media reports here.

Rahman is visiting Malaysia and China on his maiden overseas trip since assuming office earlier this year.

Rahman and Ibrahim held bilateral talks at Perdana Putra, the office of the Malaysian prime minister, in Putrajaya, the Dhaka Tribune newspaper reported.

At the meeting, they discussed “bilateral cooperation and exchanged views on regional and international developments,” Rahman said, addressing a joint press

conference.

“Our friendship is built on mutual trust, shared values and strong people-to-people ties,” he was quoted as saying by The Daily Star newspaper.

“Today, we reaffirm our commitment to strengthening Bangladesh-Malaysia relations. We agree to enhance engagement through existing mechanisms, including the Joint Commission Meeting and bilateral consultations between our foreign ministries,” he added.

During the meeting, the two sides discussed the reopening of Malaysia’s labour market for Bangladeshi workers, Bangladesh’s application to become an ASEAN Sectoral Dialogue Partner, Dhaka’s inclusion in the Regional Comprehensive Economic Partnership, and cooperation at the United Nations and other multilateral forums, the report said. O

• PLANS FOR LUXURY RESORTS ON THE ADRIATIC SEA HAVE LONG WORRIED ENVIRONMENTALISTS; THE DEVELOPMENTS ARE NOW A FLASHPOINT FOR BROADER FRUSTRATIONS WITH THE GOVERNMENT

Where luxury meets resistance: The Jared Kushner project stirring unease in Albania

Amelia Nierenberg
London, June 22

PROTESTS HAVE grown in recent days against plans by Jared Kushner, President Trump’s son-in-law, to develop luxury properties on an ecologically sensitive portion of the Albanian coast.

The protests, in the capital and in coastal towns, have become a lightning rod for widespread discontent in Albania, long one of Europe’s poorest countries. Another protest was planned for Tuesday night in Tirana, the capital.

For years, the plans — a \$1.4 billion luxury hotel complex on an island off the coast and

another development on a peninsula that is home to sensitive wetlands — have generated concerns about conservation and transparency.

Prime Minister Edi Rama of Albania has repeatedly described the projects as a chance to expand the country’s booming tourist economy and to attract foreign investors.

On Tuesday, Rama said in a post on social media that the projects represented “the ambition to create the most attractive destination of this side of the Mediterranean.”

He has rejected suggestions by opponents of the plan that Kushner, who is one of several investors in the project, re-

ceived preferential treatment to curry favor with his father-in-law, Trump.

The White House referred questions to Kushner’s investment firm, Affinity Partners, which has been backed mostly with funding from the Saudi Arabian government. Affinity Partners referred questions to Sazan Real Estate Development LLC, the developer for both the Albanian projects.

“We’re excited about the opportunity to create a world-class destination and make one of the largest private investments in the region’s history,” Asher Abelsara, the chairman of Sazan, the projects’ developer, said in a statement.



Crowds gather to protest the \$1.4 billion luxury hotel complex on the coast of the Adriatic Sea. REUTERS

He said their focus included “responsible stewardship” of the environment.

Not everyone in Albania

agrees.

Taulant Bino, the head of the Albanian Ornithological Society and an opponent of the

plan, said he was heartened that the opposition to the project had grown beyond environmental campaigners.

“It’s more or less everything there,” he said. “You find people from the left, people from the right, people from different religious beliefs.”

One issue, he said, is that no environmental impact report has been released publicly, as normally required for such a development project. Since late April, Bino said, demonstrators have gathered at the site of one of the planned developments on the Zvernec Peninsula, a 1,000-acre coastal area that is home to an array of birds, including flamingos and pelicans.

The protests started after he and other environmentalists noticed what looked like the start of construction, which he said included the tracks of heavy equipment and bulldozers dismantling sand dunes.

Bino said that in the past few days, the protests intensified after fencing, with barbed wire, was erected in the area. He said there is at least one access road, too. And on Saturday, verified video shows, the disputes turned ugly.

Men shouted across barbed wire fences. Two men dragged another man across the sand by his arms, another clip shows, while people slung what looked

like dirt at each other.

Bino and other protesters see the project as an emblem of what they fear could be democratic backsliding in Albania, which emerged from decades of Communist rule in 1991.

“It’s not only transparency about environmental law — but it’s transparency in general,” Bino said.

“It’s about democracy,” Bino added. “The protests are, of course, centered around protected areas — but it’s more about democracy in general.”

For years, locals have raised concerns about the ownership chain of the land, but deals have steamed ahead, overriding local frustrations. -NYT

INDIAN REFINERS STUDYING TECHNO-COMMERCIAL FEASIBILITY

US sanctions waiver in; Tehran dials refiners, traders for oil sales

Sukalp Sharma
New Delhi, June 22

THE NATIONAL Iranian Oil Company (NIOC) has started reaching out to international oil companies, including Indian refiners, and trading houses to resume commercial ties in a bid to restart its global oil exports, according to trade sources.

This comes against the backdrop of the US-Iran memorandum of understanding (MoU) being in place, with the first round of talks under the terms of the initial pact indicating progress between Washington and Tehran.

The MoU, which was inked last week, mentioned that the US will initially issue sanctions waivers for Iranian crude and petroleum products, until it terminates its sanctions on Iranian oil and its trade. On Monday evening (India time) the US Department of the Treasury issued a temporary 60-day waiver, allowing production, delivery, and sale of Iranian oil, petroleum products, and petrochemicals through August 21.

The US has also committed to removing its naval blockade of Iranian ports. Both measures

are being counted upon by the NIOC to move its oil — which has for years been predominantly exported to China — to the wider international market, trade sources said.

Indian refiners have also recently received communication from the NIOC, it is learnt.

A senior refinery executive said that refiners' trading teams are in touch with the Iranian side and deliberations are on regarding the techno-commercial feasibility of lifting Iranian oil under the arrangement listed in the US-Iran MoU.

Iran used to be a major source of crude oil for the country, but New Delhi stopped buying its oil in 2019 after the first Donald Trump administration walked away from the Iran nuclear deal and reimposed sanctions on Tehran.

After a gap of nearly seven years, Indian refiners bought Iranian crude again in April after the US issued a month-long sanctions waiver in a bid to bring more oil to the global market amid the West Asia war and the effective closure of the Strait of Hormuz. But once that waiver lapsed, imports from Tehran stopped again.

INDIAN REFINERS AVOID SANCTIONED OIL

AFTER A gap of nearly seven years, Indian refiners again bought Iranian crude in April after the US issued a month-long sanctions waiver

BUT ONCE that waiver lapsed, imports from Tehran stopped again. India imported about 530,000 tonnes of Iranian oil in April, as per data from DGCIS

INDIAN REFINERS steer clear of oil and gas under US sanctions to avoid the risk of attracting



secondary sanctions from Washington

India imported about 530,000 tonnes of Iranian oil in April, as per data from the Directorate General of Commercial Intelligence and Statistics (DGCIS). Indian refiners steer clear of oil and gas under US sanctions to avoid the risk of attracting secondary sanctions from Washington.

"We have been holding regular discussions on the techno-commercial feasibility of buying Iranian oil. Our teams are working to ensure that they are pre-

pared to buy Iran's crude when it is available, as per our requirement and its viability in terms of payment mechanisms and other logistical considerations," said a senior refinery executive, who didn't wish to be identified. The executive said NIOC recently reached out to his firm regarding resumption of oil trade.

Broadly, the techno-commercial feasibility of buying oil from a certain seller is a comprehensive evaluation to ascertain if the crude oil under consider-

ation is technically compatible with the refineries, and is commercially and logistically practical to purchase.

Key considerations for Indian refiners to tap into Iranian barrels would primarily include their view of the scope and durability of sanctions relief, pricing structure, and the availability of payment, insurance, and logistics mechanisms, according to industry analysts. Apart from Iran's petroleum sector, its financial sector is also under US sanctions, creating payment-related and other logistical constraints in its oil trade. Refinery executives said calls on Iranian oil imports will be taken once there is clarity on all these aspects.

While the US waiver pertains specifically to Iran's oil, petroleum product, and petrochemical exports, and not to the financial sector sanctions on Tehran, the waiver notification does mention that payments for such purchases will be allowed in dollar-denominated funds. This could help ease some, if not all, payment-related pain points pertaining to purchase of Iranian energy.

FULL REPORT ON
WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

LIFESTYLE HOTELS GAIN TRACTION

Experience-led spending on travel, recreation and hotels, along with rising demand from Gen Z consumers, is accelerating growth in India's lifestyle hotel market, said a CBRE report titled 'Gen Z Checks In: The Rise of the Lifestyle Hotel'.



Lifestyle travel sees momentum

● Experience-led spending in India is projected to grow at 10.3% CAGR during 2025-2030, outpacing physical goods spending (9.1% CAGR)

● Gen Z is driving demand for immersive, design-led and tech-enabled hospitality experiences, driving the rise of lifestyle hotels

Untapped India opportunity

● India has relatively low lifestyle hotel penetration compared with regional peers

● This presents significant opportunities through lifestyle hotel development, conversions and repositioning of existing assets

NOTE: CAGR IS COMPOUND ANNUAL GROWTH RATE; SOURCE: CBRE

Core sector growth falls to 7-mth low of 0.5% in May

New Delhi: India's core sector growth fell to 0.5% in May, the lowest in seven months as output from five of the eight constituents of the relevant index contracted year-on-year. Output of coal, crude oil, natural gas, refinery products and fertilisers fell while steel, cement and electricity production expanded.

For April, the growth had been revised to 1.8% from the 1.7% reported earlier. In May of 2025 ICI had expanded at 1.2%.

The refinery sector, which contracted by 8.7%, was the biggest drag on growth in May. It

has the highest weight of 28.04 in the ICI. Coal output fell 9.3%, crude oil 4.6%, natural gas 4.9% and fertilizers 0.9%.

"The decline in production of crude oil, refinery products and natural gas could be due to higher crude imports and softening international market prices. In the case of natural gas, with supply chains being addressed, domestic production tended to fall. Lower exports of petro products also contributed to decline in production," Chief Economist at Bank of Baroda Madan Sabnavis said. FE

RBI's 'STATE OF THE ECONOMY' ARTICLE

'Monsoon shortfall could weigh on growth, inflation'

George Mathew
Mumbai, June 22

THE RESERVE Bank of India's (RBI) 'State of the Economy' article has cautioned that an adverse south-west monsoon, if it materialises, could weigh on the domestic growth and inflation outlook.

As per the updated forecast of the India Meteorological Department (IMD) (released on May 29, 2026), the south-west monsoon (SWM) rainfall is likely to be below normal this year, it said. "The SWM arrived over Kerala on June 4, three days later than the normal date of onset (June 1). While the SWM has covered southern and parts of eastern regions so far, the cumulative rainfall (June 1-21) at the country level has been significantly lower than the normal," the article authored by RBI researchers and published in the RBI monthly bulletin said.

The reservoir position has slipped below last year. However, it remains above the decadal average, it said. "Given the good harvest last year, the public procurement of wheat has been robust. The public stock of rice and wheat with the Food Corporation of India is well above the buffer norms which may serve as a strategic cushion against any supply disruption or spike in prices triggered by a likely *El Niño* weather phenomenon," the article said.

"Views expressed in this article are those of the authors and do not represent the views of the Reserve Bank of India," the central bank said.

The RBI's Monetary Policy Committee had re-assessed both its growth and inflation projections, with risks emanating from elevated oil prices, uncertainty in global trade, adverse weather conditions and geopolitical tensions clouding the economic outlook. In its meeting held on June 5, it lowered the growth projection from 6.9% to 6.6% and hiked the inflation forecast from 4.6% to 5.1%.

Any breakdown of the interim US-Iran peace agreement may reignite material risks in terms of inflationary expectations, disrupted critical energy infrastructure, delayed investment spending, food security concerns, adverse financial stability outlook and structurally lower growth, the article said.

However, it said high frequency indicators during the first two months suggest sustained economic momentum in 2026-27 even as "domestic demand remained strong in May, supported by pick-up in urban demand". The uncertainties could have an impact on the outlook through international trade, cost pressures, capital flows and commodity prices, it said. According to the article, the global economic

RBI sold \$8.94 bn in Apr to defend rupee amid outflows, oil spike

Mumbai: The Reserve Bank of India (RBI) made net sales of \$8.94 billion in the spot foreign exchange market in April to stabilise the rupee which was under pressure due to capital outflows and the rise in crude oil prices.

In March, it had sold \$9.75 billion to support the currency amid the West Asia conflict and its impact, according to the RBI data published in its monthly bulletin.

The central bank made purchases of \$16.22 billion and sales of \$25.16 billion in April. The outstanding net for-

ward sales stood at \$95.30 billion as of April, it said.

The rupee recovered in June after the RBI announced a series of measures like swap facility on FCNR(B) deposits and sops in bond purchases by foreign investors.

"The Indian rupee remained under pressure in May amid protracted geopolitical tensions and continued foreign portfolio outflows. However, the rupee recovered in June 2026, owing to capital flow measures, easing geopolitical tensions and falling crude oil prices," the RBI said. ENS

sions clouding the economic outlook. In its meeting held on June 5, it lowered the growth projection from 6.9% to 6.6% and hiked the inflation forecast from 4.6% to 5.1%.

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landscape remains fragile despite some respite through the interim US-Iran peace agreement. "The Indian economy entered this turbulence with much better fundamentals relative to many other countries to sustain the shock," it stated.

It said India maintained a consistently high growth, anchored inflation expectations, sustained fiscal consolidation, manageable current account balance and foreign exchange buffers over the previous few years, which adds to its strength *vis-à-vis* other similar events in the past.

Amid the challenging global environment, the Indian economy grew at 7.8% in Q4 2025-26, led by private consumption and fixed investment.

As per the report, high-frequency indicators point towards resilience of economic activity in May. E-way bills continued to achieve double-digit growth.

FULL REPORT ON
WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

CRED founder Kunal Shah to take over as WhatsApp head

Soumyarendra Barik
New Delhi, June 22

IN A surprise leadership move, Meta announced that Kunal Shah, founder of fintech firm CRED, will take over as the new head of WhatsApp.

He is set to succeed Will Cathcart, who led the messaging platform for nearly seven years. Shah said that though WhatsApp had come "very far," the "delta" between what the service offers today and its "full potential is massive".

The appointment comes alongside Meta's decision to invest about \$900 million (around Rs 8,550 crore) in CRED, one of the largest investments by a global technology company in an Indian fintech startup.

The move marks one of the most significant leadership appointments involving an Indian entrepreneur at a major global consumer technology platform. WhatsApp, which serves over three billion users worldwide, and more than 500 million in India, has increasingly become central to Meta's strategy around business messaging, payments, advertising and artificial intelligence (AI)-powered services.

AI INTEGRATION

● The move comes as Meta's WhatsApp is evolving into a platform for commerce, payments, AI assistants, and business services

● Shah's mandate may include accelerating monetisation via advertising and subscription offerings while expanding AI-led experiences

WhatsApp is among the most commonly used online services in the country, serving a wide range of purposes, from personal messaging to business communication. The platform allows for secured and encrypted messages between users, and is among the more secure ways of messaging people.

As part of the deal, Shah will step away from his executive responsibilities at CRED and join Meta's global leadership team, while continuing to hold his personal stake in the fintech company. CRED has appointed Miten Sampat, who has overseen the company's strategy and finance functions since 2020, as interim chief executive

with immediate effect. Shah said that Meta will not have access to the data of CRED's users.

Mark Zuckerberg, Meta's founder and CEO, said in a post on Facebook, "Kunal built CRED into one of India's most important technology companies, and he brings the kind of builder mentality and global perspective that will serve him well in running the world's biggest messaging app. I look forward to working with Kunal to continue to make WhatsApp the best service for billions of people and millions of businesses".

Cathcart, who has led WhatsApp since 2019, said he will step down after seven years at the helm and move into a new role within Meta focused on building next-generation products.

For Meta, the move comes at a time when WhatsApp is evolving beyond messaging into a platform for commerce, payments, AI assistants and business services. Shah's mandate could include accelerating monetisation through advertising and subscription offerings while expanding AI-powered experiences across the app.

FULL REPORT ON
WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

● HIS DECISION TO LET THE ECONOMY RUN, DESPITE PRESSURE TO RAISE INTEREST RATES, HELPED FOSTER YEARS OF U.S. PROSPERITY

Hailed as US Fed's 'Maestro', Alan Greenspan dies at 100

Reuters
Washington, June 22

ALAN GREENSPAN, hailed as the greatest Federal Reserve chairman when he retired in 2006 but derided for a severe financial crisis that followed barely two years later, died on Monday aged 100, his wife said.

Greenspan, who exerted a powerful influence on the US economy during his tenure at the helm of the Fed from August 1987 to January 2006, died at his home from complications of Parkinson's Disease, Andrea Mitchell said in a statement.

"He was a giant of a man who helped shape the US economy for decades under presidents of both parties, but was always honest in acknowledg-

ing his mistakes," Mitchell said.

Greenspan oversaw the second-longest economic expansion in US history, an uninterrupted decade of growth from March 1991 to March 2001. His decision to let the economy run — despite pressure to raise interest rates against an inflation threat that never materialized — helped foster years of US prosperity and earned him rock star status as an economic "maestro".

The era was marked by his prescient judgment that a productivity surge in the mid-1990s would keep inflation contained.

His intuition in that moment is still a touchstone for policymakers, and has been referred to by former Fed Chair



Greenspan oversaw the second-longest economic expansion in US history, a decade of growth from March 1991 to March 2001. REUTERS

Jerome Powell as an example of how judgment can sometimes outperform technical models of the economy.

However, the one-time jazz

musician's monetary policy acumen later came into question as critics attacked his policies for fuelling a series of asset price bubbles and laying the

groundwork for the 2007-2009 financial crisis.

"I think the deification that came just before the financial crisis was never really deserved, and I think the lambasting that he took after he left was never fully deserved either," said Stephen Oliner, a former senior Fed official.

Greenspan, who fell in love with math through an obsession with baseball statistics, won quick plaudits for a strong response to the Black Monday stock market crash of 1987, just two months after he took office.

He also steered the US economy through the 1990-91 recession, the 1997-1998 Asian and Russian financial contagion, the collapse of the dot-com stocks bubble in 2000,

and the turbulent economic aftermath of the September 11, 2001, attacks.

Along the way, biographer Sebastian Mallaby detailed, he became a consummate Washington power player able to maneuver presidents and cabinet secretaries into making the decisions he felt were best, sometimes without them realizing who pulled the strings.

At the Fed's vaunted Jackson Hole gathering in 2005, two leading economists billed him as perhaps the greatest central banker of all time.

But when the housing price bubble that had grown during his final four years in office finally burst, it savaged his onestellar reputation — along with the global economy.

BRIEFLY

US FTA: India seeks preferential access, says Goyal

New Delhi: Trade minister Piyush Goyal said on Monday that the trade deal with the US is taking a

little longer to sign due to the 50% tariff that was imposed on goods from the country. India aims to gain preferential access through the trade pact with the US, Goyal said while speaking at a media conclave in New Delhi. REUTERS

MARKETS

Sensex	NIFTY	Gold ▲	US Dollar ▲
77,094.07	24,102.90	▲1,47,310	▲₹94.68
291.17	89.80		
0.38%	0.37%	Silver ▲	Oil ▲
		₹2,37,801	\$78.38

NOTE: GOLD, SILVER RATES AS PER INDIA BULLION AND JEWELLERS ASSOCIATION DATA GOLD PER 10G, SILVER PER 1 KG; CRUDE OIL (INDIAN BASKET) AS OF JUNE 19, 2026

Metro Railway, Kolkata

Tender Notice for e-tendering is invited by Principal Chief Engineer, Metro Railway for the following work: **Name of work:** Zonal Contract for upkeep of elevated, overhead & underground structures, stations and allied service buildings/structures etc. at both Up & DN line from Kavi Subhash Station (KSCS) (CH: Km 6.87) to IT Centre (KTC) (CH: Km 15.22) of Metro Railway, Kolkata. **Approx. Cost of Work:** Rs. 76.72,350/- **Earnest Money:** Rs. 1.53,500/- **Completion Period:** Twenty Four (24) Months. **Date and Time of Closing:** 17.07.2026 at 12.00 Hrs. The Tender Document and other details can be obtained from the website www.ireps.gov.in Amendments/Corrigendum, if any, would be hosted only on the website.

Abridged e-Tender Notice No. : Civil-2584-2026 (Open)

Follow us at: [/metrorailwaykol](https://t.me/metrorailwaykol) [/metroraikkolkata](https://t.me/metroraikkolkata)

DISTRICT POLICE HEADQUARTERS
KATHUA
E-mail: sspkathua@jkipolice.gov.in Fax/Phone No.: 01922-234010

LOOK OUT NOTICE

On 13-06-2026, one person namely Basanta Gaan S/O Jogi Gaan R/O Orissa A/P Ward No. 04 Basohli District Kathua lodged a written report at Police Station Basohli stating therein that on 12-06-2026, at about 1300 hrs his wife namely Jhili Gaan, age 34 years is missing from home. The complainant tried his best to search his wife, but all in vain. On this, missing report vide DD No. 10 dated 13-06-2026 has been entered at Police Station Basohli.

During the course of investigation, best efforts were made to locate missing individual, whereas she is still un-traced.

As such Description Roll/Photograph of said missing individual is being shared with the appeal that anybody having clue/information about her whereabouts may inform us accordingly. The informer will be rewarded suitably:-

DESCRIPTION ROLL	PHOTOGRAPH
Name Jhili Gaan Husband Basanta Gaan Permanent Address Orissa Present Address Ward No. 04 Basohli Tehsil Basohli Police Station Basohli Age 34 years Height 5 feet 6 inch Complexion Wheatish Built Normal Face Round Eyes Black Languages known Hindi/ Dogri	

Any information related to the whereabouts of the subject may be communicated on the following contacts:-

1. DPO Kathua-01922-234010 (Phone/Fax)
2. dpo.kathua@jkipolice.gov.in (Mail ID)
3. PCR Kathua-01922-234311 (Phone/Fax)
4. Police Station Basohli - 9103007514

Sd/-
Sr. Superintendent of Police,
Kathua.

DIP/3-4213/26 DATED: 22.06.2026

MOTILAL NEHRU SCHOOL OF SPORTS

RAI-131029, DIST. SONIPAT (HARYANA)
ADVT-D01/2026

Applications are invited from the eligible and interested candidates working regular basis on the analogous post in Central/State Govt. Departments for appointment of various teaching and non-teaching posts on DEPUTATION BASIS as per standard terms & conditions of deputation prescribed in Haryana Civil Service Rules, 2016 as amended from time to time will be applied. The applications should reach on or before 07/07/2026 at 04:00 P.M at the address "The Principal & Director, MNSS, Rai -131029 (Haryana)". Applications received after the last date due to postal delay or any other reasons will not be considered. **THE POST OF MASTER (SR WING) IS AT PAR WITH PGT AND THE POST OF MASTER (JR WING) IS AT PAR WITH TGT.**

Candidates are advised to go through the instructions while applying for the following teaching & non-teaching posts to be filled on deputation basis (visit school website www.mnssrai.com)

Details of Teaching & Non-Teaching Posts and Functional Pay Level (FPL)

S.No.	Name of Post	No. of Post	FPL*	Mode of appointment
1	Computer -Master (Sr Wing)	01	FPL-08	Deputation basis for a period of one year or till vacancy is filled. The period may be extended beyond one year based on performance.
2	History - Master (Sr Wing)	01	FPL-08	
3	Hindi - Master (Sr Wing)	01	FPL-08	
4	Maths - Master (Sr Wing)	02	FPL-08	
5	Music - Master (Sr Wing)	01	FPL-08	
6	English - Master (Sr Wing)	01	FPL-08	
7	Economics - Master (Sr Wing)	01	FPL-08	
8	Physical Edu Master (Sr Wing)	01	FPL-08	
9	Sanskrit Master (Sr Wing)	01	FPL-08	
10	English - Master (Jr Wing)	01	FPL-07	
11	Science - Master (Jr Wing)	01	FPL-07	
12	Maths - Master (Jr Wing)	01	FPL-07	
13	Coach - Cricket	01	FPL-06	
14	Coach Football	01	FPL-06	
15	Coach - Hockey	01	FPL-06	

*Indicative of FPL at the time of fresh joining

- Note: -
- (a) Pay protection shall be admissible to employees joining on deputation.
 - (b) Perks & other entitlements as applicable to the corresponding staff/post of MNSS, Rai will be applicable to the persons joining MNSS, Rai on deputation.
 - (c) Number of posts may increase or decrease.
 - (d) The applicant is required to submit a No Objection Certificate (NOC) from employer, where he/she is working presently.
 - (e) Sr wing is MNSS, Rai - From Class 7th to 12th Jr Wing is Kamla Nehru School - for Class 5th & 6th

Those applicants who are serving at distant locations, or to avoid any postal delay, may submit the duly filled application form along with scanned copies of all required documents through email at mnssrai@rediffmail.com. The applicant must clearly mention the post applied for in the subject line of the email.

Sd/-
PRINCIPAL & DIRECTOR
MNSS, RAI
No.46426/HR

RAIL WHEEL FACTORY
YELAHANKA, BENGALURU - 560 064. Website: www.rwf.indianrailways.gov.in

TENDER NOTICE NO.RWF/S/146/2026-27/03 Dated: 22.06.2026

On behalf of the President of India, the Principal Chief Materials Manager invites electronic bids for the following work through the website www.ireps.gov.in from experienced/ reputed contractors in the field.

Tender No.	Due Date & Time	Distance Slab	Estimated Value (in ₹)	EMD (in ₹)
RWFSTPT_FA2nd Slab	20.07.2026 at 15:00 Hrs	Above 500Kms & upto 1000Kms. Quantity: 2550MT	65.53,500/-	1,31,100/-
RWFSTPT_S_FW1ST Slab	15.07.2026 at 15:00 Hrs	02Zero) to 500Kms Quantity: 2500MT	41.75,000/-	83,500/-
RWFSTPT_S_CWS2nd Slab	23.07.2026 at 15:00 Hrs	Above 500Kms & upto a lead distance of 1000Kms Quantity: 1300MT	53.17,000/-	1,06,300/-
RWFSTPT_S_ERC3rd Slab	24.07.2026 at 15:00 Hrs	Above 1000Kms (with a mean distance of 2500Kms) Quantity: 6600MT	4,47,15,000/-	3,73,600/-

Scope of Work: Please refer RWF and IREPS website.
Contract Period: Minimum 24 (Twenty Four) months from the date of issue of Letter of Acceptance.

PRINCIPAL CHIEF MATERIALS MANAGER

NORTHERN RAILWAY

Invitation of Tenders through E-Procurement System

Principal Chief Materials Manager, Northern Railway, New Delhi-110001, for and on behalf of the President of India, invites e-tenders through e-procurement system for supply of the following items:-

S. No.	Tender No.	Brief Description	Qty.	Closing Date
01	01260032	STAINLESS STEEL WIRE ROPE FOR REGULATING EQUIPMENT	3238 NOS	13.07.2026
02	04250043	INHIBITED MINERAL INSULATING TRANSFORMER OIL	100800 LTR	13.07.2026
03	77269034	RUNNING CONTRACT FOR CHECK RAILS 11.5M LONG	1000 SET	14.07.2026
04	08263905	AC/DC CLAMP METER CUM MULTI METER	281 NOS	21.07.2026
05	09263054A	READY MIXED PAINT	126106 LTR	27.07.2026
06	08260033	MAGNETIC TELEPHONE	7812 NOS	30.07.2026
07	09262529	PACKING	4585 NOS	05.10.2026

Note:- 1. Vendors may visit the IREPS website i.e. www.ireps.gov.in for details. 2. No manual offer will be entertained.

Tender Notice No.: 22/2026-2027 Dated: 22.06.2026 2133/2026

SERVING CUSTOMERS WITH A SMILE

NORTHERN RAILWAY

E-Tender Notice

Sr. DEE/EMU/GZB for and on behalf of President of India, Invites open e-tender for the under noted work:

GeM Bid Number	GEM/2026/B/7575616 Dated: 22.06.2026
Name of the work	AMC of Fire Extinguisher-hydraulic pressure testing, repair, refilling and testing of Fire Extinguisher type CO2 gas cartridge ABC type and ABC Dry Chemical powder stored pressure type N2 at EMU Car Shed, Ghaziabad.
Tender Cost	NIL
Approximate cost	Rs. 37,93,095.00 inclusive of GST
Earnest Money	Rs. 75,870.00 (payment mode available on GeM website)
Completion period	3 Year(s)
Validity of offer	90 days
Date & Time from tender advertised on GeM website	22.06.2026
Date & Time from tender submission start and end	22.06.2026 to 15.07.2026 15:00 Hrs.
Tender closing Date & Time	15.07.2026 15:00 Hrs.
Date & Time of tender Opening (immediately when tender submission ends)	15.07.2026 15:30 Hrs.
Publication cost allocation	06041132

Note: 1. All participant Tenderer/Tenderers will submit their requisite documents along with their tender offer. "No post tender correspondence for submission of additional document shall be entertained after opening of the Technical & Commercial offer. Even suo-moto post tender letters of the tenders shall be treated as null & void".

Note 2: Duplicate documents should not be enclosed/up loaded.

Tender Notice is available on website of www.ge.m.gov.in

GEM/2026/B/7575616 Date: 22.06.2026 2134/2026

Serving Customers With A Smile

Office of The Executive Engineer P.W.D (B&R) Division Rajgarh

NIT of 09/TC/2026-27

Rajgarh dated 19.06.2026

Tender Notice

Online Tender for mentioned below are being invited. The tender have been uploaded on the e-procurement system of Public Works Department on the Portal www.mptenders.gov.in in Tender details are as below :-

S. No.	Tender No.	District	Nature of work	Name of work	Call No.	Cost of Project (PAC) (Rs. In Lacs)	EMD	Work completion period
1	2026_PWDRB_156545_1	Rajgarh	BT Renewal	B.T. Renewal work Datagram To Kila Amargarh road Ch. 10000 to 18600 length 8.60 km	Ist	160.66	160660.00	4 Month Excluding R/S
2	2026_PWDRB_156547_1	Rajgarh	BT Renewal	B.T. Renewal work Harlay Nuniyehedi Ranjipura road Ch. 00 to 2400 and Ch. 3790 to Ch. 7120 length 5.73 km	Ist	120.65	120650.00	3 Month Excluding R/S
3	2026_PWDRB_156548_1	Rajgarh	BT Renewal	B.T. Renewal work Devlisanga to Sonkheda road Ch. 00 to 4800 length 4.80 km	Ist	100.07	100070.00	3 Month Excluding R/S
4	2026_PWDRB_156550_1	Rajgarh	BT Renewal	B.T. Renewal work Eklera to Kamalpara road Ch. 0 to 4240 length 4.24 km	Ist	90.69	90690.00	3 Month Excluding R/S
5	2026_PWDRB_156560_1	Rajgarh	BT Renewal	B.T. Renewal work Padiyamata to Dugya road length 3.72 km	Ist	83.86	83860.00	3 Month Excluding R/S
6	2026_PWDRB_156565_1	Rajgarh	BT Renewal	B.T. Renewal work Sultanpura to Bahaldi road length 3.58 km	Ist	80.77	80770.00	3 Month Excluding R/S
7	2026_PWDRB_156715_1	Rajgarh	BT Patch	Zonal B.T. Patch repair work Under PWD (B&R) Division Rajgarh	Ist	50.00	50000.00	6 Month Excluding R/S
Total						686.70		

The document can only be purchased online from the above website after making online payment. The last date & time for purchase of document on line is Dated 08.07.2026 up to 17:30 PM. Detailed NIT and other details can be viewed on the above mentioned portal. Amendments to NIT, if any, would be published on website only, and not in newspaper.

EMD and All Document submission online only.

G-14735/26

Sd/-
Executive Engineer PWD (B&R) Division Rajgarh

MADHYA GUJARAT VIJ COMPANY LIMITED
Registered Office: Sardar Patel Vidyalay Bhavan,
Race Course, Vadodra 390007
Tel.No: (0265) 2310582-86
Web Site: www.mgvcl.com
E-mail: cetech.mgvcl@gebmil.com
CIN: U40102GJ2003SGC042907

E-TENDER NOTICE

Tender is invited on turnkey base works for "Site survey including underground utility verification using (GPR & EPL), Engineering, Procurement, Supply, Loading, Transportation, Unloading, Insurance, Delivery at Site, Handling, Storage, Installation, Testing, Commissioning Including Documentation of All Items/Material required to complete works for Turnkey Based Contract For Conversion of Existing LT Line Network Including Consumer Service Lines Into Under Ground Cable Network using FSP/MSP & Ring Main System under Baroda City Circle and anywhere in Vadodra District under MGVC with GIS Mapping / Geo Urja Mapping (Developed by GUVNL) and Asset Tagging under the Gujarat Wire Free City Mission", as mentioned below:

Sr. No.	Tender No.	Tender ID	Tender Amount in Crs
1	MGVCL/TECH/LT UG/ BCC/DAKOR/26-27	316324	52.86
2	MGVCL/TECH/LT UG/BCC/ FATEHGUNJ/26-27	316311	196.93
3	MGVCL/TECH/LT UG/BCC/ GORWA/26-27	316295	186.75
4	MGVCL/TECH/LT UG/BCC/ GOTRI/26-27	316322	218.86
5	MGVCL/TECH/LT UG/BCC/ INDRAPURI/26-27	316310	270.21
6	MGVCL/TECH/LT UG/BCC/ KOYALI/26-27	316313	15.87
7	MGVCL/TECH/LT UG/BCC/ LALBAUG-GIDC/26-27	316302	186.32
8	MGVCL/TECH/LT UG/BCC/ SAMA/26-27	316305	181.57
9	MGVCL/TECH/LT UG/BCC/ TARSALI/26-27	316308	215.43
10	MGVCL/TECH/LT UG/BCC/ VASANA/26-27	316316	174.33
11	MGVCL/TECH/LT UG/ BCC/VEMALI/26-27	316319	120.25

Details of tenders can be viewed and downloaded on www.mgvcl.com Tender and can be viewed, downloaded & submitted on www.tender.nprocure.com

Chief Engineer (T&O),
MGVCL corporate office,
Vadodra

TRANSMISSION CORPORATION OF TELANGANA LIMITED

e-TENDER NOTICE

The TGTranco invites online Bids under e-procurement for supply of 220V, 100Ah Battery chargers against Tender Specification No. TGPMM21-19/2026.

Tenders can have further details and download the tender schedule from e-procurement market place i.e., www.tender.telangana.gov.in. Contact Nos.: Chief Engineer/P&MM, TGTranco Phone: 040-23396000 (Extn.: 3487/3583/3460/3332) www.tgtranco.com

DIPR R.O.No.239-PP/CIL-AGENCY/ADVT/2026-27 Dt:22-06-2026 Sd/-Chief Engineer/P&MM

KERALA WATER AUTHORITY e-Tender Notice

Tender No: WRD/KWA-CESEWA/TR/20741/2024-RT1
Others-Grey-Water Reuse Tertiary Treatment Plant at Muttathara 15MLD-Design, Construction and Commissioning of 15.00. MLD Tertiary Treatment Plant in the premises of Sewerage Treatment Plant at Muttathara and allied works-Sewerage Work, EMD: Rs.5,00,000/-, Tender fee: Rs.16540/(2978) GST, Last Date for submitting Tender : 08-07-2026 03:00pm, Phone: 8547638425, Website: www.kwa.kerala.gov.in

Superintending Engineer
KWA-JB-GL-6-114-2026-27 PPD Regional Office Thiruvananthapuram

NORTHERN RAILWAY

TENDER NOTICE

Sr. Divisional Mechanical Engineer, Northern Railway, Trainset Depot, Shakurbasti; for and on behalf of the President of India, invites IREPS (www.ireps.gov.in) for the under noted work. Tender No.: 2581019TSDSSB, Name of work: Provision for Supply and Installation of Modified Drain Pipe, Dustbin Panel, Air Duct Scoop and Anti-Condensation Insulation for Vande Bharat Coaches. Approximate cost: ₹ 90,51,383.68/- including GST. Earnest money: ₹ 1,81,100/-, Completion period of the work: 18 Months. Date and time for opening of tender: 10.07.2026 at 15:00. Website particulars notice board location complete details of tender can be seen: Above tender is available on IREPS site i.e. www.ireps.gov.in w.e.f. 18.06.2026, 18:34 hrs. No.: 25.8.1019.TSD.SSB Date: 19.06.2026 2137/2026

SERVING CUSTOMERS WITH A SMILE

BPS GMC FOR WOMEN, KHANPUR KALAN, SONIPAT

सर्व साधारण को सूचित किया जाता है कि भगत फूल सिंह महिला मैडिकल कलेज खानपुर कलान सोनीपत में Boutique-cum-Tailoring shop को दुकान को किराये पर देने के लिये खुली नीलामी निविदा 30.06.2026 को 11.00 AM बजे को जमाये। निविदा व शर्त महाविद्यालय को वेबसाईट www.bpsgmckhanpur.ac.in पर देखी जा सकती है। Mob. 9416803361

Sd/-
Incharge Purchase
BPS GMC for Women,
Khanpur Kalan, Sonapat

RO. 46446/HR

NORTHERN RAILWAY

Tender Notice

Sr. Divisional Mechanical Engineer, Northern Railway, Trainset Depot, Shakurbasti; for and on behalf of President of India, invites IREPS (www.ireps.gov.in) for the under noted work.

Tender No.	2581031TSDSSB
Name of work	Operation and Maintenance of 03 Nos. RO plants at Hydrogen Plant Jind, including condition-based replacement of components for the period of two years (Manpower + Material)
Approximate Cost	Rs. 42,57,204.00/- including GST
Earnest Money	Rs. 85,200.00/-
Completion period of the work	24 Months
Date and Time for opening of tender	15.07.2026 at 15:00 hrs.
Website particulars notice board location complete details of tender can be seen	Above tender is available on IREPS site i.e. www.ireps.gov.in w.e.f. 22.06.2026, 12:56 hrs.

No: 25.8.1031.TSD.SSB Date: 22.06.2026 2136/2026

Serving Customers With A Smile

OFFICE OF UJJAIN

DEVELOPMENT AUTHORITY

Pradhikaran Bhawan, Bharatpur Administrative Zone,
Dewas Road, Ujjain - 456010
email- udaujain@gmail.com, website- www.udaujain.org

Tender Notice

Online tenders are invited from eligible firms for the following work. Detailed tender details can be found on the website <https://mptenders.gov.in/nicgp/app>

No	Tender number & date of issue	Name of work	Last date of tender
2	UDA/ET/99/26 Date12/06/2026 2026_DTCP_515562_1	On The Behalf of Shree Mahakaleshwar Temple Management Committee UDA is authorized to call for EOI for Design Engineering Construction O and M of Multi-level Car Parking near Triveni Museum Ujjain on DBFO Basis under PPP	26/06/2026

Note: Any amendments to the tender will be published online only on the website and will not be published separately in newspapers.

(Kuldeep Raghuwanshi)
Executive Engineer, UDA, Ujjain

OFFICE OF THE SUPERINTENDING

ENGINEER PHED CITY CIRCLE AJMER

LOHA KHAN TEMPO STAND, AJMER
Telephone NO 145-2970165, E-mail address: seajmer@gmail.com

S.No. SE/Ajmer/City Circle/Ar-City I/2026-27/2349-52 Date:- 8.6.26

NOTICE INVITING TENDER

(NIT No 03/2026-27)

Online tenders are hereby invited on behalf of the Governor of Rajasthan for the following works from bidders meeting eligibility as per criteria mentioned in detailed tender document which can be seen and downloaded from website <http://eproc.rajasthan.gov.in> and <http://spp.raj.nic.in>. The tenders are to be submitted online in electronic format on website <http://eproc.rajasthan.gov.in> as per schedule given below:

S. No	Name of Work	Estimated Cost (Rs in Lacs)	Bid Security @2% (Rs)	Last date of Submission of tender	Due date for opening
03/2026-27	Revenue work related to water supply i.e meter Reading of house connection Preparation of water bill, Distribution of Bill, Preparation of Ledger and MIS Supply of Consumer binder tec.in Ajmer and Pushkar.	110.00	2,20,000/-	29-06-2026	30-06-2026

Classifieds

PERSONAL

I, Parikshit Hemanth Kumar Gowda Alias Parikshit H Gowda S/o Hemanth Kumar J V R/o C-7/297, 4th Main, BDA Layout, Domlur, Bangalore, Karnataka-560071, have changed my name to Parikshit Gowda

0071043526-1

I, Mohsin Khan S/o Riyasat Khan R/o 70, Alvi Chowk Basti Hazrat Nizamuddin New Delhi-110013. My name and date of birth had been recorded as Mohasin Khan & DOB 16.12.2001. In my Passport however my correct name is MOHSIN KHAN & DOB 10.01.2001 as per valid legal documents. 0040861864-1

I MUHAMMAD ISAQ, S/o Noor Mohd, R/o, House no.297 Main market oklha Jamia Nagar Okhla New Delhi-110025, have changed my name to Mohd Ishaq 0071043532-1

I MUHAMMAD AASIF S/o Mohd Ishaq, R/o, House no.297 Main market oklha Jamia Nagar Okhla New Delhi-110025, have changed my name to Mohd Asif 0071043477-1

I Dr Sarvesh Srivastava R/o K-2103, Trident Embassy, Sector-01, Birsakh, Greater Noida West, UP have changed my minor son's name from Arunesh Nares Shrivastava to Arunesh Srivastava. 0040861878-1

I Arpan S/o Sh. Madan Lal Rathore R/o H.No.4389, Katra Lekh Ram, Gali Bahuiji, Pahari Dhiraj, Sadar Bazar, Delhi-110006 have changed my name to Arpan Rathore for all purposes 0040861890-1

It is for general information that I, Suraj Kumar S/o Birendra Kumar Sardar R/o 156, Refral Road Ward No.- 07, Near Hotel Green Palaza, Forbesganj, Araria, Bihar - 854318, declare that name of my father has been wrongly written as Briendra Kumar Sardar in my 10th Class School Certificate cum MarksSheet. The actual name of my father is Birendra Kumar Sardar, which may be amended accordingly. 0071043503-1

It is for general information that I, SOUMYA DUTTA S/o SRIDAM CHANDRA DUTTA, R/o Kachua, Basirhat, Kachua Swarnapurnagar, PO Kachua, Distt. North 24 Parganas, West Bengal-743424, declare that name of my Mother has been wrongly written as PROTIMA DUTTA in my Passport No Y9514646. The actual name of my Mother is PRATIMA DUTTA, which may be amended accordingly. 0071043523-1

I, hitherto known as Manisha Dogra, W/o Sahil Jaryal, R/o A-2/22 Alok-Kunj, Rohini, Sector 15, Narela, North West Delhi, Delhi-110089, have changed my name and shall hereafter be known as Manisha Jaryal. 0040862006-7

I, Ziyauddin S/o-Sheziauddin, H no-A-34, S/F Left-Side Main Road Brahmapuri Seelampur Delhi-110053, have changed my name to Ziauddin. 0040861959-1

I, Vineet Kumar, S/o-Naresh Kumar Gehlot, Resident of, A65-chattarpur-village chattarpur, south delhi delhi-110074, have changed my name, from VINET KUMAR to VINET, for all purposes. Date:23.06.2026. 0040861959-13

I, Varsha, D/o Narender Kumar, W/o-Vivek Tyagi, R/o-12/842, Friends-Society Vasundhara, Ghaziabad, Uttar Pradesh-201012, have changed my name from Varsha to Varsha Tyagi, for all, future purposes. 0040861959-5

I, Tabassum, W/o-Mohd Uwais, R/o-416/14, Fourth-Floor, Front-Side, Zakir-Nagar, New Friends-Colony, New Delhi-110025, have changed my name to Tabassum Uwais. 0040862020-8

I, Varuna Sarawagi, W/o-Bikash Sarawagi, R/o-F-3/27 model town-1, 3rd-floor, Delhi-110009, Have changed my name to Varuna Bakshi Sarawagi 0040862006-8

I, TIPU CHAND BISWAS S/O BINAY CHANDRA BISWAS, H.No.46, Adarsh Nagar, Khora Colony, Ghaziabad (UP) have changed my name to TIPU BISWAS. 0040861959-3

I, Sahil Jaryal, S/o Shamsher Singh, R/o A-2/22, Alok Kunj, Sector-15, Rohini, North West Delhi, Delhi-110089, have changed the name of my minor son Yuvaan Dogra aged-8-years and he shall hereafter be known as Yuvaan Jaryal. 0040862006-5

I, Sahil Jaryal, S/o Shamsher Singh, R/o A-2/22, Alok Kunj, Sector-15, Rohini, North West Delhi, Delhi-110089, have changed the name of my minor son Yuvaan Dogra aged-8-years and he shall hereafter be known as Yuvaan Jaryal. 0040862006-6

I, SURAJ S/O-Raj Kumar R/O 1/76 Khno-13/8 A-1 Block Vijay Enclave, Palam Village, South West Delhi-110045, Have changed my name to Suraj Rawat 0040862020-2

I, Arsh Askari, S/o Aamir Askari, resident of H-37/B, Gali NO-4, Main Market Shakarpur, Delhi-110092 have changed my name to Arsh Valentine and shall hereafter be known as Arsh Valentine for all purposes. 0040861923-1

I, SAYARDEVI KAMAL SINGH GIRIA, W/O KAMAL SINGH GIRIA, R/O-T-10, FLAT.No.1001, VALLEY VIEW ESTATE, GURGAON FARIDABAD ROAD, GWAL PAHARI, GURGAON, HARYANA-122003, HAVE CHANGED MY NAME TO SAYAR DEVI GIRIA. 0040862006-10

I, SANJAY KUMAR, S/O TULSI DASS, R/O-23, JAAHZ HOUSING SOCIETY, INDER ENCLAVE ROHTAK-ROAD PASCHIM VIHAR, DELHI-110087, HAVE CHANGED MY NAME TO SANJAY KAMRA 0040862020-6

I, Ruby Jain w/o Sanjay Jain r/o A-100, Surajmal Vihar Delhi-110092, have changed my name to Rubi Jain. 0040862020-1

I, Reina Sardana D/o Sahil Sardana R/o A-342, Defence Colony, Lajpat Nagar, South Delhi, Delhi-110024, have changed my name to Clementine Sardana for all future purposes. 0040862015-2

I, Rajesh Kumar, S/o Ramesh Chander R/o-WZ-6, GF, Sharda-Puri, Ramesh Nagar, Delhi-110015, have changed my name to Rajesh for all purposes. 0040862020-9

I, REKHA, REKHA RANI KAMRA, W/O SANJAY KAMRA, D/O ISHWAR DASS, R/O JAHAZ HOUSING SOCIETY, INDER-ENCLAVE ROHTAK ROAD PASCHIM VIHAR DELHI-110087, HAVE CHANGED MY NAME TO REKHA KAMRA. 0040862020-5

I, RAJESH NAMA, S/O SH. PARAS, R/O 517/A, GALI NO.6, GOVINDPUR, KALKAJI, NEW-DELHI-110019, have changed my name, from RAJESH TO RAJESH NAMA, for all future purposes. 0040862020-7

I, Pratibha Jain S/o Shri Pramod Kumar Jain R/o D-4, Lovely Apartments, Mayur Vihar Phase-1 Extn., Delhi-110091, have changed my name to Mukesh Jain for all purposes. 0040862015-3

I, Patel Suchitkumar residence of, TMQ.No. 19/1, Tejas-camp chhankyapuri, New Delhi-110003, have changed my daughter's name, from JYANA to JYANA SUCHITKUMAR PATEL, vide-Affidavit dated-19/06/2026. 0040862006-11

I, PRADEEP KUMAR SHARMA, S/O-Prem Dutt Sharma, R/o-C-1st, 182 Gali No.4, Sangam-Vihar New-Delhi-110062, have changed my minor son name KAVYA SHARMA to KARTIK SHARMA. Age about-12-years 0040862006-2

I, LIPIKA RANI BISWAS W/O TIPU BISWAS, H.No.46, Adarsh Nagar, Khora Colony, Ghaziabad (UP) have changed my name to LIPIKA BISWAS. 0040861959-4

I, PRABHAT BISWAS, S/O TIPU BISWAR R/o H.No.46, Adarsh Nagar, Khora Colony, Ghaziabad (UP) have changed my name to PROBHAT. 0040861959-2

I, Naveen Babu Gnanamoorthi, s/o-Gnanamoorthi, r/o-D-002, Stellar MI Legacy, plot-GH-01A, vtc Rampur Jagir, Gautam Gudh-Nagar, up-201306, have changed my name Gnanamoorthi Naveen Babu to Naveen Babu, for all purpose. 0040861959-11

I, Najma Begum/Nazma Nasim, W/o, Mohd Naseem Khan R/o. 1087, Katra Ghulam Mohd, Khandani Shafakhana, Lal Kuan Delhi-110006, have changed my name to Najma Khan. 0040861959-10

I, Mohammed Yasir Nasim, S/o, Mohd Naseem Khan, R/o. 1087, Katra Ghulam Moha, Lal Kuan, Khandani Shafa Khana, Delhi-110006, have changed my name to Mohammad Yasir khan. 0040861959-8

I, Mohammed Nasim Khan, S/o, Mohd Wali Khan, R/o. 1087, Katra Ghulam Mohd, Khandani Shafakhana, Lal Kuan Delhi-110006, have changed my name to Mohd Naseem Khan. 0040861959-9

I, Manju Jindal D/o Hari Kishan Dass W/o Sushil Kumar Jindal R/o-G3/80, UGF G-3 Block Model, Town-III Delhi-110009, inform that my father name wrongly, written as HARI KISHAN Dass in my pan card but my father correct name is HARI KISHAN DASS AGGARWAL 0040862027-4

I, Mamta Rajesh Vijay/Mamta Vijay Vergia, D/o-Rajendra Kumar Vijay Vergia, W/o Rajesh-Vijay, R/o G-1001, Bestech-Parkview Grandspa, Sec-81, Gurugram (HR.), have changed my name to Mamta Vijay vergia. 0040862006-4

I, Malti, D/o-Vijaypal Singh, R/o-B-323/1, Qutub-Vihar Phase-2, Chhawla, Goyla-Dairy, Taj Pur Khurd, South West Delhi, Delhi-110071, have changed my name to Malti Rawat. 0040862006-3

I, MAHESH KUMAR S/O RAM SINGH, R/o K2/29, Mohan Garden, near Gagan Bharti School Road, Uttam Nagar, DK Mohan Garden, West Delhi-110059, have changed my name to MAHESH KUMAR BAGHEL 0040862027-7

I, Manoj Kumar S/o Ravinder Singh R/o B-130, B Block, Vikas Nagar, Uttam Nagar, West Delhi-110059, I have changed the name of my minor daughter Kavya to Kavya Rathi aged 11 years. 0071043398-1

I, Badant Grover S/o Manohar Lal Grover, R/o Flat No.5, Tower-M, Great Value Sharnam, Sector-107, Noida, UP-201304, have changed my name to BASANT GROVER for all future purposes. 0071043439-1

I, Kusum W/O-Jagdeep Sardana R/O-A-368A Chhatrapur Enclave phase-2, Flat no -B-1 Street no-36, Near-Mahavir Megha Mart New Delhi-110074, have changed to KUSUM SARDANA, Permanently 0040862020-3

I, Karthika, w/o-Naveen babu, r/o-D-002, Stellar-MI Legacy, Plot-GH-01A, VTC Rampur-Jagir, Gautam budh-Nagar, up-201306, have changed my name Karthika to Karthika Naveen Babu, for all purpose. 0040861959-12

I, KM POONAM w/o VINEET DAHIYA-R/O- 268-269, THIRD FLOOR, POCKET-8, SECTOR-23, ROHINI, DELHI-110085, have changed my name to POONAM SINGH. 0040862020-4

I, KAMAL SINGH TRILOCKCHAND JI GIRIA, S/O-TRILOCK CHNAD GIRIA, R/O T-10, FLAT.No. 1001, VALLEY VIEW ESTATE, GURGAON FARIDABAD ROAD, GWAL PAHARI, GURGAON, HARYANA-122003, HAVE CHANGED MY NAME TO KAMAL SINGH GIRIA 0040862006-9

I, JASHODA RANI THAPLIYAL W/O SURENDRA KUMAR THAPLIYAL R/O B-61 SECTOR-47 NOIDA UP HAVE CHANGED MY NAME TO JASHODA THAPLIYAL 0040862027-2

I, Housila Pershad, S/o Chhote Lal, R/o H No-2440, B-Block, Gali No-65, Sant Nagar Burari, North Delhi, Changed my name to Housila Prasad Gupta. 0040862027-3

I, Chandra Vati Singh, Mother of, Azad Singh, R/o-village-Balikarnam Purwa, Post-Rajapur, Distt-Gonda (UP), 271504, have changed my name, from Chandra Vati Singh to Chandravati Singh, vide-affidavit, dated 22 June.2026. 0040862020-11

I, BINA W/O HARI PRAKASH R/O-384 PANA UDYAN NARELA DELHI-110040, HAVE CHANGED MY NAME TO BEENA SHARMA, FOR ALL PURPOSES. 0040862027-3

I, Anish S/o-Chhabila Ram Prajapati, R/o-E-319, Aali Vihar, Sarita Vihar, Delhi-110076, have changed my name to Anish Kumar for all future purposes. 0040861959-7

I, ASHA W/o Hemant Kumar R/o H.No.1450 Saini Mohalla Najafgarh, Delhi-110043, have changed my minor daughter name HEMWATI aged 11 years to HIMANI. 0040862027-5

I, ANIL KUMAR, S/o Dalil Singh Gupta, R/o PLOT No.97, Block-A-2, Dwarka, Sector-17, Dwarka, Delhi-110078, have changed my name to ANIL GUPTA permanently 0040862027-6

I, ANIL DALMIA/ANIL KUMAR, S/O-NARESH KUMAR, R/O-436, 3RD-FLOOR, KOHAT-ENCLAVE PITAMPURA, DELHI-110034, HAVE CHANGED MY NAME TO ANIL KUMAR DALMIA. 0040862027-1

I, Sunita Kumar W/o Rajendra Kumar Mandal R/o 9010, 9th floor, Maple tower, Paramount Symphony, Crossings Republik, Ghaziabad, UP - 201016 have changed my name to Sunita for all future purposes 0071043495-1

I, Shadhi Grover W/o Basant Grover, R/o Flat No.5, Tower-M, Great Value Sharnam, Sector-107, Noida, UP-201304, have changed my name to SHASHI GROVER for all future purposes. 0071043440-1

I, SHARDENDU PANDEY S/O SHRIWAR PANDEY R/O FLAT NO.19, PLOT NO-23, ANEKANT APTMENT, VASUNDHARA ENCLAVE, DELHI-110096, SHARAD PANDEY AND SHARDENDU PANDEY BOTH ARE THE SAME PERSON. 0040861920-1

I, S M Indrich Ali Son of Arshad Ali residing at T-3-A, Ward No.8, Aulia Masjid, Mehrauli, New Delhi-110030, have change my name from S M Indrich Ali to Idrich Ali for all future purpose. 0040862015-1

I, RAJIV KHOSLA S/O MR. KRISHAN BEHARI KHOSLA R/O Rama Chandra Residency, Plot No.126, H.N. 105, First Floor, Rajendar Nagar, Sector-5, Near Khaitan Public School Gate No.2, Sahibabad, Distt. Ghaziabad, U-P-201005, have changed my name from RAJIV KUMAR KHOSLA to RAJIV KHOSLA. Henceforth I would be known by the name of RAJIV KHOSLA for all future purposes. 0040861935-1

I, No.15723089H (HAV) Makwana Samratsinh Mahipatsinh, R/o Vill-Bhadiyad, Dhokera, Ahmedabad, Gujarat-382463, declare that my mine has been updated as Samratsinh Mahipatsinh Makwana in my minor son's name, Maanyrajsinh Samratsinh Makwana birth certificate. Whereas, my name is Makwana Samratsinh Mahipatsinh, mentioned in my all other documents. Both names belong to me. 0071043431-1

I, No. 2707297N Nk Sanyam, R/o VIII, Kakrolli Sardaka, Teh. Badhra, Dist. Charkhi Dadri, Haryana-127308, have changed my son's name from Aary to Aarav, vide affidavit dated 18/06/2026 before Notary Public, Delhi. 0040861871-1

I, Hemanth Kumar J V S/o Vishakante Gowda R/o C-7/297, 4th Main, BDA Layout, Domlur, Bangalore, Karnataka-560071, have changed my minor son's name from Dhimant Hemanth Kumar Gowda Alias Dhimant H Gowda aged 12 years to Dhimant Gowda forever 0071043508-1

I, Jayaan W/o Mohd Ummer R/o H.No. E-12/72, Hauz Rani, Malviya Nagar, New Delhi-110017, have changed my name from Jayaan to Jaibun Nisha for all future purposes. 0040861904-1

I, Chhabila Ram, S/o, Palki Ram, R/o.E-319, Aali Vihar, Sarita Vihar, Delhi-110076, have changed my name to Chhabila Ram Prajapati for all future purposes. 0040861959-6

I, Arun Kumar S/o Sushil Kumar r/o BE-136, Hari Nagar, Delhi-110064 have changed my name to ARUN KUMAR SARPAL 0040861907-1

I, Ankush Chourasia R/O E101, Gulshan Vivante, Sector 137, Noida, UP-201305 have changed my minor son's name from Kiyaan Chourasia to Aarsh Chourasia born on 25/03/2018 vide affidavit dt:22/06/2026 sworn before Notary at Noida 0040861927-1

I, Alakumishia W/o Jaan Mohammad R/o-39, Ali prem Garden, Pasonda, Ghaziabad have changed my name to Alkunisha. 0071043443-1

I, Abdul Rasheed S/o shakur, R/o 309, Purwa ahmad nagar, near Jali kothi, Meerut-250002, have changed my name ro Rasheed Ahmed 007104384-1

I have changed my son's name from Vansh to Vansh Gupta for all future purposes. Geeta W/o Santosh Kumar R/o 54 A Kashiram Awash Yojna Sector-45, Noida G.B. Nagar UP 201301 0071043413-1

I have changed my Daughter's name from Khushi to Khushi Gupta for all future purposes. Geeta W/o Santosh Kumar R/o 54 A Kashiram Awash Yojna Sector-45, Noida G.B. Nagar UP 201301 0071043416-1

I Shail Devi W/o Bhola Jha R/o RZ-36, A-Block, Arjun Park, Najafgarh, Delhi-110043, have changed my name to Rani Devi 0071043520-1

LOST & FOUND

My original documents, i.e. ownership papers of Property No.T-201/A, Baljeetnagar, New Delhi-110008, has been lost. finder contact: Chander Prakash Malhotra S/o, Bansi Lal Malhotra. Mobile- 00212442952 0040862020-12

I, Rakesh Kumar Singh/Amritesh Kumar Singh, resident of Plot.No. 259 SF-3, Gyan Khand-1, Indrapuram, Ghaziabad, hereby inform you that my Flat No.259/SF-3 authentic registry paper No. I-27880 has been lost from DDA Market, Indrapuram, while being photocopied on May 10, 2026. Contact:- 987392343. A suitable reward will be given to the person who returns the paper. 0071043445-1

PUBLIC NOTICE

IN THE HIGH COURT OF DELHI AT NEW DELHI
Notice Under Order V Rule 20 Code of Civil Procedure
Case No. F43 396/2014 & CH APPL. 2020/20204. 28/06/2020
Appeal Against order dated 10.11.2014 Passed By Sh. Ajay Gopal, Additional District Judge-12, Central District, Delhi
In Case No Private Petition No. 42/07 PAUL SINGHAppellant/s
Vs
STATE & ORSRespondent/s

Notice to: R-5: SHUKANTALA, W/O SH. CHARAN SINGH, R/O 3226/235, TRI NAGAR, DELHI R/o in Tower E/F-4
I, W. BALJEET SINGH, S/O LATE SMT. RANJIT KAUR, R/O NEAR KALIWARA MANDIR, AMBALA CANTT. HARYANA-135001
I/II. MR. MANJEET SINGH, S/O LATE SMT. RANJIT KAUR, R/O H-106, AGARWAL TOWER, NETAJI SUBHAS PALACE, PITAMPURA, DELHI-110034
Whereas the above noted appellant has presented an appeal under Order XLII Rule 1 Read With Section 104 of the Code of Civil Procedure, 1908 which was listed before the Court on 19.02.2016 and the Court ordered issuance of notice to you. And whereas it has been proved to the satisfaction of the Court that you cannot be served in the ordinary manner. Notice is hereby issued that if you wish to defend the above mentioned appeal and application you may cause an appearance to be entered on your behalf either in person or through an advocate duly appointed for the purpose before the Joint Registrar (Judicial) on 13.07.2026 at 11:00 A.M.
If no appearance is made on your behalf, by yourself, your pleader or someone by law authorized to act for you in the said appeal and application on the aforementioned date, no further notice of the subsequent date of hearing of the said appeal and application will be given and the same will be heard and determined ex parte in your absence.
Given under my hand and seal of this Court, this the 22nd day of April, 2026
Assistant Registrar
For Registrar General

Progressive Law Group
9/14, IIIrd Floor,
East Patel Nagar
New Delhi 110008
Mob. 9871430462

PUBLIC NOTICE
I, Abhinash Kumar Mishra, S/o Late Sh. B. N. Mishra R/o Village Jogia Tola Khangan Prachayatt Gokula P.S. Bandhwa Kurawa Bounsi District Banka Bihar, hereby declare that I have disowned and debarred my son Sh. Rajesh Mishra (Mob. 9718384761) and my daughter-in-law Smt. Namrata Mishra (Mob. 9549321572) from all my movable and immovable properties with effect from 21.06.2026 due to their misconduct. They shall have no right, title, interest or claim over any of my properties. Any person dealing with them in respect of my properties shall do so at his/her own risk. I shall not be responsible for any act, liability or transaction undertaken by them.
Sd/-
HARISH GOLA (Advocate)
Ch. No. F-728, K.K.D. Courts, Delhi-52

PUBLIC NOTICE
To be known to all that my client Mr. Sushil Kumar Sharma and Mr. Sanjay Kumar S/o Late Sh. Bhanu Singh Sharma R/o A-1/1793, Keshav Prasad Enclave, in possession of L.R. Flat bearing No. A-1078K, Second Floor, situated at Lawrence Road, Keshav Puram, Delhi, original Allotment Letter, Possession Letter, Share Partition, N.O.C. for Water & Electricity Connections, fourth copy of all Bank Challans, Conveyance Deed Allotment issued by DDA of the said Flat have been lost. N.O.C. in this effect has been lodged through online. Vide LR No. 1796/2020B dt. 10/06/2020. Any persons claiming any rights, interests, having any objection or found in possession of said original Allotment Letter, Possession Letter, Share Partition, N.O.C. for Water & Electricity Connections, fourth copy of all Bank Challans, Conveyance Deed Allotment may Withdrawn with above named person at above address/phone within 7 days from the date of publication of this notice.
Sd/-
ARVIND KUMAR
Advocate
Encl. No. D-197105

PUBLIC NOTICE
Under instructions from my client, Mr. Ajay Kapoor, I hereby give this public notice to all concerned that his son, Mr. Gohar Kapoor, S/o Ajay Kapoor, R/o 312-S1, Sarawati Apartments, Sector-D, Pocket-6, Vasant Kunj, South West Delhi, Delhi-110070, has been completely disowned and debarred from all movable and immovable, ancestral, and self-acquired properties, assets, and businesses of my client. There is no relation between my client and his son Mr. Gohar Kapoor.
Henceforth, my client Mr. Ajay Kapoor shall not be held liable or responsible for any of his acts, deeds, liabilities, contracts, loans, monetary transactions, or obligations, financial or otherwise, committed by the said Mr. Gohar Kapoor. Anyone dealing with him shall do so entirely at their own risk and consequences.
Sd/-
SUSHIL KUMAR GUPTA
Advocate
CH NO. 575, SAKET COURT COMPLEX, NEW DELHI-110009

PUBLIC NOTICE
I, Priyanka Bansal, W/o. Mr. Ravi Kant Gupta R/o C-3/354, 3rd Floor, Janakpuri, ND-58, being allotted vide DDA File No. F. 15/414/70/LAS/UNDER LIG have lost their Original Possession Letter, NOC Sheet of Water and Electricity Connection issued by DDA favoring Shri Ravi Kant Gupta for aforesaid property has been lost. A.F.I.R. LR. No. 28/155/2026 dated 05.05.2026 to this effect has been lodged to police station. Any person found in possession of original documents may write/contact the above named person at above address within one month from the date of publication of this notice and can personally contact Shri Ravi Kant Gupta, R/o C-3/354, 3rd Floor Janakpuri, ND-58, Ph. 9959221987

PUBLIC NOTICE
The general public is hereby notified that my client Sh. Jai Prakash Gupta S/o Late Sh. Raj Bahadur Gupta, R/o H.No. 69 H-35, Sector-5, Rohini, Delhi-110085, has disowned his son, Sh. Sushant Gupta and his wife, Smt. Kaveri Gupta W/o Sh. Sushant Gupta, due to their misconduct, Disobedience and disrespectful behaviour. They have no claim on his movable or immovable properties. My client and his family have severed all ties and are not responsible for their actions or obligations. Any engagement with Sh. Sushant Gupta and his wife Smt. Kaveri Gupta is at the public's own risk.
Aarti Vohra Sahni (Advocate)
D/o.230 Rohini Court Delhi.

PUBLIC NOTICE
My clients Mr. Ram Nath residents of P3A-092, Princeton estate, DLF Phase-5, Sector-53, Gurgaon, Haryana-122009, do hereby declare that they have disowned and debarred their Son Vikram Meeniratta from all movable and immovable properties due to their disrespectful behavior and out of control.
All relations with their have been severed. Any dealings with them will be at the risk, cost, and consequence of the parties involved. Our clients shall not be liable or responsible for any such dealings.
Sd/-
KAMAL SINGH (Advocate)
Encl. No. D/748/2014

PUBLIC NOTICE
My Client Sh. Amarjit Singh Mediratta S/o Late Sh. Niranjan Singh and Smt. Harjeet Kaur W/o Amarjit Singh Marrieda both R/o A-163, 2nd & 3rd Floor, Paten Nagar, New Delhi-110016 that they have disowned their elder son Sh. Mohit Preet Singh, his wife Manpreet Kaur D/o Sh. Satnam Singh. They have debarred and disowned them from all movable and immovable properties. My client shall not be responsible for any of their acts, conducts and deeds. Any person dealing with them may deal their own risk and responsibilities.
Sd/- B.B.N.O.P. Adv. Advocate
S.R.Ind & Campus, Janki Puri ND-58

PUBLIC NOTICE
For & on behalf of my clients
VAJID ALI S/o Nizamuddin & SUFIA KHATUN W/o Vajid Ali, R/o Plot No 2, Gali No 17 Yadav Enclave, Vikas Puri, Uttam Nagar, Delhi-110059 have disowned their son HASMAT ALI & his wife ANAM SHAH. Due to inappropriate behavior and mental harassment, She disowned and debar him/her from all her movable and immovable properties. My clients will not be responsible for their acts. Any one dealing with them shall do at his own risk.
Sohan Kumar (Advocate)
B-5, Sunjea Tower-1, District Center Janakpuri, New Delhi-110058

COURT NOTICE

IN THE HIGH COURT OF DELHI AT NEW DELHI
Notice Under Order V Rule 20 Code of Civil Procedure
Case No. F43 396/2014 & CH APPL. 2020/20204. 28/06/2020
Appeal Against order dated 10.11.2014 Passed By Sh. Ajay Gopal, Additional District Judge-12, Central District, Delhi
In Case No Private Petition No. 42/07 PAUL SINGHAppellant/s
Vs
STATE & ORSRespondent/s

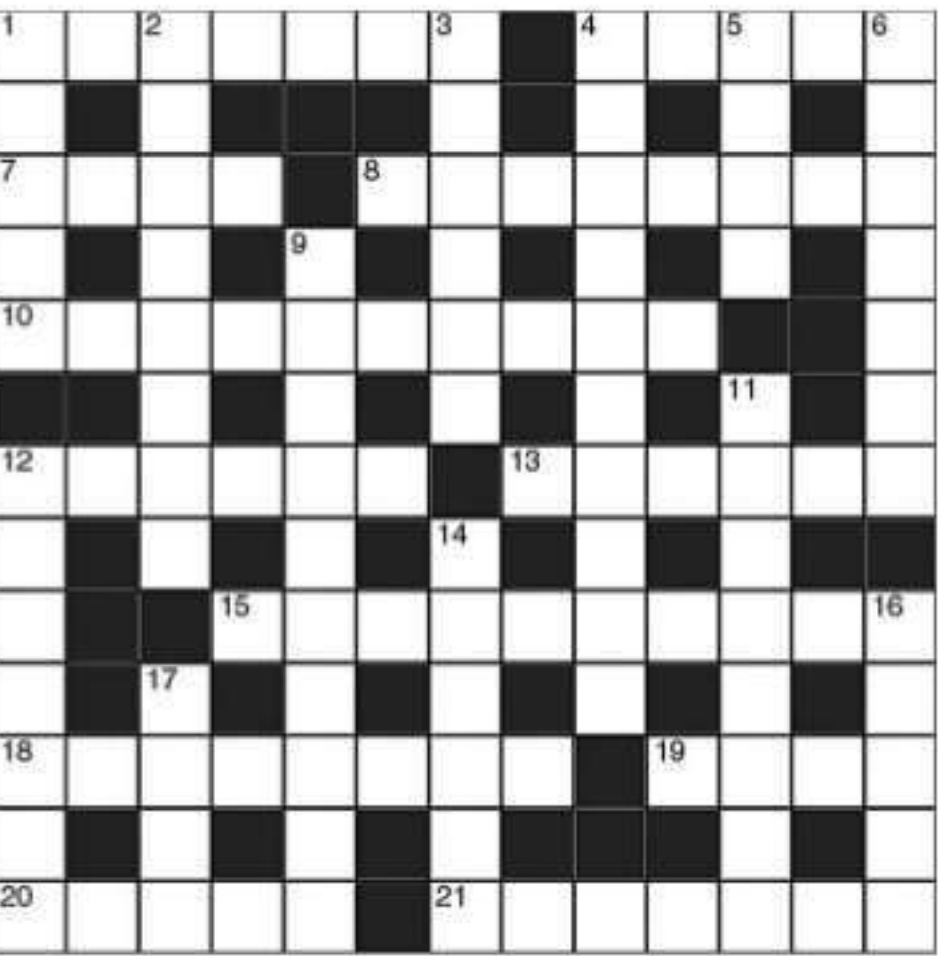
"IMPORTANT"
Whilst care is taken prior to acceptance of advertising copy, it is not possible to verify its contents. The Indian Express (P) Limited cannot be held responsible for such contents, nor for any loss or damage incurred as a result of transactions with companies, associations or individuals advertising in its newspapers or Publications. We therefore recommend that readers make necessary inquiries before sending any monies or entering into any agreements with advertisers or otherwise acting on an advertisement in any manner whatsoever.

E-TENDER NOTICE

DRM (Electrical) O/P/ECR/Dhanbad for and behalf of the President of India, invites E-Tender for the execution of following work.
E-Tender No. : GEM/2026/B/7669680, dated

CROSSWORD

6022



- ACROSS
- 1 Vessels if not exactly clippers (7)
- 4 Tidy up? No, down! (5)
- 7 Prepare to put out with the turn of the tide (4)
- 8 Warning of course takes over as anticipated (8)
- 10 Sharply picked out (10)
- 12 Sailor's way to make ends meet (6)
- 13 Produced a publication and is taken to court (6)
- 15 Unable to work after leaving the fraternity? (3,2,5)
- 18 All too human story in which evil makes a comeback (8)
- 19 A man heading for jug? (4)
- 20 How bread's gone up! (5)
- 21 Festival time without sun (7)
- DOWN
- 1 A man in a cap is seen as poor (5)
- 2 Eternal source of family strife? (8)
- 3 Has nothing to do with a grain-carrying ship (6)
- 4 Stress follows before a claim (10)
- 5 His aim is to make a victim lose heart (4)
- 6 Poverty led to being irritated (7)
- 9 Judgment is arrived at in the end (10)
- 11 Exits in the open air (8)
- 12 Being of stern disposition is summoned (4,3)
- 14 Mass-produced legislation? (3,3)
- 16 Some light on artificial stuff (5)
- 17 They're given to those who beg for weapons we hear (4)

SOLUTIONS CROSSWORD 6021 ACROSS: 1 Man of action, 9 Novices, 10 Eagle, 11 Ells, 12 Armagnac, 14 Picnic, 16 Debate, 18 Resigned, 19 Odds, 22 Trial, 23 Release, 24 Storm signal DOWN: 2 Anvil, 3 Once, 4 Assert, 5 Teenager, 6 Organza, 7 Intemperate, 8 Teacher's pet, 13 Singular, 15 Casuist, 17 Hearts, 20 Drama, 21 Flag

JUMBLED WORDS

Given below are four jumbled words. Solve the jumbles to make proper words and move them to the respective circles below. Select the letters in the shaded circles and jumble them to get the answer for the given quip.

The season of ____ is the best time for sowing the seeds of success. - Paramahansa Yogananda (7)

ANOLE

PPSYLU

RIPER

ACETUF

SOLUTIONS: Alone, Prior, Supply, Faucet

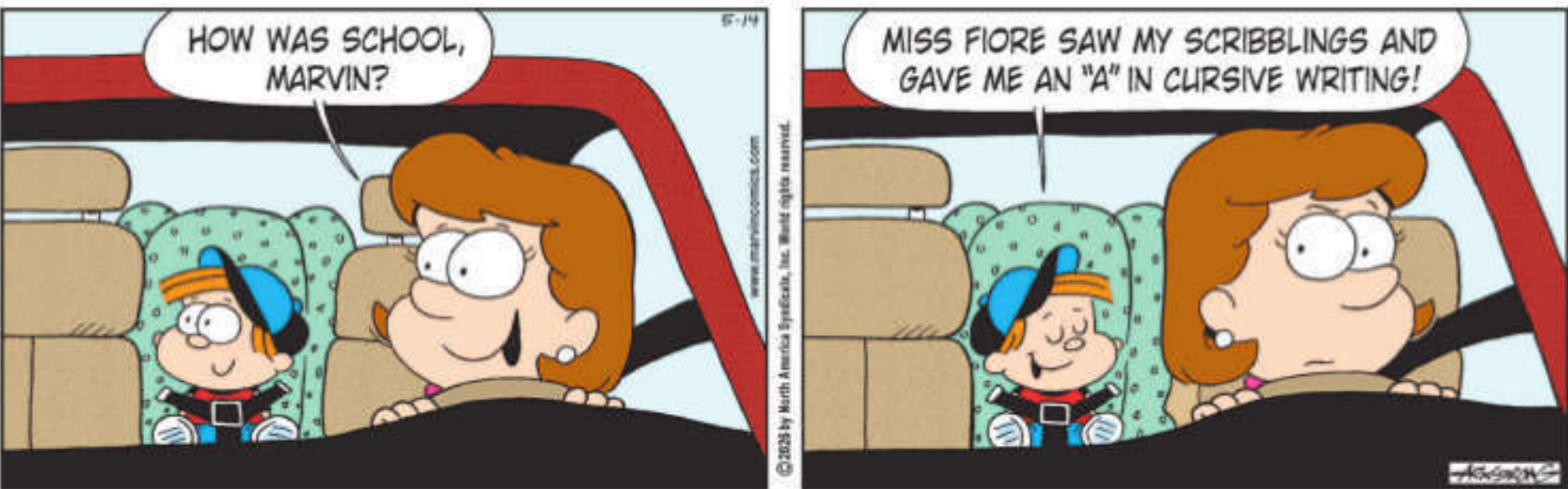
OVER THE HEDGE



CALVIN & HOBBS



MARVIN



DIFFICULTY LEVEL 1s INSTRUCTIONS

To solve a Sudoku puzzle, every digit from 1 to 9 must appear in each of the nine vertical columns, in each of the nine horizontal rows and in each of the nine boxes.

DIFFICULTY LEVEL

1s = Very easy; 2s = Easy; 3s = Medium; 4s = Hard; 5s = Very Hard; 6s = Genius

SUDOKU 6358

SOLUTION SUDOKU 6357

ROYAL STARS

BY GEORGIA NICOLS

- ARIES (MAR 21 - APR 20): This is a poor day for an important family discussion, because your feelings will affect what you say today, especially your logic. If you're discussing how to address an issue, your feelings might cloud what's important. Tonight: Warm feelings.
- TAURUS (APR 21 - MAY 21): Tread carefully when talking to siblings, relatives or neighbours today. You might be over excited about an idea. You're eager to communicate. Think before you speak. Tonight: Accept help.
- GEMINI (MAY 22 - JUNE 21): Be careful how you spend your money today. This is because it's easy for you to get carried away in the moment. Check yourself. Tonight: Good times.
- CANCER (JUNE 22 - JULY 23): You are a sensitive person. This is why you can be moody. Today Mercury in your sign is at odds with the Moon, which blurs your logic because your analytical abilities are flooded with feelings. It's a poor day for important decisions. Tonight: Happy home.
- LEO (JULY 24 - AUG 23): Today it's in your best interests to think twice before you rally your forces or demand something. Fortunately, the Venus in your sign will soften your approach and make you charming and diplomatic. Go gently. Tonight: Warm optimism.
- VIRGO (AUG 24 - SEP 23): Be circumspect in discussions with friends, groups and organisations today, because others might see you as being too emotionally invested in what you're saying. You have sway with groups. Be careful and be precise. Tonight: Generous impulses.
- LIBRA (SEP 24 - OCT 23): Today you might talk to someone in authority. It's important to know that — in their eyes — what you say might be weakened because you're speaking from your feelings rather than logic. You might have to censor yourself. Tonight: Inspiration.
- SCORPIO (OCT 24 - NOV 23): Avoid controversial topics today, because you might become so involved in something that your feelings overwhelm your rational intellect. You have a strong need to communicate to others. Steer clear of controversy. Tonight: Inner peace.
- SAGITTARIUS (NOV 24 - DEC 22): Be cautious when talking to friends or groups today. Your feelings might cloud your clear thinking. Postpone important discussions for another day. Tonight: Warm friendships.
- CAPRICORN (DEC 23 - JAN 20): People notice you today, and some will know personal details about your private life. Think twice before saying anything, because you might be more emotional than usual, which will cause you to share something you might later regret. Forewarned is forearmed. Tonight: Be a role model.
- AQUARIUS (JAN 21 - FEB 19): You want to travel or get a change of scenery. You also might be dealing with foreign countries, work-related travel or people from other cultures. Think before you speak. Tonight: Lofty thoughts.
- PISCES (FEB 20 - MAR 20): You might get involved in a discussion about shared costs relating to your kids, the cost of a vacation or something to do with the arts. This is a poor day to discuss money because your feelings are wrapped up with your ideas. Tonight: Generosity.

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

(See Section 82 Cr.PC/84 Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita)

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused Person(s) **Mukesh Kumar @ Sachin @ Golu, S/o Sh. Raj Kumar R/o H.No.280, Gali No.7, Mandoli Chungi, Near Nand Nagri, Delhi-110093** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case **FIR No.312/2024 dated 20.07.2024 u/s 25 Arms Act, P.S. Special Cell, New Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused **Mukesh Kumar @ Sachin @ Golu** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Mukesh Kumar @ Sachin @ Golu** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused **Mukesh Kumar @ Sachin @ Golu** of **FIR No.312/2024 dated 20.07.2024 u/s 25 Arms Act, P.S. Special Cell, New Delhi** is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **10.08.2026**.

By Order,
Sh. Mridul Gupta
Additional Chief Judicial Magistrate
North Room No. 117
Rohini Court, Delhi

DP/8386/Spl.Cell/2026

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 82 Cr.P.C.

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused Person(s) **Pooja, W/o: Lt. Vikram R/o: J-1949, Jahangirpuri, Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in **FIR No. 53/2021, U/s: 33/38 D. Excise Act, PS: Mahendra Park, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused person(s) **Pooja**, cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused person(s) **Pooja**, has absconded (or is concealing herself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused person(s) **Pooja**, of **FIR No. 53/2021, U/s: 33/38 D. Excise Act, PS: Mahendra Park, Delhi** is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **13.10.2026**.

By Order
Amardeep. Kaur
Additional Chief Judicial Magistrate
North Room No. 117
Rohini Court, Delhi

DP/8410/NW/2026
(Court Matter)

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 82 Cr.P.C.

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused **Kanhiya, S/o: Suresh, R/o: A3/210, Mangal Bazar, Sultanpuri, Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case **FIR No.: 345/23, U/s: 379/411 IPC, P.S. Karol Bagh, New Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said **Kanhiya** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said **Kanhiya** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused **Kanhiya** of **P.S. Karol Bagh, New Delhi** is required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before **29.07.2026**.

By Order
Sh. Nishat Bangarh
Ld. JMFC-01, (Central), Room No. 180,
Tis Hazari Court, Delhi

DP/8251/CD/2026

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 82 Cr.P.C.

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused Person **Bablu S/o: Mansoor Ali, R/o: Vegabond Jamuna Bazar Kashmere Gate, Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in **FIR No. 230/2023, U/S: 27/61/85 NDPS ACT, PS: Kashmere Gate, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused person(s) **Bablu**, cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused person(s) **Bablu**, has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused person **Bablu**, of **FIR No. 230/2023, U/S: 27/61/85 NDPS ACT, PS: Kashmere Gate, Delhi**, is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **30.07.2026**.

By Order
Sh. Vaibhav Garg
Judicial Magistrate First Class-11
Court No. 138
Tis Hazari Court, Delhi

DP/8174/N/2026
(Court Matter)

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 82 Cr. P.C.

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused Person(s) **Shabbir Khan, S/o: Mohamad R/o: Village Rohai, ANS-Tehsil, Sadabad Thana Chandpa, Dist. Hathras, Uttar Pradesh** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in **E-FIR No. 000256/16, U/s: 380/411 IPC, PS: Mahindra Park, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused person(s) **Shabbir Khan**, cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused person(s) **Shabbir Khan**, has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused person(s) **Shabbir Khan**, of **E-FIR No. 000256/16, U/s: 380/411 IPC, PS: Mahindra Park, Delhi** is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **20.11.2026**.

By Order
Amardeep. Kaur
Additional Chief Judicial Magistrate
North Room No. 117
Rohini Court, Delhi

DP/8409/NW/2026
(Court Matter)

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

(See Section 82 Cr. P.C./84 BNSS)

Whereas complaint has been made before me that the accused **Farukh S/o Sukar Ali, R/o C-425, JJ Colony, Bawana, Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in **FIR No. 63/2021 dated 13.02.2021 U/s 279/338 IPC & 3/181 MV ACT, PS Narela Industrial Area, Delhi** and it has been returned to warrant of arrest there upon issued that the said accused **Farukh** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Farukh** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that **Farukh** in **FIR No. 63/2021 dated 13.02.2021 U/s 279/338 IPC & 3/181 MV ACT, PS Narela Industrial Area, Delhi** is required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before **24.07.2026**.

By order
Sh. Sahil Gupta
Judicial Magistrate First Class
North, Court No. 06, 1st Floor
Rohini Courts, Delhi

DP/8427/ON/2026

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 82 Cr.P.C.

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused person **Nishant S/o Bijender R/o H.No. 686, Partap ki Kothi, Kanjhawala Road, Bawana, Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence **FIR No. 188/2021 u/s 25/54/59 Arms Act at P.S. Narela Industrial Area, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said **Nishant** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said **Nishant** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proceeding **u/s 82 Cr.P.C.** has been initiated in the case. Proclamation is hereby made that the said **Nishant** accused of **FIR No. 188/2021 u/s 25/54/59 Arms Act at P.S. Narela Industrial Area, Delhi** is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on **27.07.2026**.

By Order: Shri Sahil Gupta,
Judicial Magistrate First Class,
North Court No. -06, First Floor,
Rohini Courts, Delhi.

DP/8441/ON/2026

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 82 Cr. P.C.

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused Person(s) **Neeraj Kumar, S/o: Rajender Kumar R/o: H.No. C-22, Rishi Nagar Amar Colony, Nangloi, Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in **FIR No. 321/2022, U/s: 25 IPC, PS: Nangloi, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused person(s) **Neeraj Kumar**, cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused person(s) **Neeraj Kumar**, has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused person(s) **Neeraj Kumar**, of **FIR No. 321/2022, U/s: 25 IPC, PS: Nangloi, Delhi** is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **04.08.2026**.

By Order
Renu
Judicial Magistrate First Class-10
West Room No. 345
Tis Hazari Court, Delhi

DP/8110/OD/2026
(Court Matter)

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 82 CrPC / 84 Bhartiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita, 2023

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused Person **Amit Sharma @ Khem Chand S/o Uma Shankar, R/o A-24, Gali No.-2, Gokulpuri Village, Delhi**, has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in **FIR No. 317/19, U/S 279/338 IPC 3/181/146/196/185/5/181/39/192 MV Act, PS Bhajanpura, North-East Distt., Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused person cannot be found, and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused person has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant); Proclamation is hereby made that **Amit Sharma @ Khem Chand** the said accused of **FIR No. 317/19, U/S 279/338 IPC 3/181/146/196/185/5/181/39/192 MV Act, PS Bhajanpura, North-East Distt., Delhi**, is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **27.08.2026**.

By Order
Sh. Pankaj Rai
Judicial Magistrate First Class-01,
North-East, Court No.-73,
Karkardooma Court, Delhi

DP/7963/NE/2026
(Court Matter)

Bangalore Electricity Supply Company Limited

(Wholly owned by Govt. of Karnataka undertaking)
(CIN-U04010KA20025GCG030438)

BRIEF TENDER NOTIFICATION (Through KPP Portal)

BESCOM invites tenders through KPP Portal from eligible bidders against Enquiry No: **BESCOM/2026-27/IND0259 for Procurement of LT Distribution Boxes for 100 kVA and 250 kVA Distribution Transformers for BESCOM area as per Tender Specification and GTP. Bid Documents available: 22.06.2026 onwards. Last date for Bid Submission: 22.07.2026, 17:00Hrs. Opening of Bid Document: 23.07.2026, 17:15 Hrs. The Tenders can be obtained through KPP portal Website: https://kppp.karnataka.gov.in. Aspiring Bidders need to register on KPP portal. Further Bidders can take assistance with KPP help desk contact numbers: +91-8046010000, +91-8068948777 or email at support@ eprochelpdesk.com. Further details can be obtained from the office of the undersigned.**

Sd/-Chief General Manager(Ele.),
Procurement, Corporate office,
BESCOM, 2nd Floor, K R Circle,
Bengaluru-560001.

For Electricity related complaints call : 1912

Download BESCOM Mithra Mobile APP.

DP/8404/NW/2026
(Court Matter)

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 82 Cr. P.C.

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused Person(s) **Ishwar @ Pintu, S/o: Anil Gupta R/o: H.No. H-3/1181-82 Jahangirpuri, Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in **FIR No. 128/2019, U/s: 33 D.Excise Act, PS: Jahangirpuri, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused person(s) **Ishwar @ Pintu**, cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused person(s) **Ishwar @ Pintu**, has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused person(s) **Ishwar @ Pintu**, of **FIR No. 128/2019, U/s: 33 D.Excise Act, PS: Jahangirpuri, Delhi** is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **23.07.2026**.

By Order
Sahil Gupta
Judicial Magistrate First Class-07
North Court No. 06 1st Floor
Rohini Court, Delhi

DP/8404/NW/2026
(Court Matter)

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 84 BNSS

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused **Vikash @ Suraj S/o Chitwan Kewat R/o House No. 217, Gali No. 03, Jeevan Park, Libaspur, Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case registered vide **FIR No. 1406/2021 U/S 25/54/59 Arms Act, PS Mahendra Park, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest their upon issued that the said accused **Vikash @ Suraj** can not be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said **Vikash @ Suraj** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused **Vikash @ Suraj** of **FIR No. 1406/2021 U/S 25/54/59 Arms Act, PS Mahendra Park, Delhi** is required to appear before this court (or before me) to answer the complaint on or before the day of **23.07.2026 at 10:00 am**

By Order
Ms. Amar Deep Kaur
Addl. Chief Judicial Magistrate
North District, Room No. 117
Rohini Courts, Delhi

DP/8343/NW/2026(Court Matter)

● RESULTS
GROUP H
Spain 4-0 Saudi Arabia Atlanta Stadium
Uruguay 2-2 Cape Verde Miami Stadium
GROUP G
Belgium 0-0 Iran Los Angeles Stadium
New Zealand 1-3 Egypt Vancouver Stadium
GROUP J
Argentina 2-0 Austria Dallas Stadium

● MATCH SCHEDULE
GROUP J
Jordan vs Algeria San Francisco, 8.30 am (Tuesday)
GROUP K
Portugal vs Uzbekistan Houston, 10.30 pm (Tuesday)
Colombia vs DR Congo Guadalajara, 7.30 am (Wednesday)
GROUP L
England vs Ghana Boston, 1.30 am (Wednesday)
Panama vs Croatia Toronto, 4.30 am (Wednesday)
ZEE5 OTT & UNITE8 CHANNELS



Djed Spence. REUTERS

Defender Spence unconcerned by Tuchel shouting

ENGLAND DEFENDER Djed Spence said he was unfazed by Thomas Tuchel's outburst at training, describing the German coach's demands for high standards as "part of the game" as England pursue World Cup glory. Video of Tuchel shouting "Djed, Djed, Djed, wake up!" during a passing drill in training on Saturday went viral. "It's normal," Spence said. "He's a great manager. He wants the best from his players. He demands high standards and for this tournament, we need to be ready, we need to be on it." REUTERS

Schlotterbeck out of World Cup with ankle injury

GERMANY CENTRAL defender Nico Schlotterbeck will miss the rest of the World Cup and will be sidelined for several months after picking up an ankle ligament injury in their 2-1 Group E victory over Ivory Coast on Saturday, the team said on Monday. Schlotterbeck, a starting centre-back, was injured early in the game and was replaced at halftime by Antonio Ruediger. A scan on Sunday revealed the player had torn a ligament in his left ankle. REUTERS

● DEFINING ATTACKING TREND

How the low-ball across six-yard box is World Cup's top goalscorer

Teams are driving passes across goal-mouth to confuse defenders, find goals

Mihir Vasavda
Mumbai, June 22

LAMINE YAMAL'S goal against Saudi Arabia looked simple. That was exactly the point. The move began with Spain breaking down the left before Mikel Oyarzabal whipped a low pass across the six-yard box. Yamal arrived at the far post and tapped in. No complicated build-up, just a hard ball across goal and a runner arriving at the right moment. Yet that goal may have captured one of the defining attacking trends of this World Cup. For all the talk about spectacular long-range strikes, teams are increasingly finding

Messi misses from spot, then strikes twice to become WC's greatest scorer

Sandip G
New York, June 22

IN THE space of half an hour, Lionel Messi showed he is mortal yet immortal. Like Diego Maradona 40 years ago on the same day, with a goal scored by his hand and another with his imagination. Messi missed a spot kick, before he scored a belter and added one more late in the game for a 2-0 Argentina win. In the ninth minute of the game, against Austria, an upgrade on Algeria, the team Messi eviscerated, he fluffed a penalty. Anticipation buzzed, the cameras converged to not Messi, but his priceless left leg. He measured his steps, kissed the ball and set off, the run-up intentionally stuttered. The world waited breathlessly for the his-

toric moment when he could become the highest goal-scorer in the World Cup, another entry into his album of consummate greatness. The next moment, the arena shook in silence. The infallible failed to burst the nets, his shot weak and wayward. The audience might have rubbed their eyes to fathom if it were real or imagined. It was just the 33rd spot kick he had missed in his entire career (out of 111) attempts. The curse of the Nelson they say. Messi rubbed his eyes in disappointment. But he didn't grieve, because he knows the vicissitudes of the game, the imperfections and the mortality of even the immortals. Thirty interminable minutes later, he atoned in a more fitting way to break the record of Miro-



Lionel Messi became the highest goalscorer in World Cup history, picking up his 17th and 18th goals on Monday. AP

slav Klose than a soft penalty, in a manner that would gloriously sum up his career. A left-footed whip that blasted into the nets. Thiago Almada raced with the ball to the left, passed to Facundo Medina, who lashed a cut

back into the box. The target was Medina, but he stepped over it while dragging all the defenders into him. Messi, galloping like a pony, pinged it with the precious left foot of himself. He ran towards the corner flag, gazed at

the sparkling blue skies, both hands aloft in his signature pose, before the teammates swarmed him. Messi's response was mild, a smile that contained all the devilish genius about him. The goals made him the highest goal scorer in the World Cups with 18 to his name. In this number, he could watch his entire career, the years he reeled under the burden of Diego Maradona, the elusive World Cups, the near retirement, the wrath of his countrymen, the redemption and the glory in Qatar. Stuningly, 12 of those 18 goals have come in the last two editions. Many layers of Messi are embedded in the number. A scorer of great goals and great scorer of goals, an insatiable trier that kept coming back to fulfil his dream of winning the World Cup, a

totem for his country and a joy to the world, a testament of longevity, of adaptability and of sustained evolutions. The most understated part is perhaps his longevity, of how he has defied the inevitable physical decline, the niggles and sores that hit him more often, the injuries that take longer to heal and easier to recur. Making adjustments should not be difficult for a man of his intelligence and intuitions. But readying his mind would be the tougher part. The 38-year-old gleans inspiration from Rafael Nadal, the retired tennis gladiator. "We're watching a Rafa Nadal series right now and I feel like him, in that sense, giving everything and enjoying what you do," he said after the last game, when he scored a hat-trick. "I felt good. I

prepared myself as best I could physically to be on a par with my teammates. My seventh World Cup? No, I don't know... Right now I'm just enjoying myself on the pitch. I like competing, being up to the task. I love playing football; it has been my passion since I was a little kid. When I am in good form, I give everything I have on the field," he added. Great players often have the ability to slow the clock on their signature moments, lending them a frictionless epic quality. Like when Messi finds the ball on his left foot, a moment of perfect stillness that also carries an implication of irresistible power. It's his enduring genius, too. The world around him has changed; the game and tactics have, he himself has, yet not his undiluted passion for the game.

DIVIDED HOUSE, UNITED TEAM

Iran win goalless game

Asian powerhouse keep sheet clean for second successive game as ageing Belgium off-target



Sandip G
New York, June 22

FOR NINETY minutes and a few more, football united a divided nation. Either side of those nervous yet exciting passages, fans rolled out and waved two variants of the national flag, the pre and post revolutionary ones; some held their fists on the pounding chest when the tune-ful national anthem Ei Iran thrummed in the arena; some booed and raised slogans. Football was once Iran's balm and beat, now it's a symbol of the conflicts that had clutched the country. The dual world of cheering and booing resumed after the goalless draw.

How could the fans, regardless of their affiliations, whether they perceive players as regime-men or eleven proud footballers, not celebrate a game they nearly won and etched a glorious moment for their country. Belgium played nearly a quarter of the game with 10 men, after Nathan Ngoy was jettisoned for pulling Mehdi Taremi's shirt when he was through on goal, from a clumsy touch by the young defender. Iran had a sumptuous goal ruled off-side, their repelling of Belgium's gilded forwards was a defensive masterclass. If only their forwards read each other's minds. Their playing patterns in the offensive half were ineloquent, often caught in a dilemma whether to shoot or pass, eventually doing neither and getting dispossessed. Maybe, the unusual practice of flying in and out of the country before and after the games was stressing them. FIFA boss Gianni Infantino had



Iranian players and staff react after their draw against Belgium. AP

promised after the first game that he would do what he could, but his promise remained just another promise. A broken promise. They had to fly to Los Angeles on Saturday and would fly out after the game.

In the background

Another narrative in the fraught US-Iran diplomacy broke out when US homeland security secretary Markwayne Mullin told Fox News on Saturday that somebody with "direct ties" with Iran's Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps attempted to enter the United States with the Iranian football team but was not allowed to board the flight on Saturday. Football was once Iran's balm and beat, now it's a symbol of the conflicts that had clutched the country. The unidentified person, reportedly, was Mehdi Taj, the federation's president, among the 15 officials of the Iran federation the US had denied visa. Iran's football federation immediately issued a rejoinder that Mullin's accusations were "fabricated with the aim of damaging the reputation of Iranian football and disrupting the national team's participation". The political dust settled when the game took over. Every nearly moment of Iran produced a collective sigh of angst—Iran's fans had clearly outnum-

bered the Belgium counterparts, whose percussion beats were drowned the guttural fury of Iranians. It was, as though, the game melted their differences, even if briefly. All of them sighed when their delightful goal was called off-side. Cruelly so. If only there was leniency for aesthetics.

Brief hope

Just before the hydration break, Iran received a free kick for a hand ball 25 yards away from Thibaut Courtois' perch. Ehsan Hajjisaifi, exuding an intimidating intensity, seemed as though he planned to curl the ball over the wall, running and lowering his body to get the whip on the ball. Instead, he coaxed a pass that was more a brush-stroke than a sledgehammer down the side of the wall. The talisman Taremi trapped the ball, turned past the stupefied Belgians and finessed a shot past Courtois. The stands exploded, flags of all shades and messages proudly draped the stands. It seemed as though it were the moment that dissolved the nation's recent travails, a blessing. Instead, it was the moment that broke the Iranian hearts. They could have been together in joy, but here they were together in tragedy. VAR checks showed that Taremi was marginally off-side (just his back-side!) He stood inconsolably, with his hands on head.

It would remain a regret for years, on a day they displayed their rearguard resilience. The five-man backline, pouncing like a defensive wave, blocked out all routes to their goal. Leandro Trossard and Alexis Sael-emaekers hit dead ends like a google map gone bonkers. Romelu Lukaku was left isolated, and whenever he got the ball, his first touch, a storied weakness of his, let him down. It was down to Kevin de Bruyne's improvisations to unlock the maze. And he only found cracks, that shook the wall. The wall neutralised, the boulder remained, the goalkeeper Alireza Beiranvand, his iron fists keeping the goalmouth shut. The fans chanted his name, and he warmly applauded them. But soon after the Iran fans spilled out of the stands, they started beating their drums, stood on the flag and shouted anti-regime chants, as several videos that went viral show. A protester, unnamed, says: "We are not here to support the team chosen by our regime. We are here to show our support for the oppressed people of Iran, not the players." Ironically, the same Iran's coach Amir Ghalenoei used when describing his players' plight, "the most oppressed team in the World Cup." But for 90 minutes, it was just one Iran, those eleven men on the field. The contest proved a tale of

With a goal and assist, Salah answers doubters in Egypt win

Diya George
New Delhi, June 22

A PHONE in one hand, a bottle in the other, and showing off his six-pack, Mohamed Salah danced in the dressing room as his teammates clapped and sang around him. Those celebrations lasted deep into the night in Vancouver as Salah led Egypt to a first-ever win at the World Cup, humbling New Zealand 3-1 in a Group G match.

The historic moment, which propelled the seven-time African champions to the top of the table, triggered wild scenes thousands of miles away in Cairo, where fan zones erupted in a sea of red and white. For a nation that had waited 92 years for this feeling, the jubilation was as much a release of pent-up tension as it was a party. Egypt's President, Abdel Fattah el-Sisi, also joined the celebrations. He wrote on X: "I congratulate the Egyptian national team and the fans of our great people on achieving the first victory in the history of Egypt's participation in the World Cup, with an honorable performance that reflects the determination and will of the people of this country."

Salah, as he so often is, was in the thick of it. After an underwhelming Premier League season by his own standards, he came into this World Cup with a lot to prove—something he had been trying to tell everyone all along. That he is still up there, still one of the best. A quiet performance against Belgium that yielded only an assist had some people writing him off already. A low-key first half against New Zealand did little to help. But he stepped up when Egypt needed him most, scoring a goal and providing an assist in a match that all but confirmed their progress to the knockout stages. The Egyptian King, as he is known to the adoring Anfield crowd, was delighted but knew the job was not done. Speaking after the game, Salah said: "It's a great achievement for all the players. It's a great win. It's a great vibe. The next game is very important." The contest proved a tale of



Mohamed Salah has either scored or assisted for Egypt in all four of his World Cup appearances. AP

The historic moment, which propelled the seven-time African champions to the top of the table, triggered wild scenes thousands of miles away in Cairo.

two halves, showcasing contrasting tactical approaches. New Zealand's strategy was direct: launch long balls, secure the initial header and attack. Meanwhile, the Pharaohs attempted a patient build-up, looking to dismantle the defence through intricate passing. Regrettably for Egypt, they lacked any real synchronisation in the first half, with players often appearing oblivious to their teammates' next moves.

Kiwis strike first

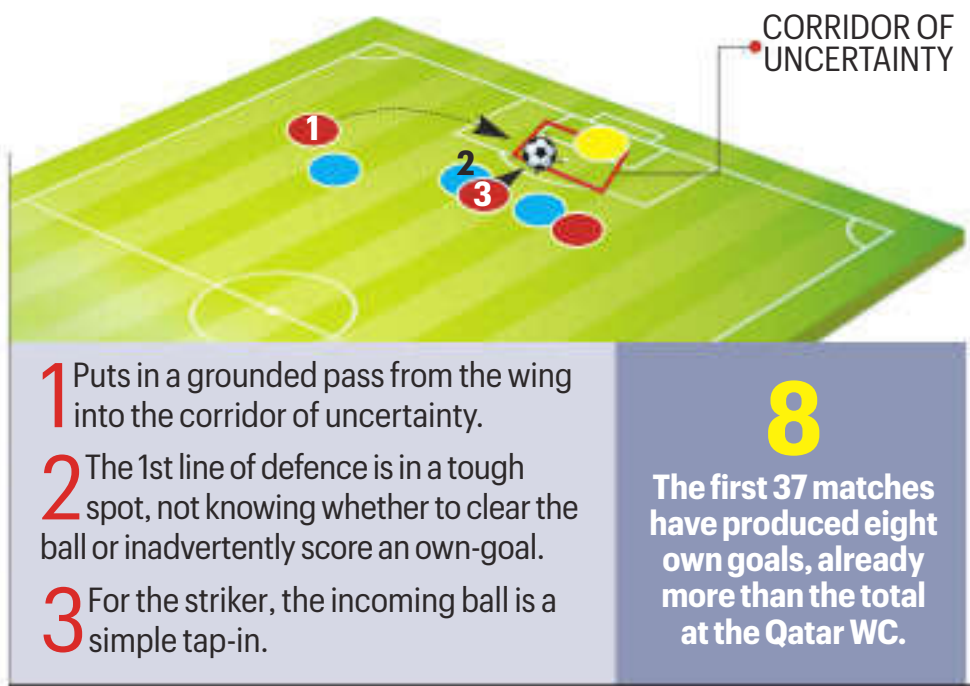
The Kiwis took the lead in the 15th minute through a set piece that Egypt seemed woefully unprepared for. Tim Payne's corner arrived in the middle of the box to a somewhat completely unmarked Finn Surman, who fired in one of the simplest goals of his career. New Zealand had taken the lead for the third time in two games. This one would not stick either. Hossam Hassan's half-time team talk seemed to have revitalised his squad, as they emerged for the second half looking like an entirely different beast. New Zealand, however, remained dangerous and nearly doubled their lead in

the 52nd minute. Marko Stamenic, operating deep on the left wing, spotted Ibrahim McCowatt's surging run into the box. His reverse header was denied by goalkeeper Mostafa Shobeir's lightning-quick reactions. Six minutes later, Egypt's persistence finally paid off. Mustafa Ziko levelled the game as New Zealand surrendered a lead for the third time this tournament. Mohamed Hany's cross found Ziko unmarked in the box, and goalkeeper Max Cromcombe may still feel he should have done more to keep out the header, which was powerful but straight at him. Just before the second hydration break, Egypt seized the advantage. The opening goalscorer turned provider, feeding the ball directly to Salah. One of Premier League's most prolific African goalscorers delivered a vintage finish, controlling the play on the flank before exchanging a sublime one-two with Ziko and bending a precise left-footed strike into the far bottom corner. By the 80th minute, New Zealand looked like they were running on fumes under the Vancouver sun. Egypt finished the job with 10 minutes of normal time remaining. This time, it was the substitute Trezeguet, meeting Salah's corner near the edge of the six-yard area with perfect timing and powering a bullet header past Cromcombe, leaving the goalkeeper no chance and extinguishing any hopes of a late comeback. Salah joined Ziko in recording both a goal and an assist on the night.

Morocco look to finish top of group

Atlanta: Morocco will be chasing not only victory but also goals against already-eliminated Haiti in Atlanta on Wednesday, eager to finish top of their World Cup group ahead of Brazil. It would be a statement success for the North Africans, who have four points from their opening two Group C games and made an immediate impression when they had Brazil on the back foot in their drawn first match at the tournament. Morocco, who then beat Scotland in Boston, have picked up where they left off from the last World Cup, where they became the first African and Arab country to reach the semis. Brazil will be playing Scotland at the same time in Miami, and if both the five-time world champions and Morocco win their last group games, then top place in Group C will be decided on goal difference. REUTERS

● CREATING CHAOS



winger reaches the byline and fires a low ball across goal, defenders have only a split second to react. Any touch can send the ball into the net. Spain's opener against Saudi Arabia was a per-

fect example. Oyarzabal's delivery travelled through the most dangerous area in front of goal, and Yamal arrived unnoticed at the back post. The United States benefited



Lamine Yamal celebrates after scoring Spain's opener. AP

from the same pattern against Australia. Folarin Balogun drilled a low cross across goal and defender Cameron Burgess, racing back towards his own net, could only divert it

into the goal. Belgium benefited from an own-goal in the 1-1 draw with Egypt. This was another variation. Thomas Meunier fired a low ball towards Romelu Lukaku. The striker missed it, but the pressure forced Egypt's Mohamed Hany into a desperate clearance that ricocheted into his own net. Ghana's winner against Panama followed a similar trend. Deep into the stoppage time, Brandon Thomas-Asante drove the ball down the left flank and rolled a pass toward the middle, which Caleb Yirenkyi tapped into the back of the net.

Tricky corridor

Goalkeepers are unsure whether to come for the ball. Defenders are terrified of missing it or turning it into their own net. Attackers, meanwhile, only need a touch. That is why

so many chances at this World Cup have come from balls driven across goal rather than from traditional aerial crosses. Own goals rising The trend also helps explain the surge in own goals. The first 37 matches produced eight own goals, already more than the total at Qatar 2022. Own goals are often dismissed as bad luck. Most are not. They are usually the result of pressure. A defender sprinting towards his own goal, while trying to deal with a low cross has almost no time to adjust. One awkward touch is enough. The increase in own goals is not a separate story. It is evidence of the same trend. At this World Cup, the most dangerous pass is often not the spectacular one. It is the simplest: a hard, low ball flashed across the six-yard box.

Owen backs Ronaldo: ‘He will be there for big moments’

Express News Service
New Delhi, June 22

CRISTIANO RONALDO’S in-different start to his record sixth World Cup appearance last week against DR Congo has sharpened the criticism of the waning abilities of the Portugal superstar.

Ronaldo endured a forgettable night, with just three shots to show, after playing full 90 minutes in a tame 1-1 draw against Congo in their Group K opener. The 41-year-old soon became the face of criticism, with pundits and former footballers slamming Ronaldo’s contribution, besides being obsessed with the idea of hunting for goals from the box.

Ronaldo’s lacklustre performance was in sharp contrast to his long-time rival Lionel Messi’s sparkling hat-trick for Argentina. While their recent outings have widened the gulf between the duo, former Ballon d’Or winner Michael Owen has backed Ronaldo to turn around his poor form around.

Portugal next play Uzbekistan in Houston on Tuesday, and Owen said he expected the response from the record international goal-scorer to appear in the form of a hat-trick.

“It did not help Cristiano Ronaldo that Lionel Messi scored a hat-trick the night before Portugal played, but I’m not having the criticism of him,” Owen wrote in his *Daily-Mail* column. “Hasn’t he always played like this? But how many times has this happened and he’s shut everyone up in the next game? If you’re picking Ronaldo then you have to accept what he is there for – and I wouldn’t be surprised if he responds with a hat-trick of his own against Uzbekistan,” the former Manchester United and Real Madrid striker said.

Owen also brushed aside critics for targetting Ronaldo’s one-dimensional style, insisting that he has remained a box-to-box poacher for a considerable period now.

“But hasn’t he always played like this, to a degree? He has never been a player, especially in recent years, who involves himself in the game. He will be there for the big moments, though. If he’s not scoring, it’s too easy to blame Ronaldo. At 41, he is going to be questioned.”



Cristiano Ronaldo during training ahead of Tuesday’s match against Uzbekistan. AP



Row, Norway, Row

Norwegian fans perform the viral Viking Row during their team’s match against Iraq in Boston last week. AP

Viking invasion: Norway supporters riding a wave

Two neighbours give country’s first appearance in 28 years its identity, one song at a time

Amit Kamath
Mumbai, June 22

FOR ABOUT an hour on Sunday night, Times Square became a fjord. Thousands of Norwegian football fans, rocking their bright red jerseys, had invaded midtown Manhattan. In a part of New York that is among the most frequented by tourists, the Norwegians congregated on the iconic Red Steps, waited for a cue on the drums from a man in a Viking hat, and then, in unison, let out a guttural chant of ‘ro’ (pronounced ruuh) while mimicking a rower’s motion. In the middle of the celebration, someone blasted a Norwegian chartbuster called Vikingblod, and fans joined in.

After Boston, the Viking Row and Vikingblod had come to New York. It was a little slice of the party that the Norwegian fans are going to bring to the New York/New Jersey Stadium when Norway takes on Senegal. The country is playing in its first FIFA World Cup in 28 years, and the fans have pulled out all stops, including invoking their proud Viking history, to make it unforgettable.

At their first pitstop in Boston, the Norwegians went viral after a clip showed some fans rowing up while sitting on an escalator at Boston’s South Station. Since then, the Viking

Row has been unmissable wherever the Norwegian team’s gone. Their fans did it on the streets of Boston and in cafes, where the party-loving Scotland fans too joined in.

The Norwegian Prime Minister, on a short visit to the USA, also joined in at an event. In New York, before the Times Square invasion, the sounds of ruuh also echoed on the Hudson River when a group of Norwegian fans got on a ferry, sat on the hull and started rowing. Then, they did it while seated on the floor of a metro as well.

Back home in Norway, too, the celebration and the Vikingblod song have caught the country’s imagination. Vikingblod rose to become the no 1 song on Spotify last week. Members of Norway’s parliament, the Stortinget, have paused a session to do the Viking Row. Oslo Airport created a campaign using a group to do it at the lufthavn. Nurses have gone viral for doing it in hospitals while sitting on stretchers. A non-profit body to help those with spinal cord injuries even got people in wheelchairs to line up in a row and do it.

“It’s become part of the Norwegian football team’s identity,” Ole Frøystad, the creator of the Viking Row, told *The Indian Express*. “We had no idea a chant could bring people together like this. When we see fans from other teams sitting and rowing with us, it shows amazing unity. It’s nice to see fun and peace between countries. That’s the best thing that could have ever happened.”

Frøystad, who goes by the moniker of Mr Row Row, is one of the faces of Oljeberget, the biggest supporters club for Nor-



“We had no idea a chant could bring people together like this. When we see fans from other teams sitting and rowing with us, it shows amazing unity.”
OLE FRØYSTAD,
CREATOR OF VIKING ROW

way football team, which has brought an estimated 10,000 fans to the US. He’s also the man with the long locks sporting a Viking hat and giving the Norwegian fans a cue to start rowing. The Viking Row made its debut in a Norway-Switzerland friendly, and was then used in a game against Sweden, where it gained some popularity online. But it’s at the World Cup that it’s gone viral.

Along the way, serendipity played a role. One of Frøystad’s neighbours, Jonas Thommasen, was also working on a song that could be an anthem for fans of the national team. Frøystad and Thommasen spent hours discussing the celebration and the song, even taking the discussions with them on a vacation to Tenerife.

Eventually, Thommasen came up with a song that honoured their Viking heritage and

had multiple references to Norse explorer Leif Erikson, who was the first European to land on continental America, about 500 years before Christopher Columbus.

“I started writing the song after Norway beat Italy. I had this idea that people throughout the world don’t really know about the Norwegian Viking who discovered America,” Thommasen said. “The idea for the song was that now the Norwegian Vikings are coming back to America, to take back the continent that they discovered 400 years before Columbus. Since we are going across the Atlantic as the Vikings did back in the days with their Viking ships, I thought, the rowing would be a fit.”

Norway currently has two songs, one by broadcaster NRK called *Sammen for Norge* (Together for Norway). Thommasen says that while *Sammen for Norge* is more of a ballad, *Vikingblod* is a rock song. There is also the iconic anthem *Alt for Norge* (All for Norway) that was released when Norway last played at a World Cup, which is making a comeback.

“Vikingblod is catchy, it can be sung in the stadium, and it feels very unifying. It’s like everybody in a boat together, you have to row with timing. You need power, stability, and cooperation. I felt it was a good symbol for what we are trying to achieve in the World Cup.”

The whole idea behind both efforts, Frøystad pointed out, was to put the country of five million on the map. The supporters have already set the stage. Now, it’s time for Erling Haaland & Co to grab an oar and start rowing.

Cape Verde, nation of 525,000, inches closer to knockouts

Sayak Dutta
Kolkata, June 22

ON OCTOBER 13 last year, the Cape Verde government declared a half-day holiday so the nation could watch their team play Eswatini. Cape Verde won 3-0. They haven’t stopped since. Jose Maria Silva, the national director of state protocol, said qualification for this World Cup was the third defining moment in Cape Verde’s history, after Independence Day and the first multiparty elections of 1991. On Sunday in Miami, they held Uruguay, two-time world champions, to a 2-2 draw.

They have not lost a match at this World Cup. They may not be finished.

This is a team built from scattered people. Kevin Pina grew up in Praia before his family left for Brockton, Massachusetts, a kid in a diaspora, playing football where he could find it, until a former Cape Verde captain named Carlos Morais spotted him on the street and convinced his father to send him back. Portuguese clubs Casa Pia and Benfica both rejected him. He found his way to Krasnodar in Russia, where in 2024-25 he won the league.

Centre-back Roberto Lopes had a different route entirely. Born in Dublin to an Irish mother and a Cape Verdean father, he was playing for Shamrock Rovers and working in finance when a LinkedIn message arrived in 2018,



Cape Verde’s Helio Varela (top) celebrates scoring his side’s second goal in the 2-2 draw against Uruguay in Miami on Sunday. AP

written in Portuguese, a language he didn’t speak. He assumed it was spam.

Nine months later a follow-up came in English. He said yes immediately. The team’s motto is ten islands, one nation, one dream. The squad is that motto made flesh.

Rodrigo Bentancur fouled Telmo Arcanjo just outside the box in the 21st minute and collected a yellow card. Pina placed the ball 34 yards from goal, found a gap in Uruguay’s wall and drove it into the bottom corner. The Uruguay defence stood still. Pina ran, eyes welling, teammates piling on. It was only the second direct free kick scored at this entire World Cup.

Uruguay went ahead through Agustin Canobbio six minutes into first-half injury time, with Luis Suarez watch-

ing from the stands. It looked decisive. It wasn’t. Helio Varela came off the bench, seconds after coming on, intercepted a loose pass from Mathias Olivera and slotted past Fernando Muslera, stranded off his line. Varela is 24, born in Almada, plays for Maccabi Tel Aviv. He had never scored for Cape Verde before.

“I had dreamed of this, but I never imagined it would happen this way,” he said. “Scoring my first goal for the national team on my World Cup debut is incredible. I have no words.”

This is a country of 525,000 people. When the fixtures were announced in December, few gave them a point.

They play Saudi Arabia next. Win that, and they are in the knockout rounds.

Why Japan forwards are told to have ‘ego’, like anime hero

Shivani Naik
Pune, June 22

IN A goal-glut of a 4-0 win against Tunisia, Japanese striker Ayase Ueda hammered two. It was the most Japan had ever scored at a World Cup.

For his first, Ueda cheekily sent a drive through the legs of defender Montassar Talbi from the edge of the box. Later, he lobbed a header over a much taller defender after meeting Kaishu Sano’s flick. His backheel pass also sparked Junya Ito’s solo run for Japan’s third.

Seen as a ruthless No. 9 – physical, aggressive in the air and clinical in his finishing – Ueda is the advent of what the Japanese call the ‘egoists’.

Creator of the hit anime series Blue Lock, Muneyuki Kaneshiro said last month: “We are waiting for serious egoists who aim to win the World Cup.” His illustrator, Yusuke Nomura, went a step further, saying: “We look forward to applications from all ego-driven people who believe, ‘I am the world’s best striker!’”

The idea was simple: Japan needed strikers obsessed with scoring and unafraid of putting themselves first.

The country that gave the



Ayase Ueda (L) epitomises the team’s new thinking. AP

world Captain Tsubasa was rethinking whether Japanese minds needed to be reprogrammed to create a striker who doesn’t apologise for taking a shot. Some observers link it to the Japanese concept of waa – social harmony and teamwork. Blue Lock challenges that ethos through protagonist Yoichi Isagi, who learns to become ruthless in front of goal and develop what the series calls a striker’s ego.

Since 2024, the Japan Football Association has collaborated with Blue Lock through “Future Camp”, a programme that combines scouting Japanese-heritage players abroad with the manga’s theme of ‘individual awakening.’ “The egoists we imagined may also exist in this real world. No, I am sure

they do!” Nomura said at the programme’s launch.

Blue Lock’s plot begins at a real inflection point in Japanese football history: the 3-2 defeat to Belgium at the 2018 World Cup. *Kodansha Publishing USA* describes the story: “Japan’s team struggles to regroup, but what’s missing? An absolute Ace Striker, who can guide them to the win. The Japan Football Union is hell-bent on creating a striker who hungers for goals and thirsts for victory, and who can be the decisive instrument in turning around a losing match...”

The Belgium defeat has been dissected repeatedly, most notably in *NHK’s* documentary *14 Seconds of Rostov*. Made on a budget of 500,000 euros, it interviewed more than 50 people, including coach Akira Nishino, captain Makoto Hasebe, and Belgian stars Thibaut Courtois, Romelu Lukaku and Kevin De Bruyne.

It revisited every detail of the collapse, asking whether Japan lacked belief, stamina or concentration in the decisive moments.

After reflecting through a documentary, came manifesting for an Ace Striker, through Manga.

{ T 2 0 W O R L D C U P }

How India can qualify for semis after losing to South Africa

Express News Service
Mumbai, June 22

INDIA’S SIX-WICKET loss to South Africa has kept Group A wide open, with three contenders level on four points. In a tightly packed table, net run rate is now expected to determine which teams progress to the semifinals.

The group has essentially become a four-way contest where margins of victory are just as crucial as winning itself. Here are the matches left for all teams in the race:

INDIA
Matches left: vs Bangladesh, vs Australia
Points: 4
NR: +2.511

India’s position is still underpinned by their dominant early wins over Pakistan and the Netherlands, which created a strong cushion in net run rate. That buffer continues to keep them ahead of the other contenders despite the setback against South Africa.

If India can win both their remaining games, the superior

If India can win both their remaining games, the superior net run rate could still help them qualify for semis

net run rate could still help them qualify for the semifinal. A loss in either game would make the path difficult.

SOUTH AFRICA
Matches left: vs Netherlands, vs Bangladesh
Points: 4
NR: -0.546

South Africa’s campaign began on a difficult note with a defeat to Australia, which immediately left them behind the eight ball on net run rate.

They responded with a close win over Pakistan before producing a strong performance to beat India and stay alive in the race.

However, their negative net run rate still puts them on the back foot. To push ahead in the race, South Africa may need

victories combined with big margins in their remaining games.

BANGLADESH
Matches left: vs India, vs South Africa
Points: 4
NR: -0.641

Bangladesh opened with a win over the Netherlands but were heavily impacted by their nine-wicket loss to Australia, which significantly dragged down their net run rate. A win over Pakistan has kept them in contention, but their position remains the most precarious among the three teams.

Their remaining fixtures against India and South Africa leave little room for error. Bangladesh will likely need not just wins, but a strong swing in net run rate to stay in the semifinal race. Australia remain the most secure side in the group, with three wins from three matches and a net run rate of +4.391, placing them in a commanding position.

Pakistan and the Netherlands have been eliminated from semifinal contention.

Shankar Narayan
Mumbai, June 22

INDIA MAY have won two of their first three matches at the Women’s T20 World Cup and remain in contention for a semi-final berth, but their six-wicket defeat to South Africa at Manchester exposed a concern that has quietly followed them through the tournament – the inability of the middle-order to build on the platform laid by the top-order.

At the centre of that conversation is captain Harmanpreet Kaur. Her scores of 36 off 35 balls against Pakistan and 24 off 22 against South Africa look respectable on paper, but a closer look tells a different story.

In both matches, India lost early wickets and needed someone experienced to rebuild the innings before launching at the death.

Harmanpreet did the rebuilding, but could not manage the acceleration towards the later overs which the innings needed.

Against Pakistan, her strike rate was just above 102 despite facing enough deliveries to dictate the innings. She hit four boundaries but also played 13

dot balls, allowing Pakistan’s spinners to build pressure through the middle overs before holing out while trying to force the pace.

The pattern repeated against South Africa. Harmanpreet made 24 from 22 deliveries with five dot balls. Once she settled in, the innings never shifted gears. There were singles; gentle pushes into the gaps and strike rotation, but very little intent to attack either the seamers or the spinners.

It is this middle phase that has begun to be a cause of concern. In modern T20 cricket, rebuilding is only half the job.

The batter who absorbs pressure is also expected to cash in once set. Harmanpreet had reached that point in both innings but struggled to find the gears required to push India to a big score.

Falling numbers

The numbers also suggest this is not simply a two-match blip. Since 2023, Harmanpreet has scored 909 runs in 42 innings in the middle overs at a strike rate of 116.24, which is noticeably lower than the likes of Amelia Kerr (125.55) and Heather Knight (120.55).



Harmanpreet Kaur hasn’t managed to accelerate the scoring rate when needed. AP

She has also chewed up 244 dot balls, more than Kerr (207) and Knight (204), thereby leaving India with more work to do at the death. Her own teammate, Jemimah Rodrigues, has struck at 132.29 in the same number of innings and has consumed only 158 dot deliveries.

Even her own career graph points towards a gradual shift. After striking at over 130 in 2021, Harmanpreet has largely hovered between 109 and 126 in recent seasons.

In 2026, she scored 265 runs at a strike rate of 126.2. Respect-

able but not quite matching the explosive standards expected from India’s premier middle-order batter.

The statistics only reinforce what has been visible during this World Cup. Harmanpreet is spending enough time at the crease to influence matches, but is not consistently turning starts into innings that take the game away from the opposition.

Pressure on others

The concern is not that Harmanpreet has failed. It is that she has not imposed herself after doing the difficult part of surviving. That has created an increasing burden on India’s lower middle-order, particularly Richa Ghosh.

Against Pakistan, Richa produced the late flourish that Harmanpreet could not, helping India finish with a match-winning total.

Against South Africa, however, a far stronger bowling attack prevented a repeat. Without that final assault, India were restricted to 158, a total that proved inadequate in the end. After coming out to bat at number four against Pakistan, Harmanpreet walked out to bat

at number five on Sunday.

Former India captain Mithali Raj believed that Harmanpreet should consider coming one position higher and have Rodrigues bat at number five.

“We haven’t seen Harmanpreet bat that late at number five very often, so perhaps she can come in at number four and Jemimah at number five. Jemimah has played there before and could be better suited to facing spin later in the innings,” she told *JioStar*.

India still have two must-win matches against Bangladesh and Australia. Qualification remains in their hands, but the margin for error has reduced considerably.

The batting order may not need wholesale changes, but India do need Harmanpreet to trust her range once she is set. They need her to take on the bowling, force captains to spread the field and turn starts into match-defining innings.

Because if that acceleration does not return over the next few days, India may once again find themselves leaving another World Cup wondering what might have been.

With stats inputs from Lalith Kalidas